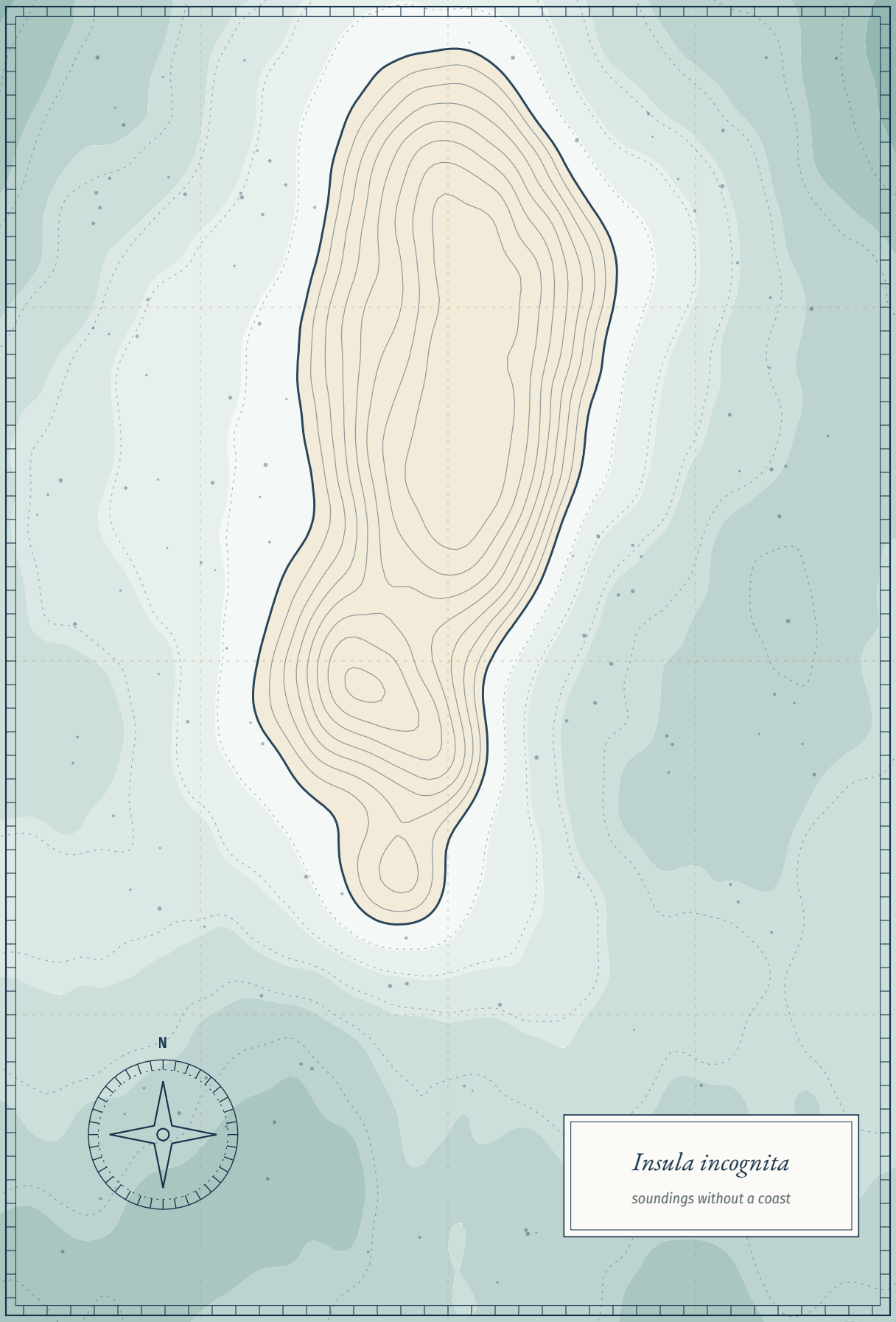


The God of Jacob,
Not of the Philosophers

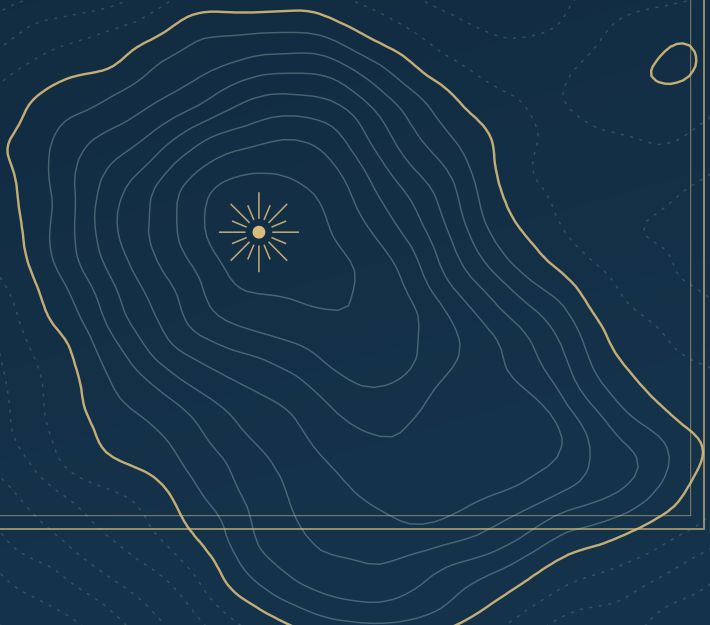

N
Insula incognita
soundings without a coast

The God of Jacob, Not of the Philosophers

Lost as Serial Pascaliad

Constancy, Custody, and Anamnesis in the Three Orders

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair





Dieu d'Abraham, Dieu d'Isaac, Dieu de Jacob,
non des philosophes et des savants.

God of Abraham, God of Isaac, God of Jacob,
not of the philosophers and of the learned.

Blaise Pascal, *Mémorial*, 23 November 1654

Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Lost* (ABC, 2004–2010; created by Jeffrey Lieber, J. J. Abrams, and Damon Lindelof; showrun by Lindelof and Carlton Cuse across six seasons and 121 episodes) is best understood neither as a puzzle-narrative whose meaning resides in solved enigmas nor as a character melodrama in mythological costume, but as a *serial Pascaliad*: a sustained narrative realization of Blaise Pascal's anthropology of the lost (*égaré*) human being. Three Pascalian coordinates organize the reading. First, the series literalizes fragment L198/B693 of the *Pensées*, in which a man carried asleep to a "desert and terrifying island" wakes without knowing where he is, who placed him there, what he has come to do, or what he will become in dying—a sentence whose clauses map, with nearly diagrammatic exactness, onto the master questions the series poses and, in its final season, answers. Second, the series assembles a dramatis personae named for the "philosophers and savants" of modernity (Locke, Hume, Rousseau, Burke, Bentham, Bakunin, Faraday, Hawking, Minkowski, C. S. Lewis) and subordinates them to a numinous center named Jacob, thereby restaging the antithesis of Pascal's *Mémorial*: "Dieu de Jacob, non des philosophes et des savants." Third, the six-season arc traverses Pascal's three incommensurable orders—of bodies, of minds, of charity (L308/B793)—moving from survival and somatic healing, through an epistemic labyrinth of stations, equations, and time travel, to a terminal register of love and recognition.

Within this architecture the dissertation identifies a *perditology*—a systematic thought of lostness—built on three conceptual innovations. *Constancy* names an anthropology in which personal identity is neither substance (Locke), nor bundle (Hume), nor self-positing will, but fidelity maintained across temporal discontinuity and received from another; its proof-text is "The Constant" (4.05), read through Hume's denial of any impression "constant and invariable," Levinas's account of time as relation to the Other, and Ricoeur's ipse-identity of the kept promise. *Custody* names a political theology in which the island's sovereign is reconceived as a keeper—the *shomer* of Genesis 2:15 and 4:9, the *katechon* of 2 Thessalonians 2—so that the series' succession of regimes (survivor polity, DHARMA technocracy, the Others' theocracy, Widmore's capital, Jacob's providential rule) culminates in a custodial reign that, like Prospero, abjures its "rough magic." *Anamnesis* names an eschatology in which the end is neither apocalypse nor escape but collective recollection: the flash-sideways is read against Plato's Myth of Er, Dante's paired rivers Lethe and Eunoë, the *Bardo Thödol*, Swedenborg's

world of spirits, Proust's *temps retrouvé*, and Walter Benjamin's principle that nothing which has ever happened is to be given up as lost.

Methodologically, the study combines onomastic philology, comparative mythography (Hebrew Bible, Egyptian funerary religion, Zurvanite Zoroastrianism, Gnostic and Manichaean cosmology, Indic and Buddhist soteriology), comparative literature (from Homer to Borges, Bioy Casares, Flann O'Brien, John Fowles, and Stephen King), narratology (Augustine, Genette, Barthes, Kermode, Ricoeur, Frye, Bakhtin), political theology (Schmitt, Foucault, Agamben), and reception theory (Blumenberg, Jonas, Voegelin), while distinguishing rigorously between attested sources and structural analogues. Its principal findings are: that the series' philosopher-names constitute an ironic prosopopoeia of the Enlightenment (the fictional Locke is precisely the "enthusiast" the historical Locke condemned, and of the characters named for philosophers in the strict sense only Hume survives the island); that the Man in Black condenses Milton's Satan, who rises "involv'd in rising Mist" from an underground river beside the Tree of Life before possessing a body not his own; that Jacob's providence is Molinist, his election Pauline, and his failure Jobian; and that the finale's polarized reception is the predictable consequence of what Pascal called the infinite distance between orders—an audience schooled in the order of minds confronting a resolution in the order of charity. A final chapter subjects the perditology to postcolonial, feminist, and disability critique, arguing that the series' universalist charity is articulated through specific erasures, above all of the Pacific in whose waters its "Oceanic" island is set.

Contents

Abstract 5

Epigraphs, Corpus, and Protocols of Attribution 9

Introduction: *Sans Lumière* 13
The Pascalian Premise

Part I

Archives

1 The Onomastic Archive 23
Philosophers, Savants, and the Prosopopoeia of Modernity

2 Scriptures of the Island 31
The Strata of the Sacred

3 The Four Archipelagoes 43
Castaway, Utopian, Illusionist, and Afterlife Fictions

Part II

Axes

4 The Hatch and the Wager 67
Faith, Reason, and Discernment

5 Chronosophy 81
Augustine, Molina, Novikov; the Constant against the Variable

6 Constancy 93
From Tabula Rasa to Self-Constancy

7 Custody 105
Sovereignty, Pastorate, Panopticon, Katechon

8 The Twins and the Light 117
Theodicy, Dualism, and the Chthonic Good

9 Anamnesis 127
The Flash-Sideways as Eschatology of Recollection

Part III

Receptions and Limits

10 The Poetics of the Hatch 141
Seriality, Enigma, Achrony

11 Shipwreck with Spectators 153
Gnosis, Charity, and the Finale's Disproportion of Orders

12 The Limits of the Island 161
Terra Nullius, the Maternal Vessel, and the Ensemble

Conclusion: Nothing Is Lost 171

Bibliography 175

Keywords 182

Figures and plates

Figure 1 Pascal's three orders across the six seasons 16
Figure 2 The namesakes and their characters 30
Figure 3 The four archipelagoes and their refused exits 46
Figure 4 The Swan as wager 70
Figure 5 Constancy, fidelity, and the constants 99
Figure 6 The nine regimes of the island 107
Figure 7 A household of origins 120
Figure 8 The awakenings of the sideways 132
Figure 9 Frye's modes and the romance quest 148
Figure 10 The spectator's shore 154
Figure 11 The eye that opens and the eye that closes 171
Plate I The strata of the sacred 22
Plate II The six times of the series 66
Plate III A sea of islands 140

Epigraphs, Corpus, and Protocols of Attribution

En voyant l'aveuglement et la misère de l'homme, en regardant tout l'univers muet, et l'homme sans lumière, abandonné à lui-même, et comme égaré dans ce recoin de l'univers, sans savoir qui l'y a mis, ce qu'il y est venu faire, ce qu'il deviendra en mourant, incapable de toute connaissance, j'entre en effroi comme un homme qu'on aurait porté endormi dans une île déserte et effroyable, et qui s'éveillerait sans connaître où il est, et sans moyen d'en sortir.

— Blaise Pascal, *Pensées*, L198/B693

In with the River sunk, and with it rose / Satan involv'd in rising Mist, then sought / Where to lie hid.

— John Milton, *Paradise Lost* IX.74–76

...the king shall live without an heir, if that which is lost be not found.

— William Shakespeare, *The Winter's Tale* III.ii

...there is no impression constant and invariable.

— David Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature* 1.4.6

Translation of the Pascalian epigraph

"When I see the blindness and the wretchedness of man, when I survey the whole mute universe, and man without light, abandoned to himself and as though lost in this corner of the universe, not knowing who has put him there, what he has come to do, what will become of him in dying, incapable of all knowledge, I fall into terror, like a man carried asleep to a desert and terrifying island, who wakes without knowing where he is and without any means of escape." Unless otherwise indicated, all translations from French, Latin, German, and Greek are the author's.

Corpus

The primary corpus comprises the 121 broadcast episodes of *Lost* (ABC, 22 September 2004 – 23 May 2010), cited by season and episode number with title, e.g. "The Constant" (4.05); multi-part installments are cited by range, e.g. "The Incident" (5.16–5.17). A secondary, *paracanonical* stratum is admitted where it clarifies but never where it contradicts broadcast canon: the tie-in novel *Bad Twin* (2006), attributed to the fictional passenger Gary Troup; the alternate-reality games *The Lost Experience* (2006) and *Find 815* (2008); the mobisodes *Missing Pieces* (2007–2008); and the epilogue "The New Man in Charge" (2010), released with the sixth-season home-video set. Dialogue is paraphrased except for brief, iconic formulae—many of which the series itself elevated into episode titles ("Live Together, Die Alone," "Whatever Happened, Happened").

Authorship

"Created by" credit rests with Lieber (whose earlier script, *Nowhere*, secured him credit through Writers Guild arbitration), Abrams, and Lindelof; the concept originated with ABC executive Lloyd Braun's request for a hybrid of *Cast Away* and *Survivor*. Abrams's direct involvement diminished after the first season, and the series' long arc was governed by Lindelof and Cuse with a rotating writers' room. Following Foucault's analysis of the author-function, "the series" is treated here as a collective enunciative subject; where intention is attributed to named individuals, it rests on their public statements.

Three grades of attribution

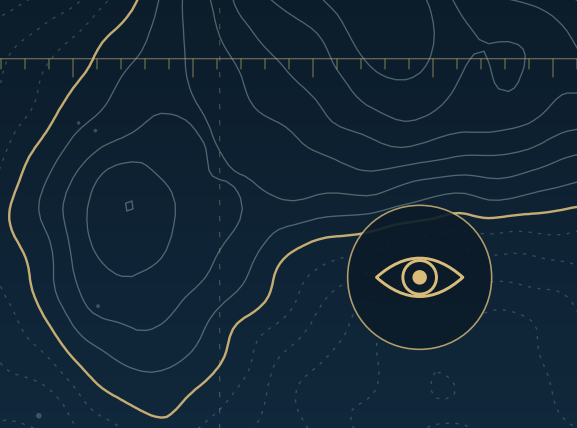
Because a work this allusive invites unlimited projection, every comparison in this study belongs to one of three grades. **Grade A (attested)**: a source the series itself cites on screen (a book in a character's hands, a station named for a text, an episode title) or that its makers publicly acknowledged. **Grade B (onomastic)**: a name whose referent is unmistakable but whose

intended function is undocumented (Desmond David Hume; Charlotte Staples Lewis). **Grade C (analogical)**: a structural homology asserted by the critic, with no claim of influence (Zurvanite twinship; Dante's Eunoë). The dissertation's original thesis is built chiefly from Grade C relations, but it is disciplined by Grades A and B: an analogy is admitted only where it illuminates a feature the attested archive already foregrounds. The grade is signaled in the prose wherever ambiguity might arise. The makers described their own allusions in these terms. Lindelof told *Time* in April 2010 that naming a character after a philosopher or placing a book on screen was a way of acknowledging something that had influenced the writers and was informing the series, and he gave Stephen King as his example: the producers acknowledged King by having Juliet name him as a favorite writer at her book club's discussion of *Carrie*. Carlton Cuse had told critics in January 2007 that *The Stand* had been, in many ways, the model for the show. Grade A therefore rests not only on what appears on screen but on the makers' own account of why it appears there.

Introduction

Sans Lumière

The Pascalian Premise



0.1

An eye opens on an island

Lost begins with an eye. In the first shot of the pilot (1.01), an extreme close-up shows Jack Shephard's eye snapping open; he lies supine in a bamboo grove, a dog runs past, and only then does the camera discover the burning fuselage on the beach. The series ends with the same eye. In the final shot of "The End" (6.17–6.18), Jack lies in the same grove, the same dog settles beside him, an aircraft crosses the sky, and the eye closes. Between these two images lie six seasons, 121 episodes, and one of the most elaborate mythological constructions in the history of broadcast narrative. The bracket is not ornamental symmetry. It is the visible form of a question posed, with uncanny literalness, by Blaise Pascal in the 1650s.

Fragment L198/B693 of the *Pensées*, quoted as this study's first epigraph, describes the human condition through a single extended simile: man is like someone carried asleep to a desert and terrifying island who wakes without knowing where he is and without any means of escape. The comparison is not incidental to Pascal's apologetics; it is the emotional premise from which the wager, the analysis of *divertissement*, and the doctrine of the three orders all proceed. What has gone unremarked in the critical literature is that *Lost* reproduces not only the simile's scene but the grammar of its interrogations, clause by clause. The correspondence is set out below.

Table 1 *The clauses of L198 and their correlates in Lost*

Clause of L198	Translation	Correlate in *Lost*	Principal loci
l'homme sans lumière	man without light	The Light at the Heart of the Island, of which every human carries a portion and covets more; its extinction when the stone is removed	"Across the Sea" (6.15); "The End" (6.17–6.18)
abandonné à lui-même	abandoned to himself	The founding maxim that those who cannot live together will die alone	"White Rabbit" (1.05); "Live Together, Die Alone" (2.23–2.24)
comme égaré dans ce recoin de l'univers	as though lost in this corner of the universe	The title; an island that cannot be found except by calculation, that moves, and that is "lost" to the world's maps	"316" (5.06); "There's No Place Like Home" (4.12–4.14)
sans savoir qui l'y a mis	not knowing who put him there	Jacob's touches and his claim to have brought the candidates	"The Incident" (5.16–5.17); "What They Died For" (6.16)
ce qu'il y est venu faire	what he has come to do	Candidacy, vocation, the protector's office	"Lighthouse" (6.05); "What They Died For" (6.16)
ce qu'il deviendra en mourant	what will become of him in dying	The flash-sideways revealed as a shared afterlife	"LA X" (6.01–6.02) through "The End"
incapable de toute connaissance	incapable of all knowledge	The mysteries, the withheld answers, the finale's refusal of total explanation	passim; Chapters 10–11
porté endormi… et qui s'éveillerait sans connaître où il est	carried asleep… waking without knowing where	The pilot's opening shot	"Pilot" (1.01)
sans moyen d'en sortir	without means of escape	The raft, the freighter, the island that will not release its people, the Man in Black's longing to leave	"Exodus" (1.23–1.25); seasons 4–6

The fragment continues beyond the epigraph in a direction no less pertinent. Pascal observes others around him "of a like nature," asks whether they are better informed, and finds they are not; these *misérables égarés*—these wretched lost ones—then attach themselves to whatever pleasing objects lie at hand, while he alone refuses such attachment and searches instead for some *marque* that God may have left of himself. Here, in miniature, is the bifurcation of the castaway community. One party diverts itself: Hurley builds a golf course among the wreckage ("Solitary," 1.09), Sawyer hoards salvage and paperbacks. The other searches for signs: Locke digs at a buried hatch, Rousseau maps the jungle, and the series' viewers, in their millions, begin to read the island's hieroglyphs, numbers, and station logos as marks left by an author who will not show his face.

0.2

The *Mémorial* and the philosophers

On the night of 23 November 1654, Pascal underwent the conversion he recorded on a slip of parchment and sewed into the lining of his coat, where it was found after his death. The *Mémorial* opens with a single word—*FEU*, fire—and continues: "Dieu d'Abraham, Dieu d'Isaac, Dieu de Jacob, non des philosophes et des savants." The antithesis could serve as the casting principle of *Lost*. The island is populated by figures bearing the names of modernity's philosophers and savants—John Locke, Danielle Rousseau, Desmond David Hume, Juliet Burke, Mikhail Bakunin, Daniel Faraday, Eloise Hawking, George Minkowski, Charlotte Staples Lewis, and Locke's alias Jeremy Bentham—while its sacred center, invisible for five seasons, bears the name of the patriarch. Fire belongs to that center: Jacob's body is burned, his ashes are gathered, and the protective circles drawn around his dwelling are circles of ash. The brainwashing film shown in Room 23 ("Not in Portland," 3.07) flashes the sentence that God loves its viewer as He loved Jacob—an unmistakable citation of Malachi 1:2 and its Pauline reprise in Romans 9:13, the classical *locus* of the doctrine of election. The series thus stages, across six years, the contest Pascal's parchment declares already decided: the philosophers are named, observed, tested, and in most cases killed; the God of Jacob is the one who remains.

The Pascalian resonance has not escaped readers entirely. The first major academic collection on the series, Sharon Kaye's *Lost and Philosophy*, took as its subtitle *The Island Has Its Reasons*, an evident inflection of Pascal's most famous sentence: *le cœur a ses raisons que la raison ne connaît point* (L423/B277). Yet the allusion remained a title. No study has observed that the series' cosmology is organized around a place explicitly called the Heart of the Island, that the reasons of this heart are precisely those which the reason of its men of science cannot know, or that Pascal's entire apologetic structure provides the most economical account of the series' architecture. This dissertation proposes that account.

0.3

The three orders

In L308/B793 Pascal distinguishes three orders of reality, each infinitely removed from the next: *corps*, *esprits*, and *charité*. "La distance infinie des corps aux esprits figure la distance infiniment plus infinie des esprits à la charité, car elle est surnaturelle." The fragment closes with two impossibilities: from all bodies together one cannot produce the least thought, and *de tous les corps et esprits, on n'en saurait tirer un mouvement de vraie charité*—from all bodies and minds together one could not draw a single movement of true charity, for that is of another order, supernatural.

Lost traverses these orders in sequence, not exclusively but by dominant register. Its first season is governed by the **order of bodies**: water, shelter, wounds, infection, childbirth, hunting, the Monster as predator, Locke's paralyzed legs restored, a doctor's hands. From the opening of the hatch onward, the dominant register shifts to the **order of minds**: orientation films, research stations, a numerical sequence with apocalyptic consequences, electromagnetic anomalies, the epistemic theater of the Others, the physics of time travel, and, structurally, the flash-forward and the time-skip, which convert the narrative itself into a problem of knowledge. The audience's mode of attention migrates accordingly, from suspense to what Jason Mittell calls forensic fandom. The final season pivots to the **order of charity**: candidacy freely accepted, sacrifice, forgiveness, and a terminal sequence in which persons recognize one another in love and walk together into light. The pivot is not a betrayal of the preceding order but its Pascalian completion. No accumulation of answers, however exhaustive, could produce the movement in which Jack, at last, takes his father's hand; that movement is of another order.

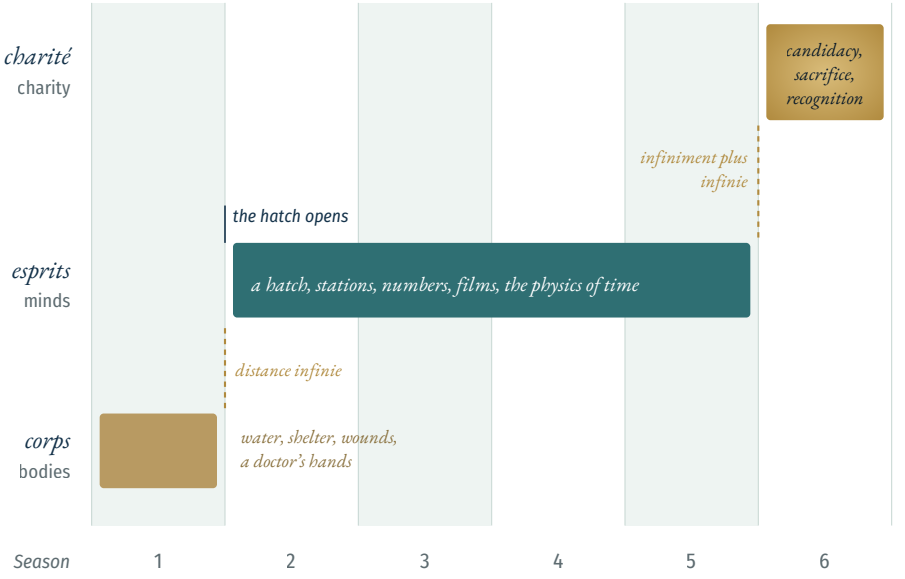


Figure 1 *Pascal's three orders across the six seasons (0.3). The order of bodies governs the first season; from the opening of the hatch, the order of minds; in the final season, the order of charity. The gaps widen as Pascal's distances do: infinite, then infinitely more infinite (L308/B793).*

This scheme accounts for what no prior reading has explained: why the finale satisfied and enraged in roughly equal measure. Viewers who had been trained, over five seasons, to treat the order of minds as the series' ultimate horizon received, at the threshold of the third order,

goods they had not been schooled to want. The resulting controversy, examined in Chapter 11, is less a verdict on the finale's craft than the dramatic enactment of the disproportion Pascal describes.

0.4

Status quaestionis

The scholarship on *Lost* falls into four overlapping bodies. The first is forensic and paratextual: the fan wiki *Lostpedia* (founded 2005), weekly exegetical journalism, and the producers' official podcast, which together constituted an unprecedented apparatus of real-time commentary. The second consists of guidebooks, notably Lynnette Porter and David Lavery's *Unlocking the Meaning of Lost* (2006) and their subsequent *Lost's Buried Treasures* (with Hillary Robson), which catalogued the series' literary and philosophical allusions with admirable diligence. The third is the philosophy-and-popular-culture genre, represented by Kaye's two collections (2008; 2011), whose essays address faith and reason, free will, utilitarian ethics, and the philosopher-names. The fourth, and most theoretically developed, is media studies: Roberta Pearson's edited *Reading Lost* (2009); Jason Mittell's essay "Narrative Complexity in Contemporary American Television" (2006) and monograph *Complex TV* (2015), which established concepts such as the operational aesthetic and drillability with *Lost* as a central exhibit; Henry Jenkins's *Convergence Culture* (2006) and Jonathan Gray's *Show Sold Separately* (2010) on transmedia storytelling and paratexts; and Randy Laist's collection *Looking for Lost* (2011).

This literature has three characteristic limits. The guidebook and philosophy-and-popular-culture traditions produce *inventory without architecture*: they identify allusions—Locke and Rousseau, Hume and Bentham, the Egyptian statue, the Narnian lamp post—but treat them as an aggregate of Easter eggs rather than as elements of a system. Media studies produces *form without theology*: it explains brilliantly how the series solicited its audience, but brackets what the series says, as though the content of its metaphysics were incidental to its seriality. Finally, those readings that do engage the series' religious content tend toward *theology without critique*, celebrating the ecumenical window of the final church without asking whose sea and whose land were required to build the island on which that church's congregation first met. This dissertation responds with an architecture (the three orders), a theology (the perditology), and a critique (Chapter 12).

0.5

Thesis: a perditology in three movements

The Latin *perdere* yields both *perditus*, lost, and *perditio*, ruin or damnation. The ambiguity is the series' own. In one register, to be lost is to be damned: the Man in Black, cast into the Light and expelled from it as smoke, and the Whispers in the jungle—souls, the series eventu-

ally discloses, who cannot move on—embody perdition. In another register, to be lost is the precondition of being found, as in Shakespeare's late romance *The Winter's Tale*, where an abandoned infant is named Perdita, "the lost one," and the oracle declares that the king shall live without an heir "if that which is lost be not found." *Lost* is saturated with lost children whose recovery or nonrecovery determines the fate of the island's polities: Alex, raised by her mother's enemy; Walt, abducted for his gifts; Aaron, saved, surrendered, and returned; Ji Yeon, born off-island. The series navigates between perdition and Perdita. It is, in a precise sense, a *perditology*: a sustained thought about what it means to be lost, and about the conditions under which the lost may be kept, remembered, and found.

The perditology unfolds through three conceptual innovations, each developed in a chapter of Part II and each resolving a tension inherited from the philosophical tradition the series names.

1. **Constancy** (Chapter 6). Against the Lockean *tabula rasa* the series sets character as disposition, revealed but not erased by catastrophe; against Hume's dissolution of the self into a bundle of perceptions it sets a self that remains itself only through fidelity to another. Personal identity becomes a relational achievement sustained across temporal discontinuity—Ricoeur's *ipse* rather than *idem*, the identity of the kept promise rather than of an enduring substance.
2. **Custody** (Chapter 7). Against sovereignty conceived as decision (Schmitt), as surveillance (Bentham), or as providential management (Jacob), the series moves toward a sovereignty of keeping: the protector as *shomer*, the brother's keeper and the garden's keeper, whose office is to restrain rather than to rule. The island's "cork" is a *katechon* in the sense of 2 Thessalonians 2:6–7; the series' last regime replaces the manipulative magus with a caretaker who governs by solicitude.
3. **Anamnesis** (Chapter 9). Against an apocalyptic eschatology of rupture, the series offers an eschatology of recollection. The flash-sideways is neither an alternate timeline nor an escape from history but history remembered together; its theological grammar is that of Augustine's *memoria*, Plato's recollection, Dante's Eunoë, and Benjamin's chronicler, for whom nothing that has happened is to be given up as lost.

These three innovations are, respectively, the series' answers to the three Pascalian questions it inherits from L198: who am I, waking here (constancy); who has placed me here, and to what end (custody); and what will become of me in dying (anamnesis). Chapters 4, 5, and 8 provide their epistemic, temporal, and theodical infrastructure.

0.6

Method and its limits

The method is a convergent hermeneutics in which five disciplines are made to illuminate a single object: onomastic philology (what the names carry), comparative mythography (which structures the series inherits), comparative literature (which fictions it rewrites), narratology (how its form produces meaning), and political theology (what its regimes reveal about sovereignty). Reception theory then reflects on the community of interpreters the series created. The three grades of attribution set out above govern every comparison.

Two cautions apply throughout. First, *Lost* was made under industrial conditions that left visible marks on its narrative: the producers negotiated with ABC, in May 2007, a fixed end date and a remaining total of 48 episodes; the 2007–2008 Writers Guild strike truncated the fourth season to 14 episodes; and departures of cast members, together with the physical maturation of the child actor who played Walt, foreclosed certain lines of development. This study therefore distinguishes **constitutive incompleteness**, in which the withholding of an answer belongs to the work's meaning, from **contingent incompleteness**, in which it reflects the accidents of production. The theological reading defended here does not absolve the series of the latter. Second, the dissertation does not claim that the series' makers read Pascal, Molina, or Dōgen. It claims that the series is intelligible as a system only when brought into relation with the traditions these figures represent, and that the traditions the series names explicitly lead, by their own inner logic, to those it does not.

0.7

Plan of the work

Part I, "Archives," reconstructs the series' sources. Chapter 1 reads its onomastic system as an ironic prosopopoeia of modern philosophy and science. Chapter 2 excavates its scriptural strata: Hebrew, Egyptian, Iranian, Gnostic, Manichaean, and Indic. Chapter 3 situates the series within four archipelagoes of prior fiction: the castaway narrative, the utopian island, the island of illusion, and the afterlife voyage.

Part II, "Axes," develops the perditology. Chapter 4 reconsiders the faith–reason antagonism as a problem of discernment. Chapter 5 offers a chronosophy of the series' multiple temporalities and of its final preference for the Constant over the Variable. Chapters 6 and 7 develop constancy and custody; Chapter 8 the theodicy of the twin brothers and the Light; Chapter 9 the anamnestic eschatology of the flash-sideways.

Part III, "Receptions and Limits," turns to form and audience. Chapter 10 analyzes the series' narrative poetics. Chapter 11 reads the finale's reception through Lucretius, Blumenberg, and Pascal's disproportion of orders. Chapter 12 subjects the perditology to postcolo-

nial, feminist, and disability critique. The Conclusion returns to the bamboo grove and to the eye that closes there.

Part I

Archives

1 *The Onomastic Archive*

2 *Scriptures of the Island*

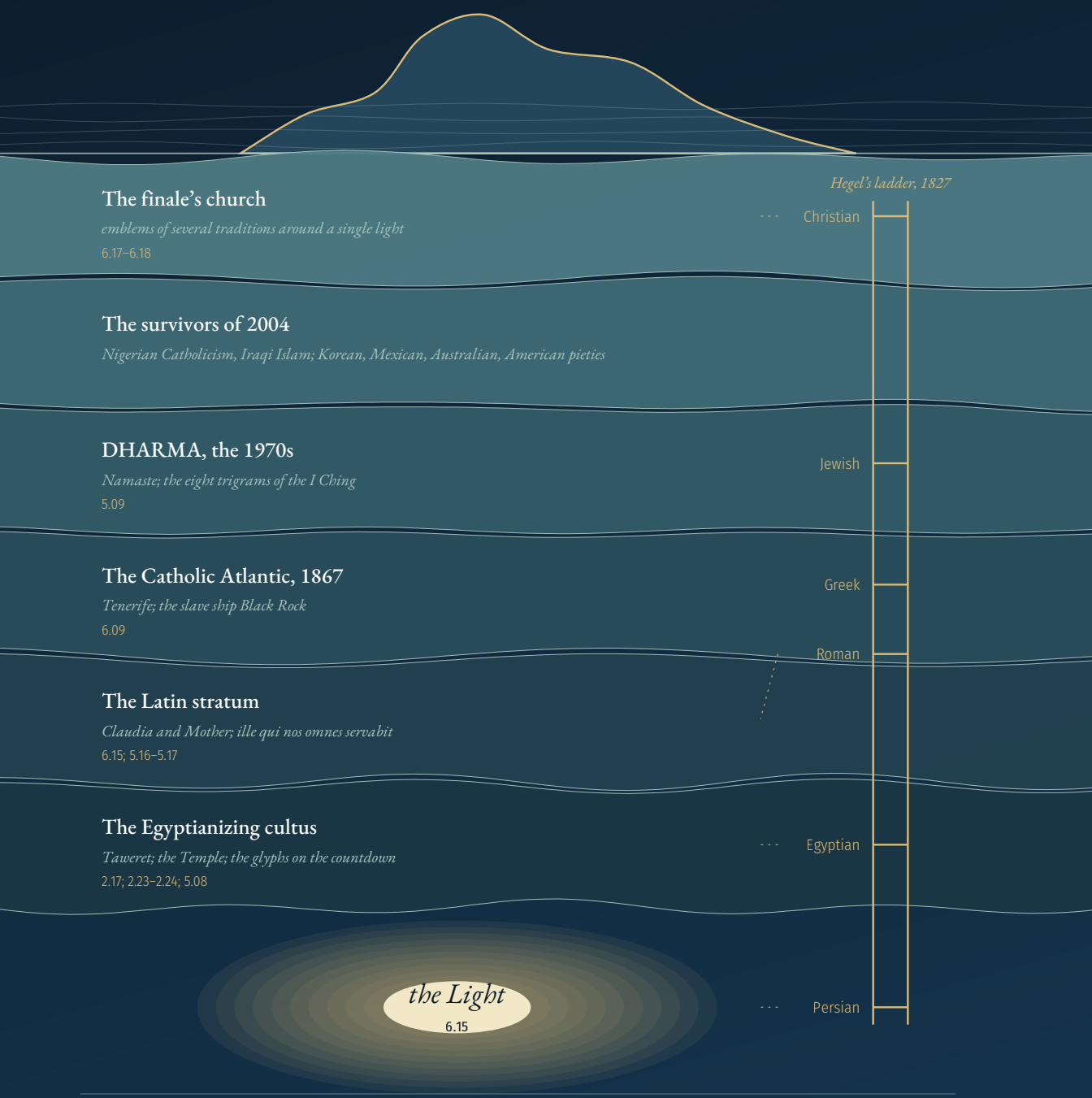
3 *The Four Archipelagoes*



Plate I

The strata of the sacred

Oldest at the bottom: the island's own chronology of sacred deposits (2.1)



Set against Hegel's ladder of religions, the island reproduces nearly every rung (2.1).
The ocean around it supplies no stratum of its own (12.1).

Chapter 1

The Onomastic Archive

Philosophers, Savants, and the Prosopopoeia of Modernity

The names in *Lost* are not Easter eggs but arguments. Taken together, they constitute a prosopopoeia—a rhetorical personification—of the modern tradition from Locke to Hawking, in which each namesake's signature doctrine is embodied, tested, and in most cases inverted by the character who bears it. The pattern is consistent enough to have predictive force: a character named for a philosopher will be placed in a situation that exposes the limit of that philosopher's central claim. The table below summarizes the principal cases; the sections that follow analyze them.

Table 2 *The onomastic archive: characters, namesakes, and inversions*

Character	Namesake	Namesake's signature doctrine	Narrative inversion	Fate on the island
John Locke	John Locke (1632–1704)	Empiricism; *tabula rasa*; memory criterion of personal identity; critique of "enthusiasm"	An enthusiast of revelation whose body is worn by another	Murdered off-island; corpse occupied (5.07; 5.16–5.17)
Jeremy Bentham (Locke's alias)	Jeremy Bentham (1748–1832)	Panopticon; utility; the "auto-icon"	A corpse transported, displayed, and impersonated	Dies with Locke
Desmond David Hume	David Hume (1711–1776)	Self as bundle; causation as constant conjunction; skepticism about miracles	Finds his "constant" in another person; becomes himself a living anomaly	Survives
Danielle Rousseau	Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778)	State of nature; natural education (*Émile*)	The solitary "savage" is a traumatized scientist; her child is reared by her enemies	Killed (4.08)

Character	Namesake	Namesake's signature doctrine	Narrative inversion	Fate on the island
Juliet Burke	Edmund Burke (1729–1797)	The sublime of terror; the "little platoon"	Seeks the little platoon of home; dies triggering a sublime detonation	Dies (6.01)
Mikhail Bakunin	Mikhail Bakunin (1814–1876)	Anarchism; *God and the State*	An anarchist's name in a theocracy's service	Dies (3.22–3.23)
Daniel Faraday	Michael Faraday (1791–1867)	Electromagnetic field theory; devout Sandemanian faith	A physicist whose theory becomes a creed	Shot by his mother (5.14)
Eloise Hawking	Stephen Hawking (1942–2018)	Chronology protection conjecture	Enforces the timeline's "course correction" at her son's expense	Survives
George Minkowski	Hermann Minkowski (1864–1909)	Unified spacetime	Dies unmoored in time	Dies (4.05)
Charlotte Staples Lewis	C. S. Lewis (1898–1963)	Narnia's time differential; the afterlife fictions	Dies of temporal dislocation; her childhood lies on the island	Dies (5.05)

1.1

Locke: the empiricist as enthusiast

The historical Locke opened the second book of *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1689) by supposing the mind to be "white paper, void of all characters, without any ideas" (II.i.2)—the image later condensed into the formula *tabula rasa*, which the series adopts as the title of its third episode. In that episode (1.03) Jack offers the fugitive Kate a Lockean amnesty: their old lives ended in the crash, and each may begin again. The series spends six seasons refuting the offer. The flashback, its signature device, establishes that no one arrives on the island blank; each character carries what Leibniz, answering Locke in the *Nouveaux essais*, called the veins in the marble—dispositions that circumstance reveals but does not create.

The second Lockean doctrine the series tests is the memory criterion of personal identity (*Essay* II.xxvii). Locke's most famous thought experiment imagines the soul of a prince, "carrying with it the consciousness of the prince's past life," entering the body of a cobbler: the resulting being, Locke concludes, would be the same *person* as the prince but not the same *man*. *Lost* stages precisely this case in reverse. From the fifth-season finale onward, the Man in Black wears John Locke's body; he is the same man, in Locke's sense, but not the same person. The series' title for the off-island episode in which Locke dies, "The Life and Death of Jeremy Bentham" (5.07), already marks the dissociation: Locke dies under an alias, and the body that returns to the island returns under no proper name at all.

The third doctrine is the most consequential. In a chapter added to the fourth edition of the *Essay* (1700), "Of Enthusiasm" (IV.xix), Locke attacked the disposition that sets aside reason in favor of immediate revelation, a disposition that in his words "takes away both

reason and revelation, and substitutes in the room of them the ungrounded fancies of a man's own brain." The fictional Locke is the series' great enthusiast. He reads the island's events as personal revelation, interprets dreams as commands, and subordinates evidence to conviction. The irony is exact: the character named for modernity's most influential critic of enthusiasm is enthusiasm's tragic hero, and his tragedy unfolds exactly as the historical Locke predicted—not because faith is false, but because faith without a rule of discernment can be captured by whatever voice speaks most confidently. Chapter 4 develops the consequence.

A final onomastic detail completes the inversion. The historical Locke's patron was Anthony Ashley Cooper, first Earl of Shaftesbury, in whose household Locke served as physician; in 1668 Locke supervised the operation that drained an abscess on Shaftesbury's liver. The fictional Locke's father is the con man Anthony Cooper, who defrauds his son of a kidney ("Deus Ex Machina," 1.19) and throws him from an eighth-story window ("The Man from Tallahassee," 3.13). The physician who saved his patron's organ becomes the son whose father harvests his own. The patron-client relation of Restoration politics is rewritten as the predatory paternity that runs through the entire series.

1.2

Bentham: the panopticon and the auto-icon

When Locke leaves the island to recall the Oceanic Six, he travels as Jeremy Bentham. The alias carries two Benthamite projects. The first is the Panopticon (1791), the circular prison in which an unseen inspector observes every inmate, which Foucault made the emblem of disciplinary modernity. The series literalizes it in the Pearl station, whose orientation film reveals that the occupants of the Swan were themselves under observation ("?", 2.21), and generalizes it in the Others' surveillance of the survivors and in Jacob's lighthouse, whose mirrored wheel shows the homes of the candidates scattered across the world ("Lighthouse," 6.05).

The second Benthamite project is less often recalled. Bentham directed that after his death his body be preserved and displayed, explaining the proposal in a pamphlet titled *Auto-Icon; or, Farther Uses of the Dead to the Living*. His dressed skeleton, surmounted by a wax head, still sits in a cabinet at University College London. *Lost* converts this eccentric bequest into a theological horror. Locke's corpse is carried back to the island in a coffin aboard Ajira Flight 316, and the Man in Black assumes its likeness: the dead is put to "farther use" by the living—or rather by a being who is neither living nor dead in any ordinary sense. Bentham's utilitarian calculus, meanwhile, finds its spokesmen in Ben Linus and the Others, whose recurrent appeal to the greater good licenses abduction, deception, and murder.

1.3

Hume: the skeptic's constant

Desmond David Hume shares not only his namesake's surname and given name but his Scottish birth. The correspondence is the most philosophically productive in the series. In the section "Of Personal Identity" in *A Treatise of Human Nature* (1739), Hume denied that introspection reveals any enduring self: if any impression gave rise to the idea of self, it would have to continue invariably the same throughout our lives, "but there is no impression constant and invariable." The self is a bundle of perceptions in perpetual flux. In "The Constant" (4.05), Desmond's consciousness becomes unmoored from the bundle's chronological order, oscillating between 1996 and 2004; the physicist Faraday tells him that he can survive only by finding a constant, something that exists in both times. What the fictional Hume finds is precisely what the historical Hume declared unavailable—not, however, within the bundle of his perceptions, but outside it, in Penny Widmore.

Two further Humean doctrines are activated. Hume reduced causation to the observation of "constant conjunction" (*Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, VII); the episode's title quietly converts an epistemological term of art into an ethical one. And Hume's essay "Of Miracles" (*Enquiry* X) argued that testimony to a miracle can never outweigh the uniform experience against it. Desmond, after turning the Swan's failsafe key, survives an electromagnetic discharge that should have destroyed him and acquires prophetic flashes; the skeptic's namesake becomes the series' most undeniable miracle. It is worth recording a pattern that is either design or the most eloquent of accidents: of the characters named for philosophers in the strict sense—Locke, Rousseau, Hume, Burke, and Bakunin, together with Locke's Benthamite alias—only Hume survives the island.

1.4

Rousseau: the savage, the child, and the signal

Danielle Rousseau enters the series as a voice before she is a body: a French distress call that, Sayid calculates in the pilot, has looped for sixteen years. When she appears, she is the jungle's solitary inhabitant, armed, trap-laying, half-mad—a figure apparently drawn from the *Discourse on the Origin of Inequality* (1755), whose natural man wanders the forest alone, without language or society. It should be noted that the phrase "noble savage" is not Rousseau's; it was coined by Dryden in *The Conquest of Granada* (1672)—"When wild in woods the noble savage ran"—and attached to Rousseau only later. The series appears to understand the distinction. Its Rousseau is neither noble nor savage but a scientist whose expedition, the fifth season discloses, was destroyed by the island ("This Place Is Death," 5.05); her wildness is trauma, not nature.

The deeper inversion concerns education. In *Émile* (1762), Rousseau prescribed that his pupil's first book, and for a long time his only one, should be *Robinson Crusoe*, the castaway's manual of self-sufficiency. Danielle's daughter Alex is taken from her in infancy and raised by Ben Linus among the Others. The island, the Robinsonade's ideal schoolroom, becomes the site where the natural mother is deprived of her child and the child is formed by a polity of deception. Rousseau's opening sentence in *The Social Contract*—man is born free and everywhere he is in chains—could serve as the epigraph of Alex's biography.

1.5

Burke: the sublime and the little platoon

Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* (1757) located the sublime in terror: whatever is fitted to excite ideas of pain and danger is a source of the strongest emotion the mind can feel. The island is a Burkean sublime from its first scene, and Juliet Burke, the fertility specialist recruited under false pretenses to solve the island's maternal mortality, experiences it as captivity. Her political desire is the one Burke articulated in the *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790): to love the "little platoon we belong to in society," which Burke called the first principle of public affection. Stranded in 1977, she builds exactly such a platoon with Sawyer inside the DHARMA Initiative's suburban compound—a Burkean idyll of domestic continuity amid a technocratic utopia. She dies striking the hydrogen bomb that ends that idyll, in the most literally sublime image the series produces ("The Incident," 5.16–5.17; "LA X," 6.01–6.02).

1.6

Bakunin: the anarchist in the theocracy

In *God and the State* (1882), Bakunin inverted Voltaire's maxim that if God did not exist it would be necessary to invent him: if God really existed, Bakunin replied, it would be necessary to abolish him. Mikhail Bakunin of *Lost*, a former Soviet signals officer who runs the Flame station, serves the most hierarchical society on the island, a theocracy governed in the name of an invisible patriarch. The anarchist's namesake is a zealot of obedience. Fittingly, he refuses to stay dead—surviving the sonic fence, reappearing to die at last in the Looking Glass station—as if the revolutionary principle he names kept returning in the very regime that suppresses it. Bakunin's question is finally answered not by him but by Ben, who kills Jacob in "The Incident": the abolition of God is accomplished by God's most loyal administrator.

1.7

The savants: field, chronology, spacetime

The physicists' names constitute a second register. Michael Faraday discovered electromagnetic induction and developed the concept of the field; the island's defining physical property

is an electromagnetic anomaly, and the Swan exists to discharge it. Faraday was also a lifelong elder of the Sandemanians, a small and strict Christian sect—a scientist of faith, which is exactly what Daniel Faraday becomes when his doctrine that "whatever happened, happened" yields, in "The Variable" (5.14), to a wager that human choice can alter the past. Stephen Hawking proposed in 1992 the chronology protection conjecture, according to which the laws of physics prevent the formation of closed timelike curves and thereby protect history from paradox. Eloise Hawking is that conjecture personified: her doctrine that "the universe has a way of course correcting" ("Flashes Before Your Eyes," 3.08) protects the timeline even at the cost of her own son, whom she shoots in 1977 knowing what she does. Faraday names his laboratory rat Eloise, after her.

Hermann Minkowski's lecture "Raum und Zeit" (1908) declared that henceforth space by itself and time by itself were doomed to sink into mere shadows, and only a kind of union of the two would preserve independent reality. George Minkowski, the freighter's communications officer, is the first character we see destroyed by that union: unmoored like Desmond but without a constant, he dies in "The Constant" (4.05). The episode thus offers a controlled experiment. Two men suffer the same dislocation; the one who has a constant lives, and the one who has none dies. The savants' names, in sum, mark the island as a place where the twentieth century's physics of fields, spacetime, and causal protection becomes existential.

1.8

Fabulists, mystics, and kings

A third register gathers writers and religious figures. Charlotte Staples Lewis carries the full name of C. S. Lewis, whose Narnia is governed by a time differential between worlds and whose lamp post gives its name to the DHARMA station from which the island is located ("316," 5.06); Lewis's afterlife fictions, *The Great Divorce* (1945) and *The Last Battle* (1956), will prove central to Chapter 9. The Looking Glass station and the episode titles "White Rabbit" (1.05) and "Through the Looking Glass" (3.22–3.23) cite Lewis Carroll, whose White Queen remarks that "it's a poor sort of memory that only works backwards"—a precise description of the flash-forward that the latter episode introduces. Ben Linus's alias, Henry Gale, borrows the name of Dorothy's uncle in L. Frank Baum's Oz cycle; the episodes "The Man Behind the Curtain" (3.20) and "There's No Place Like Home" (4.12–4.14) confirm that Ben is a humbug wizard, ruling in the name of a god he has never seen.

Richard Alpert, the ageless intermediary between the Others and Jacob, shares his name with the Harvard psychologist who became Ram Dass, author of *Be Here Now* (1971). Ram Dass means "servant of God"; the series' Richard is literally the servant of Jacob, bound to him by the gift of an unending present. The Temple's master is named Dogen, after Dōgen Zenji (1200–1253), whose essay "Uji" ("Being-Time") argues that time and being are not two. Boone Carlyle, who follows Locke into the jungle and dies in the search for revelation ("Deus Ex Machina," 1.19), bears the surname of Thomas Carlyle, author of *On Heroes, Hero-Wor-*

ship, and the Heroic in History (1841). Christian Shephard and his son Jack carry the pastoral image of the Gospel of John and of Psalm 23, whose number reappears beside Jack's name on the cave wall of candidates ("The Substitute," 6.04). Ana Lucia Cortez, the martial leader of the tail-section survivors, bears the conquistador's surname. Hugo Reyes, finally, carries a Germanic given name meaning mind or heart and a Spanish surname meaning kings: the series' last ruler is, etymologically, the heart-king, keeper of the Heart of the Island.

1.9

Anagrams: purgatory, the other man, lost time

The onomastic archive includes three anagrams. Ethan Rom, the Others' infiltrator in the first season, is an "other man." Mittelos Bioscience, the front company that recruits Juliet ("Not in Portland," 3.07), rearranges into "lost time," the *temps perdu* of Proust, whose *Le Temps retrouvé* will prove the closest literary analogue to the finale. Most remarkable is Gary Troup, the passenger sucked into the jet engine in the pilot and the fictional author of the tie-in novel *Bad Twin*, whose name rearranges into "purgatory." The hypothesis most persistently proposed by viewers—that the survivors were dead and the island a purgatory—is thus literally consumed by the machine in the series' first hour. The producers repeatedly denied it, and correctly: the island is real. Yet in the final season the hypothesis returns, transposed from the island to the flash-sideways, which is indeed a purgatorial waiting place. The anagram both kills and prophesies the interpretation.

1.10

The ossuary of the Enlightenment

The onomastic archive has a shape. The philosophers of modern selfhood (Locke, Hume), politics (Rousseau, Burke, Bakunin), and administration (Bentham) are brought to the island and subjected to its tests; most of them die there. The physicists of field, spacetime, and chronology arrive with the freighter and the time-skips; Minkowski, Charlotte, and Faraday die of the very temporal phenomena their namesakes theorized. The survivors are telling: Hume, who finds a constant outside himself, and Hawking, the protector of chronology. Above them all stands the patriarch's name. The island functions, onomastically, as an ossuary of the Enlightenment—a place where the names of modernity's philosophers and savants are interred in the presence of the God of Jacob. That is the *Mémorial*'s antithesis rendered as a casting sheet. Chapter 2 turns to the scriptures in which that God's name, and his brother's namelessness, are inscribed.

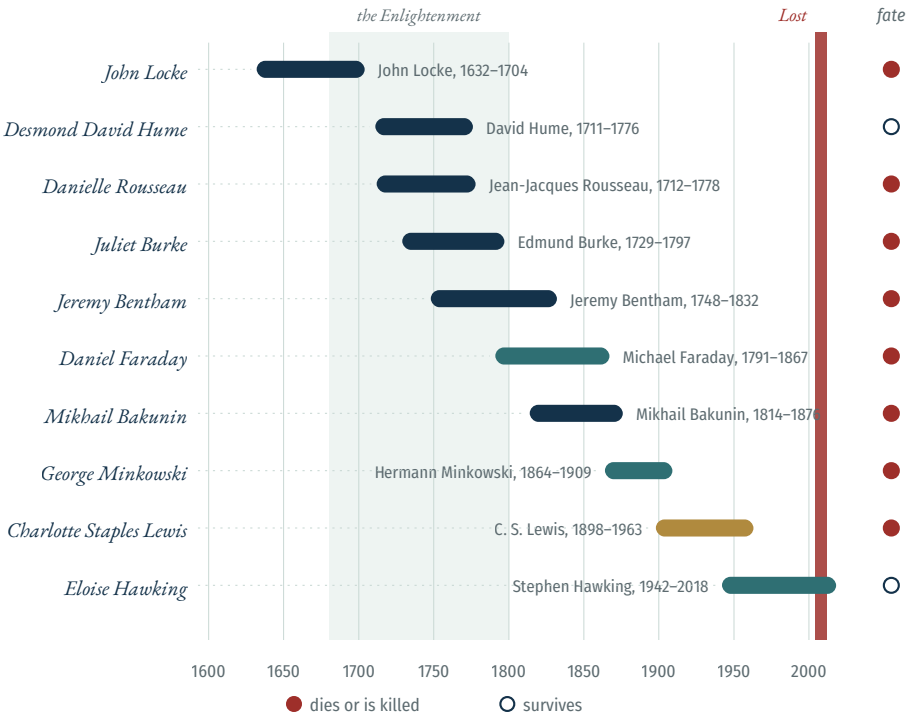


Figure 2 *The ossuary of the Enlightenment (1.10). Ten characters and the namesakes whose doctrines they invert, on one timeline from Locke's birth to the series' broadcast. Eight of the ten die or are killed.*

Chapter 2

Scriptures of the Island

The Strata of the Sacred

The religious materials of *Lost* are not blended but deposited. Critics habitually call the series "syncretic," but syncretism names a fusion in which sources lose their contours, whereas the island preserves its sources as superposed strata, each legible, each dated within the fiction, each overlying an older one. This chapter excavates those strata—Hebrew, Christian, Egyptian, Iranian, Gnostic, Indic—argues that their arrangement constitutes a deliberate inversion of the most influential modern narrative of religious history, Hegel's, and closes with the hermeneutic rule that governs the whole deposit.

2.1

Stratigraphy, not syncretism

The fiction supplies its own chronology of sacred deposits. Oldest is an Egyptianizing cultus of unknown authorship: the colossal statue whose four-toed foot first appears in "Live Together, Die Alone" (2.23–2.24) and whose rear view in "LaFleur" (5.08) discloses the hippopotamus goddess Taweret, an identification the producers confirmed; the Temple with its hieroglyphic walls; the glyphs that replace the numerals on the Swan's countdown when it expires ("Lockdown," 2.17). Above this lies a Latin stratum. The shipwrecked Claudia and the woman credited only as "Mother" speak Latin in the opening minutes of "Across the Sea" (6.15), and the Others retain Latin as a liturgical tongue, down to the shibboleth by which Ilana's party identifies itself—"What lies in the shadow of the statue?"—and Richard's answer, *Ille qui nos omnes servabit*, "he who will keep us all" (5.16–5.17). Then comes the

Catholic Atlantic of the nineteenth century, embodied in Richard Alpert's Tenerife of 1867 and the slave ship *Black Rock* ("Ab Aeterno," 6.09); then the countercultural Orientalism of the 1970s, in which the DHARMA Initiative greets its members with *Namaste* (5.09) and stamps its stations with the eight trigrams of the *I Ching*; then the globalized religiosity of the 2004 survivors—Nigerian Catholicism, Iraqi Islam, and Korean, Mexican, Australian, and American pieties; and, finally, the ecumenical church of the finale, whose stained glass bears the emblems of several traditions around a single light.

Laid against Hegel's 1827 *Lectures on the Philosophy of Religion*, this stratigraphy reveals a pattern that cannot be accidental in its totality, whatever the status of its parts. Hegel's "determinate religions" form a ladder of spirit's self-understanding, from natural religion to the "consummate religion" of Christianity. The island reproduces nearly every rung.

Table 3 *Hegel's sequence of religions (1827) and the strata of the island*

Station in Hegel's sequence (1827)	Hegel's designation	Stratum in *Lost*	Principal loci
Persian	religion of the good, or of light	The Light; twins of light and darkness; "a little of this light" in every person	"Across the Sea" (6.15)
Egyptian	religion of the enigma (*Rätsel*)	Taweret; the Temple; glyphs on the countdown; judgment beneath the Temple	2.17; 2.23–2.24; 5.08; 5.12
Jewish	religion of sublimity	Jacob; election (Malachi 1:2 in Room 23); the invisible sovereign	3.07; 5.16–5.17
Greek	religion of beauty	Jacob's tapestry and its Homeric inscription; the castaway epic	5.16–5.17
Roman	religion of expediency (*Zweckmäßigkeit*)	The Others' Latin; their utilitarian theocracy of "the greater good"	1.21; season 3
Christian	consummate religion	Christian Shephard; Eko's church and baptisms; the final church	1.05; 2.12; 6.17–6.18

Three features of the correspondence matter. First, Hegel's designation of Egypt as the "religion of the enigma" is precisely the function Egyptian iconography serves in the series: glyphs, statue, and Temple are signs that announce meaning while withholding it. Hegel called the Sphinx the symbol of the symbolic itself (*Aesthetics*), and the series stations its enigmas in Egyptian dress because, since Champollion, Egypt has been the West's emblem of the signifier awaiting decipherment—a role the fan wiki *Lostpedia* assumed with something like Champollion's zeal. Second, Hegel's account of Roman religion as a religion of utility, in which the gods serve the ends of the state, fits with disquieting exactness the Latin-speaking Others, whose ethic of "the greater good" (the title of 1.21 and the refrain of Ben's regime) is Benthamite in content and Roman in idiom. Third, and decisively, the series traverses Hegel's ladder in the opposite direction. Hegel's is a *phenomenology*, an ascent from enigma toward spirit's self-transparency. *Lost* begins at the top, among moderns whose religion is Christian or post-Christian, and digs downward through DHARMA, the *Black Rock*, the Others' Latin, and

the Egyptian cultus to the oldest thing on the island, a light in a cave. Paul Ricoeur, in *De l'interprétation* (1965), distinguished an *archaeology* of the subject (Freud's regress toward origins) from a *teleology* of spirit (Hegel's progress toward ends) and argued that interpretation must hold both. The series' religious architecture is an archaeology that culminates not in Hegel's consummate religion but in a window through which many traditions refract one light: a teleology that refuses to name its *telos* as the property of any single confession.

Jan Assmann's concept of the "Mosaic distinction"—the distinction between true and false religion that, on his account, monotheism introduced into a world of mutually translatable cosmotheisms (*Moses the Egyptian*, 1997)—clarifies what this refusal does and does not mean. The series does not abolish the distinction between true and false; its entire final season turns on telling the true guide from the false one. What it does is relocate the distinction. The boundary between truth and falsehood no longer runs between traditions, which the window reconciles, but through each person, who must discern between Jacob and the thing that wears Locke's face. The Mosaic distinction is interiorized. Chapter 4 calls the resulting faculty *discernment*; the present chapter traces its scriptural raw materials.

2.2

The Hebrew stratum I: the twins

The series names its god after the patriarch who received the name Israel, and it reads the Genesis cycle (Genesis 25–33) with a philologist's attention. Biblical Jacob is the younger twin, born grasping his brother's heel—*ʿaqev*, the root of his name, which Esau later glosses as "supplanter" (27:36). The series inverts the birth order. In "Across the Sea," Jacob is born first, and his mother, Claudia, who expected one child, has chosen only one name. The second child is never named. The supplanter becomes the rightful heir, and the brother is denied even the dignity of being supplanted under a name of his own; the credits call him "Man in Black."

Genesis characterizes the brothers by vocation: Esau is "a cunning hunter, a man of the field," Jacob "a plain man, dwelling in tents" (25:27). The series preserves the opposition and gives it a Cainite inflection. The younger twin leaves the hearth for the field and for the village of the Latin-speaking castaways, learns that metal behaves strangely in certain places, sinks wells, and engineers a wheel by which to channel the Light and escape. He is a man of technique, heir to Tubal-cain, "instructer of every artificer in brass and iron" (4:22), and to Cain himself, who built the first city (4:17)—the line Augustine took as the foundation of the earthly city (*De civitate Dei* XV.1). Jacob remains with Mother, without city or technique; he sits by the sea and weaves.

Two details of the biblical cycle are redistributed between the island's brothers with chiastic precision. The first is the disguise. In Genesis 27 Jacob deceives his blind father by wearing his brother's garments and goatskins on his hands and neck, provoking Isaac's perplexity: "The voice is Jacob's voice, but the hands are the hands of Esau" (27:22). In *Lost* impersonation passes from Jacob to his brother, who wears the forms of the dead as Jacob wore Esau's

skins; when the Man in Black returns in John Locke's form, the voice is the brother's and the body is Locke's. The patriarch's signature act becomes the adversary's signature power. The second is the nocturnal struggle at the ford of the Jabbok (32:22–32). There Jacob wrestles until dawn with a "man" who touches the hollow of his thigh, blesses him with the name Israel, and refuses to disclose his own name (32:29). Rabbinic exegesis identified the nameless wrestler as the heavenly prince, the *sar*, of Esau (*Genesis Rabbah* 77:3), and later tradition named that angel Samael. The structure of the midrash is the structure of the series: the patriarch's adversary is his twin's nameless double, met beside running water. In "Across the Sea" the brothers' decisive struggle takes place at the stream that issues from the Light. And the island's Jacob, like the wrestler, marks those he elects by touch—Kate, Sawyer, Sayid, Jack, Hurley, Sun and Jin, and Locke himself, whom Jacob touches as he lies broken after his fall ("The Incident," 5.16–5.17). The touch that wounds and names becomes the sacrament of candidacy.

The narrative also condenses Genesis's parental split. In the biblical account Isaac prefers Esau and Rebekah prefers Jacob, and the conflict over the blessing runs between the parents. *Lost* gives the twins a single parent who shows evident partiality to the younger yet consecrates the elder, so that the contradiction passes from between the parents to within the parent. Mother's partiality and her lie—that there is nothing across the sea—precede and provoke the younger son's revolt. The series thus locates the origin of evil, as Section 2.6 will show, not in the dark twin but in the parental economy that produced him.

2.3

The Hebrew stratum II: the stone, the garden, and the keepers

Fleeing his brother, Jacob sleeps at Luz with a stone for a pillow and dreams of a ladder on which angels ascend and descend; waking, he declares that the Lord is in this place and he knew it not, that this is "none other but the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven," and he sets up the stone as a pillar and anoints it (Genesis 28:10–22). Rabbinic tradition fused this stone with the *even shetiyah*, the Foundation Stone that the Mishnah locates in the Holy of Holies (Yoma 5:2) and from which, according to the Talmud, the world was founded (Yoma 54b). In *Pirkei de-Rabbi Eliezer* (ch. 35), God sinks Jacob's stone into the depths and makes it the keystone of the earth, set like the keystone of an arch at the world's navel. A further tradition makes the stone a seal upon the abyss: when David dug the Temple's foundations, the deep rose and threatened to flood the world until a sherd inscribed with the divine Name was cast down to hold it back (Sukkah 53a–b).

The convergence with the Heart of the Island is, at the least, remarkable (Grade C). Beneath the island lies a luminous cave into which water flows; at its center a carved stone is set in an aperture, which Jacob, in his parable of the wine bottle, calls the cork that keeps the darkness where it belongs ("Ab Aeterno"). When Desmond lifts the stone in "The End," the light goes out, the water drains, and the island begins to break apart; when Jack replaces it, the

light returns. The Heart of the Island is the *even shetiyah* of a fictional world: the omphalos that Mircea Eliade identified as the archetypal Center, the *axis mundi* where heaven, earth, and underworld meet (*The Myth of the Eternal Return*, 1949). It is also a Bethel, a place where the divine was present and its visitors knew it not. Isaiah's *Vere tu es Deus absconditus* (45:15), which Pascal made a cornerstone of his apologetics and Lucien Goldmann the title of his study of Pascal and Racine (*Le Dieu caché*, 1955), describes the island's governing theology for five seasons: Jacob is everywhere in his effects and nowhere in his person.

The garden furnishes the stratum's second motif. Genesis employs the verb *shamar*, to keep or guard, at three decisive points: Adam is placed in Eden "to dress it and to keep it" (2:15); the cherubim are stationed east of the garden "to keep the way of the tree of life" (3:24); and Cain, asked where his brother is, replies, "Am I my brother's keeper?" (4:9). The triad—keeper of the garden, keeper of the way, keeper of the brother—is the scriptural matrix of the series' theory of sovereignty, which Chapter 7 develops under the name *custody*.

Its first appearance in the series is archaeological. In "House of the Rising Sun" (1.06), Jack and Kate discover in the caves two skeletons with a pouch holding one black and one white stone; Locke names them "Adam and Eve," and Jack, judging from the decay of their clothing, dates them to forty or fifty years before. Five seasons later the series reveals them as Mother and the Man in Black, laid together by Jacob ("Across the Sea"). The island's first parents are a woman who killed a mother to take her children and the son she favored; its Eden is founded on a matricide and a fratricide; and the doctor's confident dating is the order of minds' first error. The Syriac *Cave of Treasures* had already imagined Adam and Eve living and buried in a cave whose relics would become the ground of redemption. *Lost* opens with that cave and explains it only at the end, an *inclusio* that binds its genesis to its eschatology.

2.4

The Christian stratum: shepherd, substitute, sacrament

The series' most visible Christian sign is a name. Christian Shephard, the alcoholic surgeon whose death in Sydney sets Jack aboard Oceanic 815, unites the Johannine Good Shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep (John 10:11) with Psalm 23, which Eko recites with Charlie over the burning Beechcraft ("The 23rd Psalm," 2.10) and whose number stands beside Jack's name on the cave wall of candidates. In "White Rabbit" (1.05), Jack finds his father's coffin empty—an empty tomb that seems to announce resurrection. The final seasons reverse the sign. The Man in Black tells Jack that the figure who led him to water in the first days was himself ("The Last Recruit," 6.13), and the series implies, without fully specifying, that the apparitions of Christian on the island were at least in part the adversary's masks. The genuine Christian Shephard appears only once, in the church of the finale. The distinction recalls John 10:1—whoever enters the sheepfold "some other way" is a thief—and, more precisely, Jean-Luc Marion's phenomenology of the *idol* and the *icon* (*L'idole et la distance*, 1977; *Dieu sans l'être*, 1982). The idol returns the viewer's gaze to itself; the icon opens it to an invisible

that exceeds it. The Monster's apparitions are idols in exactly this sense—Jack's father, Eko's brother, Ben's daughter, each a mirror of its viewer's guilt or longing. The Christian Shephard of the church is an icon, visible only when the viewers have become capable of looking through rather than at.

The Christian stratum is also the stratum of the *substitute*. Mr. Eko, a Nigerian warlord, assumes the priesthood of his murdered brother Yemi after soldiers mistake him for a priest during a heroin deal (2.10): the substitution of brothers that structures the Jacob cycle recurs in miniature. Eko's sacramental acts are the most explicit in the series. He baptizes Claire and her infant son ("Fire + Water," 2.12) and begins, with Charlie, to build a church on the beach, which he abandons when a dream summons him to the Swan's button ("?," 2.21). The liturgy of the church is displaced by the liturgy of the hatch—a substitution whose significance Section 2.5 makes clear. His death enacts a refusal. Confronted by an apparition of Yemi, Eko declines to repent, declaring that he did not ask for the life he was given but did his best with it; the Monster then kills him ("The Cost of Living," 3.05). The staff on which he carved scriptural citations passes to Locke, who reads on it a paraphrase of God's promise to Abram —"lift up your eyes and look north" (cf. Genesis 13:14)—and obeys it as a direction.

Charlie Pace's Catholicism is articulated through two objects. The first is the cache of Virgin Mary statues filled with heroin that he recovers from the Beechcraft and hoards (2.10–2.12): the image of the Mother of God serves, literally, as a container of narcotic, an emblem that Marx's dictum on religion as the opium of the people (1844) could hardly have anticipated more exactly. The second is his death, foreseen by Desmond and accepted as the price of Claire's rescue ("Greatest Hits," 3.21; "Through the Looking Glass," 3.22–3.23): Charlie drowns in the Looking Glass station after writing a warning on his palm, a sacrificial substitution that anticipates the season-six vocabulary of candidates and replacements. The two objects mark the poles of the Christian stratum—idolatry and sacrifice—between which the series' theology of charity is worked out.

Two further rites complete the stratum. In "Ab Aeterno" Jacob repeatedly plunges Richard Alpert beneath the waves until Richard, who believes himself already dead and damned, cries that he wants to live: a baptism by near-drowning whose content is Deuteronomy's injunction, "I have set before you life and death… therefore choose life" (30:19). In the Temple's spring the series stages the inverse rite. Its water heals—Richard carries the dying child Ben there in 1977, warning that the boy will lose his innocence ("Whatever Happened, Happened," 5.11)—and its turbidity recalls the pool of Bethesda, whose healing power was released when an angel "troubled the water" (John 5:4, a verse absent from the earliest manuscripts). When Sayid is immersed in the murky spring after Jacob's death, he returns from death changed—"infected," in the Temple's diagnosis ("LA X," 6.01–6.02; "What Kate Does," 6.03). Immersion yields not new birth but possession. Baptism and anti-baptism are the sacraments of the two brothers.

2.5

The Egyptian stratum

Taweret and the law of the substitute mother. Taweret, the composite goddess with the body of a pregnant hippopotamus, the limbs of a lion, and the back of a crocodile, protected women in childbirth. Her statue presides over an island on which childbirth kills: women who conceive there die before they can give birth, the problem that brought Juliet Burke to the island. The irony deepens into a structural law once the founding scene is known. Jacob's mother, Claudia, is killed minutes after giving birth, and her sons are raised by the woman who killed her. Ben Linus's mother, Emily, dies giving birth to him in the woods outside Portland, and he is raised by a resentful father ("The Man Behind the Curtain," 3.20). Rousseau's daughter Alex is raised by Ben; Claire's son Aaron is raised by Kate, as the psychic Richard Malkin's insistence that the child must not be "raised by another" (1.10) had darkly foretold; Sun's daughter, born off-island, is raised by her grandmother. The series obeys a *law of the substitute mother*: on this island the woman who bears is not the woman who rears. The statue of the goddess of childbirth stands over that law as its cenotaph.

Ammit and the weighing of the heart. Taweret's iconography has a dark double. Ammit, the "devourer of the dead" who waits beside the scales in the judgment scene of the *Book of the Dead*, combines the same three animals—crocodile, lion, hippopotamus—in another order. Spell 125 depicts the deceased in the Hall of the Two Truths, reciting the so-called negative confession before forty-two assessor deities while the heart is weighed against the feather of Maat; the heart that fails is thrown to Ammit. The Monster performs this office. In "The 23rd Psalm" it confronts Eko and flashes images of his life before withdrawing: a psychostasia. In "The Cost of Living" Eko refuses to repent—a negative confession refused rather than recited—and is devoured. In "Dead Is Dead" (5.12) Ben descends to a chamber beneath the Temple whose carvings appear to show the jackal god Anubis, who presides over the weighing, confronting a column of smoke; there the Monster judges him and lets him live. That a statue of the goddess of birth houses Jacob while an Ammit-like devourer serves his brother distributes Egyptian iconography between the twins as a theology of birth and judgment. The judgment, moreover, concerns the heart, which Egyptian anthropology treated as the seat of the person and left in the mummy. The heart scarab laid on the breast of the dead bore Spell 30B, which pleads with the heart—addressed as "my heart of my mother"—not to testify against its owner. The series' sacred center is called the Heart of the Island; its first protector is called Mother.

Senet and the invisible opponent. In "Across the Sea" the younger twin finds on the shore a senet board, the Egyptian game that became, in the New Kingdom, an allegory of the soul's passage through the underworld; the vignette to Spell 17 in the Papyrus of Ani shows the deceased playing senet against an opponent who is not depicted. The younger brother tells the elder that one day he may invent his own game, and then everyone else will have to

follow his rules. The pilot had already made the game the series' governing metaphor: Locke teaches Walt backgammon, a game older than Jesus Christ, with two players and two sides, one light and one dark (1.01–1.02). The rules recur thereafter as the series' figure for metaphysical law ("He changed the rules," Ben says when Keamy kills Alex, 4.09). Johan Huizinga located the origin of culture in the "magic circle" of sacred play (*Homo Ludens*, 1938); the island is such a circle, and the ring of ash around Jacob's cabin its liturgical emblem.

The ka and the corpse. Egyptian funerary religion held that the *ka*, the vital double, required a dwelling—the preserved body or, failing that, a statue. The Monster's dependence on the bodies of the dead follows a *ka*-logic (Grade C): it appears as Christian Shephard, whose body was aboard the plane; as Yemi, whose body lay in the Beechcraft; as Alex, who died on the island; and, finally, as Locke, whose corpse it arranged to have carried back. The Benthamite auto-icon of Chapter 1 and the Egyptian *ka*-statue converge in the coffin aboard Ajira 316.

Apophis and the cork. Egyptian cosmology did not imagine the final destruction of chaos. Each night the serpent Apophis assailed the solar barque, and each night it was repelled, never annihilated; the priestly repertoire preserved in the *Book of Overthrowing Apophis* (Papyrus Bremner-Rhind) maintained *maat*, cosmic order, against *isfet*, disorder, by perpetual liturgical labor. This is precisely the island's theology of evil. Jacob does not destroy his brother; he confines him, and the island is the cork that keeps the darkness in the bottle. The Swan transposes the same theology into technology: every 108 minutes a code must be entered and a button pushed to discharge an electromagnetic build-up, and when the rite is interrupted catastrophe follows ("Live Together, Die Alone"). Locke's crisis of faith in the second season—is the ritual efficacious, or merely the psychological experiment the Pearl's orientation film suggests (2.21)?—is the crisis of every liturgy of maintenance, and the series answers it in the ritual's favor: the button was real. That later Egyptian theology could station Set, the murderer of Osiris, at the prow of the solar barque as the spearman who repels Apophis adds a final ambivalence. The fratricide is also a defender of order; the adversary has a part in the cosmos he threatens. The series will draw the same conclusion about its own fratricides.

2.6

The Iranian stratum

Plutarch, in *On Isis and Osiris* (46–47), already set Egyptian and Persian dualisms side by side: Osiris against Typhon (Set), Oromazes against Areimanius, light against darkness, with Mithras between them as *mesitēs*, the mediator. The series' Iranian stratum begins from this comparison. Its twins are a dualism of light and darkness; Richard Alpert, Jacob's intermediary with the Others, is its *mesitēs*; and Thomas More, as Chapter 3 notes, had his Utopians address the supreme being as Mithra.

The closest Iranian parallel is Zurvanism, the heterodox Zoroastrian theology preserved by hostile Christian witnesses such as the fifth-century Armenian Eznik of Kolb and analyzed by R. C. Zaehner (*Zurvan: A Zoroastrian Dilemma*, 1955). Zurvan, infinite Time, sacrificed for a thousand years to obtain a son and, at the end, doubted whether his sacrifice would bear fruit. From the sacrifice Ohrmazd was conceived; from the doubt, Ahriman. Zurvan vowed the kingship to the firstborn; Ahriman, learning this, tore through the womb to emerge first, and Zurvan, recognizing the dark child as not the son he had sought yet bound by his vow, granted Ahriman a dominion limited to nine thousand years, after which Ohrmazd would reign alone. The homology with "Across the Sea" is close (Grade C): a parent expects one son and receives two; the unexpected second is the dark one; the dark twin's dominion is a limited interval within the reign of light. The divergences are as instructive. *Lost* restores the firstborn's priority, and it makes the dark twin's revolt the product not of his nature but of the parent's failure—of Zurvan's doubt in the myth, of Mother's lie in the series.

Zoroastrian ethics opposes *asha*, truth and cosmic order, to *druj*, the Lie. On the island the primal lie is maternal, and its repetition structures the fifth season, whose second episode, "The Lie" (5.02), concerns the Oceanic Six's cover story. Hurley, temperamentally incapable of sustaining that lie and confined for a time to a psychiatric hospital, becomes in the end the island's protector. The last ruler of the island is, in the Avestan sense, an *ashavan*, a possessor of truth; Chapter 7 argues that his truthfulness is the condition of his custody.

Manichaeism, the third-century religion of Mani, radicalized the dualism into a cosmic drama of light imprisoned in darkness: particles of divine light, swallowed by matter in a primordial defeat, await liberation. In "Across the Sea," Mother explains the Light in terms that are recognizably Manichaean—a little of it is in every person, but they always want more—and adds that if it goes out here, it goes out everywhere. Yet the series' trajectory is the one Augustine traced away from Manichaeism, which he had followed as an auditor for nine years (*Confessions* III–V). Augustine's resolution was the doctrine that evil has no substance of its own and is a privation of the good, *privatio boni*. The Smoke Monster is the most exact visual allegory of that doctrine in popular culture. Born when the younger twin is cast into the Light, it has no form of its own; it is a shapeless darkness that can appear only by borrowing the forms of the dead; and its single desire is to leave. It is evil as lack—of form, of name, of home.

2.7

The Gnostic stratum

In the epilogue to *The Gnostic Religion* (1958), Hans Jonas set Pascal's cry before the infinite spaces—"Qui m'y a mis? Par l'ordre et la conduite de qui ce lieu et ce temps a-t-il été destiné à moi?" (L68/B205), who has put me here, by whose order has this place and this time been allotted to me?—beside the Mandaean question of who had cast the soul into the affliction of the worlds, and argued that modern existentialism had rediscovered the Gnostic experience of

thrownness. The juxtaposition is the hinge of the present study. *Lost* poses Pascal's question with literal force: its survivors do not know who placed them on the island, and the time-skips of the fifth season literalize the fragment's further bewilderment—why here rather than there, why now rather than then. The series then offers two answers.

The first is the Man in Black's, and it is Gnostic. Jacob, he tells Sawyer in the cave of names ("The Substitute," 6.04), has manipulated their lives since childhood to find a replacement; the protectorship is a meaningless servitude; the rational course is to leave with him. Structurally this is the Gnostic redeemer myth: an imprisoning demiurge, a cosmos that is a cage, a messenger from beyond who offers knowledge and escape. Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981), the novel Locke gives the captive Ben in "Eggtown" (4.04), is the twentieth century's most influential restatement of that myth—its Black Iron Prison, its conviction that time itself is counterfeit—and its appearance on screen at the series' midpoint marks the Gnostic option as one the narrative explicitly entertains.

The second answer, Jacob's in "What They Died For" (6.16), rejects the Gnostic premise. He did not pluck them from happy lives; they were flawed and alone, looking for something they could not find in the world, and he chose them because they were like him and needed the island as much as it needed them. This is not a demiurge's alibi but a theology of vocation, and its implied cosmology is the one Plotinus defended against the Gnostics in *Ennead* II.9: the world is not a prison to be fled but an order to be kept. Eric Voegelin's diagnosis of modern political Gnosticism as the attempt to immanentize the eschaton through knowledge and technique (*The New Science of Politics*, 1952) illuminates the series' two technological projects of exit and salvation. The Man in Black's wheel and the DHARMA Initiative's research program—which, in the paracanonical archive of *The Lost Experience*, aims to alter the factors of an equation predicting human extinction—are Gnostic in Voegelin's sense: salvation by gnosis, exit by engineering. Both fail.

The series does not, however, reject Gnosticism wholesale. Its eschatology preserves Gnosticism's most beautiful structure while discarding its acosmism. The "Hymn of the Pearl" in the *Acts of Thomas* (108–113) tells of a prince sent from the East into Egypt to recover a pearl guarded by a serpent in the sea. He puts on Egyptian garments, eats Egyptian food, forgets that he is a king's son, and sleeps, until a letter from his parents, flying as an eagle and becoming speech, wakes him; he remembers, recovers the pearl, and on returning sees himself in his robe of glory as in a mirror. Forgetting, a messenger, awakening, recognition in a mirroring garment: this is the structure of the flash-sideways, in which Desmond is the messenger and the beloved other is the mirror in which each character recognizes himself. The series' position may be called *custodial gnosis*—anamnesis without acosmism, an awakening that leads not out of the world but back into its memory. Chapter 9 develops the formula.

2.8

The Indic and East Asian stratum

The DHARMA Initiative—Department of Heuristics And Research on Material Applications—borrows the Sanskrit term for the order that upholds the cosmos, for duty, and for the Buddha's teaching. The acronym states its hubris: an initiative that would initiate dharma, mastering by method what the tradition holds to be the given law of things. Its insignia, an octagon of the eight trigrams of the *I Ching* enclosing each station's emblem, invokes the *Book of Changes* and the Taoist cosmology of yin and yang, whose emblem places a seed of each principle within the other. Chapter 8 argues that this figure, not the Manichaean one, governs the series' final account of the twins: Jacob's light contains darkness (he manipulates, he condemns his brother, he brings people to suffer), and his brother's darkness contains a seed of light (a longing for his birth mother's people and for home).

The Numbers—4, 8, 15, 16, 23, 42—sum to 108, the interval in minutes at which the Swan's code must be entered. The number is sacred across the Indic traditions: the Muktika canon counts 108 Upanishads, the Hindu and Buddhist rosary (*mala*) has 108 beads, and in Japanese Buddhism the temple bell is struck 108 times on New Year's Eve (*joya no kane*), once for each of the defilements that bind beings to suffering. The button is a *japa*, a repeated invocation, and each discharge a bell struck against the world's accumulated affliction. The station's emblem compounds the allusion (Grade C): in Sanskrit poetics the swan (*haṃsa*) can separate milk from water, the emblem of *viveka*, discrimination between the real and the unreal—and the Swan is the station where Jack and Locke dispute faith and reason through the second season.

The conditioning film of Room 23 ("Not in Portland," 3.07) assembles the stratum's darkest syncretism. Between images of violence and nature it flashes maxims: *everything changes*; *we are the causes of our own suffering*; *only fools are enslaved by time and space*; *God loves you as He loved Jacob*. The first two condense the Buddhist doctrines of impermanence and of craving as the origin of suffering; the third announces, in the register of conditioning, the time travel of the fifth season; the fourth cites Malachi on election. Dharma and election here serve control. Room 23 is the precise inverse of the finale's window: both assemble the emblems of many traditions, but the room uses them to disarm the will and the window to receive the person. The series contains two syncretisms, and the difference between them is the difference the whole work turns upon.

Two names anchor the stratum in historical persons. Richard Alpert, as Chapter 1 noted, took the name Ram Dass, "servant of God"; less often recalled is that the historical Alpert co-authored with Timothy Leary and Ralph Metzner *The Psychedelic Experience: A Manual Based on the Tibetan Book of the Dead* (1964). The series' ageless intermediary between the living and the dead thus bears the name of a modern adapter of the *Bardo Thödol*, the Tibetan guide that instructs the newly dead—who often do not know they have died—to recognize

the clear light; Chapter 9 argues that the flash-sideways is structured as a bardo. Dogen, master of the Temple, bears the name of Dōgen Zenji, whose essay "Uji" ("Being-Time") teaches that time is not a container through which beings pass but is itself being, each moment complete. The fictional Dogen came to the island, he tells Sayid, by a bargain with Jacob: the son he had injured while driving drunk would live, but the father would never see him again ("Sundown," 6.06). The Zen master's exile repeats in the Indic stratum the Akedah pattern that runs through the Hebrew one: a father's relation to his son mediated by sacrifice.

2.9

The rule of the strata: everything that does not lead to charity is figure

The strata require a principle of interpretation, and Pascal provides one. In the bundle of the *Pensées* devoted to the figurative character of the Law, Pascal argued that Scripture is a cipher with a double sense, and he stated its key in two sentences: "Tout ce qui ne va point à la charité est figure. L'unique objet de l'Écriture est la charité" (L270/B670)—everything that does not lead to charity is figure; the sole object of Scripture is charity. He was restating Augustine, for whom whatever in Scripture cannot be referred to good morals or true faith must be read figuratively (*De doctrina christiana* III.10.14), and for whom anyone who thinks he understands Scripture without building up the double love of God and neighbor has not yet understood it (I.36.40).

Applied to the island, the rule yields three consequences. First, the mythological apparatus —the provenance of the statue, the physics of the Light, the mechanics of the wheel, the translation of the glyphs—constitutes the island's literal sense, and the literal sense is figure: not false, but not the point. Second, the series' answers to its enigmas are to be sought where the figures lead, in the order of charity: the explanation of the Light is the community that gathers in its afterglow. Third, the distinction between the two syncretisms of Section 2.8 becomes exact. Room 23 assembles the sacred for the sake of domination; it does not lead to charity, and so it is not even figure but idol. The window assembles the sacred for the sake of recognition; it is figure fulfilled.

Pascal's figurism carries a heavy burden. His distinction between "carnal" and "spiritual" readers was articulated polemically against Judaism and belongs to the long history of Christian supersessionism. The present study adopts the structure of the hermeneutic—figure ordered to charity—while rejecting its polemical assignment, and the series supports the correction. Its final window includes the Star of David; its god bears the name of the patriarch of Israel; and its elected keeper is chosen not against the nations but on their behalf, as Abraham's blessing was to extend to "all families of the earth" (Genesis 12:3). Election in *Lost* is custodial. The Others' shibboleth states the doctrine in four Latin words: the one who lies in the shadow of the statue is *ille qui nos omnes servabit*—the one who will keep us all. Chapter 3 turns from the scriptures in which that keeper is inscribed to the fictions through which his island sailed before it reached the screen.

Chapter 3

The Four Archipelagoes

Castaway, Utopian, Illusionist, and Afterlife Fictions

Lost sails through every major archipelago of the Western island imagination and refuses, at each, the exit by which that archipelago has traditionally released its castaways. The castaway narrative ends in rescue and return; the series makes return a catastrophe. The utopian narrative ends in a rationally constructed polity; the series destroys each of its laboratories by its own methods. The narrative of illusion ends in an unmasking; the series unmasks its magicians only to find further masks and, beneath the last of them, not a trickster but a light. The afterlife narrative ends in the revelation that the living were dead all along; the series stages that revelation and inverts it, so that death ratifies rather than annuls the reality of what has been lived. This chapter reconstructs the four archipelagoes, maps the series' passage through them onto the three Pascalian orders, and argues that the cumulative refusal of their exits constitutes a narrative *via negativa*: by closing every door through which prior fiction let its islanders leave, the series clears the ground for the only resolution that remains—to stay, to keep, and to remember.

3.1

The oceanic island

In an early text published only posthumously, "Causes et raisons des îles désertes" (written in the 1950s; collected in *L'île déserte et autres textes*, 2002), Gilles Deleuze distinguishes two geological kinds of island and reads them as two mythologies. *Continental* islands are accidental and derived: fragments that disarticulation, erosion, or fracture has separated from a mainland, they figure the dream of being apart. *Oceanic* islands are originary and essential: rising

from the sea by volcanic eruption or the slow labor of coral, they figure the dream of beginning again. The desert island, on Deleuze's account, is the site not of a first origin but of a *second* origin—a re-creation after catastrophe, for which the myth of the Flood supplies a ready paradigm—and the human being who arrives there leaves it deserted only if he becomes, as it were, the island's own consciousness, the island dreaming itself. The survivors of *Lost* arrive aboard Oceanic Flight 815. They are oceanic in Deleuze's precise sense: thrown not onto a fragment of a continent they might rejoin but onto an origin from which, after catastrophe, a world must be begun again, and whose final keeper will be the one who learns to become its consciousness.

The airline's name carries a second sense. "Oceanic feeling" was Romain Rolland's phrase, in a letter to Freud, for the sensation of limitless union with the world that he took to be the wellspring of religion; Freud, opening *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930), diagnosed it as a survival of the infant's ego before its differentiation from the world. The finale will be judged by many viewers in exactly Freud's terms, as a regressive fantasy of union. The two senses of the word—the island of second origins and the feeling of boundless communion—are the two halves of the series' eschatology, and Chapter 9 argues that the series succeeds in holding them together.

The island has been, since antiquity, the West's preferred instrument for thinking. John R. Gillis's *Islands of the Mind* (2004) argues that the Atlantic world was imagined before it was mapped, and that its islands served as places to think with: sites of origin, isolation, testing, and paradise. Gillian Beer's essay "Discourses of the Island" (1989) traced the island's function as an emblem of the bounded self and the bounded nation. Mikhail Bakhtin's account of the "adventure-time" of the Greek romance—a time of shipwrecks, abductions, and sudden reversals from which the lovers' identity emerges unchanged by every trial ("Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel," 1937–1938)—describes the chronotope the castaway island inherits, and anticipates the question of constancy that Chapter 6 takes up. Elizabeth DeLoughrey's *Routes and Roots* (2007), together with Epeli Hau'ofa's essay "Our Sea of Islands" (1993), has shown how much violence the trope of the isolated island conceals: the Pacific, which Hau'ofa reconceived as a connected oceanic world, was repeatedly reduced by colonial science to a scatter of isolates suitable for experiment. Chapter 12 returns to that critique. The present chapter traces the trope's literary history, because *Lost* inherits all of it.

The four archipelagoes, their paradigm texts, and the exits the series refuses are summarized below.

Table 4 *The four archipelagoes*

Archipelago	Paradigm texts	Governing question	What *Lost* inherits	Exit refused
Castaway	*Odyssey*; *Robinson Crusoe* (1719); *The Swiss Family Robinson* (1812); *L'Île mystérieuse* (1874–1875); *The Coral Island* (1857); *Lord of the Flies* (1954); *The*	How does one survive, and how does one get home?	Salvage, labor, the footprint, the founding of a polity, the longing for return	Rescue and return

Archipelago	Paradigm texts	Governing question	What *Lost* inherits	Exit refused
	Stand (1978); *Vendredi* (1967); *Foe* (1986); *Cast Away* (2000)			
Utopian and laboratory	Plato's Atlantis; More's *Utopia* (1516); Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627); Swift's Laputa (1726); Wells's *Doctor Moreau* (1896); Skinner's *Walden Two* (1948); Huxley's *Island* (1962)	How should we live, and what can we know and make?	The hidden research polity, the island as laboratory, the Law, the conditioned subject	Salvation by method
Illusionist	*The Tempest* (c. 1611); Bioy Casares's *La invención de Morel* (1940); Fowles's *The Magus* (1965); Dick's *Time Out of Joint* (1959); Lem's *Solaris* (1961); *The Prisoner* (1967–1968); *The Truman Show* (1998)	What is real, and who is staging it?	The magus, the stage, the recorded image, the apparition, the watcher	The unmasking of the trick
Afterlife	Isles of the Blessed; the Irish *immrama* and the *Navigatio Sancti Brendani*; Avalon; Dante's *Purgatorio*; Vane's *Outward Bound* (1923); O'Brien's *The Third Policeman* (1967); Lewis's *The Great Divorce* (1945); *Jacob's Ladder* (1990); *The Others* (2001)	What becomes of us in dying?	The waiting place, the dead who do not know, judgment, recognition	The revelation that they were dead all along

The series' passage through these archipelagoes follows, in its dominant registers, the Pascalian sequence set out in the Introduction. The first season is a castaway narrative governed by the order of bodies. The seasons that disclose DHARMA, the Others, and the island of 1977 are utopian and laboratory narratives—the order of minds in its constructive mode, as making. The middle seasons are also, pervasively, narratives of illusion: staged camps, surveillance stations, conditioning rooms, flash-forwards that deceive the viewer about which way time is running—the order of minds in its critical mode, as unmasking. The sixth season enters the afterlife archipelago and, with it, the order of charity. The voyage is not strictly linear, and the archipelagoes overlap; but the sequence holds, and its terminus is the one archipelago whose exit the series does not merely refuse but transforms.

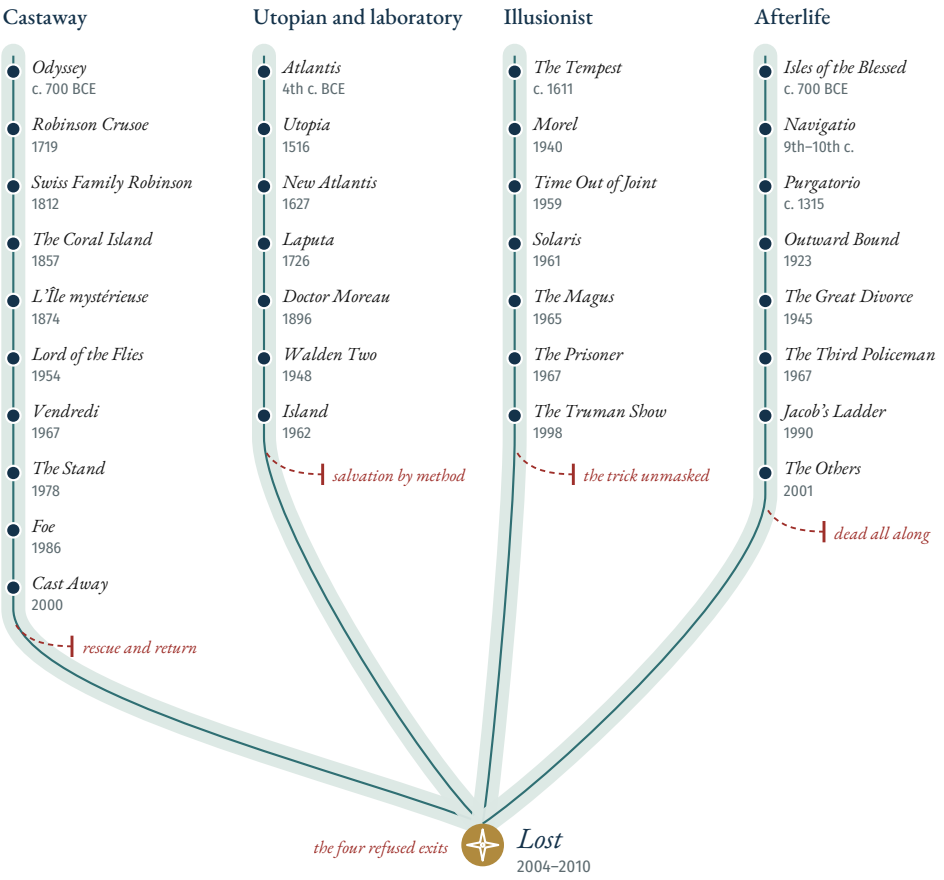


Figure 3 *The four archipelagoes (3.1). Each tradition flows toward the series, which inherits its devices and refuses its characteristic exit: rescue and return, salvation by method, the unmasking of the trick, the revelation that the dead were dead all along.*

3.2

The castaway archipelago

Homer and the divided Odysseus. The *Odyssey* is the first castaway narrative of the West, and *Lost* divides its hero in two. Odysseus spends seven years on Ogygia, which Athena describes as a sea-girt island "where is the navel of the sea" (*ὅθι τ' ὀμφαλός ἐστι θαλάσσης*, 1.50)—the same omphalic figure that Chapter 2 traced to the Foundation Stone. His keeper is Calypso, whose name derives from *kalyptō*, to conceal; she offers to make him "deathless and ageless all his days" (5.136; cf. 7.257), and he refuses, preferring a mortal wife and home. The poem first shows him sitting on the shore, weeping and gazing over the barren sea (5.81–84; 5.151–158); he leaves only when the gods command his release, on a raft he builds with his own

hands (5.234–261). His most famous trick is a name: he tells the Cyclops that he is called *Outis*, Nobody (9.366). The epithet of the poem's first line, *polytropos*, "of many turns," names his genius for disguise.

Every element of this complex reappears in the island's founding generation, and nearly all of it is assigned to the adversary. The Man in Black is the series' Nobody, the brother without a name. He is *polytropos* in the most literal sense: a shapeshifter. He is held on an island by a woman who conceals—Mother, whose lie that there is nothing across the sea is Calypso's concealment made into doctrine—and the defining image of "Across the Sea" (6.15) is the younger twin gazing over the water toward a home he has never seen. Like Odysseus he is a craftsman of escape: in his first life he digs wells and builds a wheel, and in his last he schemes toward an airplane and a submarine. But no Hermes is sent to secure his release; his *nostos* is to a mother's people he never knew; and he can leave only by killing. The one gift Calypso offered that he cannot obtain is the one Odysseus chose—mortality—and he receives it only when the Light is extinguished in "The End," receiving with it his death. The series' Odysseus, in other words, is its devil: the hero of cunning, craft, and homesickness becomes the adversary in an order where cunning is not the highest good.

The other half of Odysseus is Desmond Hume, whose beloved bears the name Penelope (Grade B). Desmond sails into a race around the world, is wrecked on the island, and spends three years confined in the Swan while Penny searches the world for him. Penelope is Homer's archetype of fidelity, and her signature stratagem is temporal: she weaves by day and unweaves by night the shroud of Laertes in order to hold off the suitors (2.93–110; 19.137–156; 24.128–146), suspending time by weaving it. When Desmond's consciousness comes unmoored in "The Constant" (4.05), the fixed point that holds him is Penelope; when the fourth season closes with their reunion at sea, under a title borrowed from Oz ("There's No Place Like Home," 4.12–4.14), the *nostos* is Homeric. Desmond is the Odysseus who has a Penelope; the Man in Black is the Odysseus who has none. The difference between them is the difference Chapter 6 calls constancy.

Calypso's refused gift goes to a third figure. Richard Alpert, taken from the hold of the *Black Rock*, asks Jacob that he might never die and receives agelessness—the Calypsan *agēraon*—which he spends nearly a century and a half serving and, by the final season, longing to be rid of. In "The End" he finds a gray hair, and mortality returns to him as grace. The series thus distributes the *Odyssey* across three men: Desmond receives homecoming, the Man in Black receives only death, and Richard receives Calypso's gift and then its revocation.

The Homeric presence is not merely structural. Jacob's tapestry in "The Incident" (5.16–5.17) bears across its head, in capitals, a Greek line from the *Odyssey*: *θεοὶ τόσα δοῖεν ὅσα φρεσὶ σῇσι μενοινᾷς*, "may the gods grant you all that your heart desires" (6.180) (Grade A). The line is Odysseus's blessing on Scheria, spoken by a shipwrecked man, naked and crusted with brine, to Nausicaa, the princess who has found him on the shore. It goes on to name the gifts it asks for: a husband, a home, and a noble like-mindedness (*homophrosynē*), for nothing is

better or stronger than when a man and a woman keep house together of one mind (6.180–185). Commentators read the blessing as programmatic for the whole poem: the bond Odysseus wishes for Nausicaa is the one he wins back on Ithaca, where the like-mindedness of husband and wife is tested and proved (Books 18–23). The series stages the same blessing in the flesh in the same episode, when Jacob appears at the reception after Sun and Jin's wedding and tells them, in fluent Korean, never to take each other or their love for granted. The wedding ring Sun gave Jin that day is engraved in Korean with the promise that they will never be apart, as the network's own materials for the 2010 auction of the series' props record. Between the wedding and the end the ring passes through other hands: Jin gives it to Locke as false proof of his death, and Ben takes it from the body of the man he has strangled and uses it to lure Sun back to the island. Yet it comes home to the hand it was promised to, and the series keeps the promise to the letter when Jin, unable to free Sun in the sinking submarine, tells her that he will not leave her again, and they drown together ("The Candidate," 6.14). The island's god weaves under a castaway's prayer for marriage. In Homer weaving belongs to two kinds of figure: to Penelope, who weaves in order to keep faith, and to the spinning powers of fate, who fix the measure of each life. The question at the core of the series' theology—whether Jacob's providence is fate or fidelity—is posed by the loom at which he works, and the inscription already leans toward the answer Chapters 5 and 7 defend. The line above the design is not a decree but a blessing, and what it blesses is the like-mindedness of two people, the good Chapter 6 calls constancy.

The line's place in the poem also extends the series' Pascalian frame. When Odysseus wakes on Scheria he asks to the land of what mortals he has come; the same line returns, word for word, when the Phaeacians carry him home asleep and set him down on Ithaca, where he wakes inside a mist the goddess has poured around him, so that his own country looks strange to him (6.119; 13.200). Ancient critics already disputed whether the mist disguised the man or the land: Aristophanes of Byzantium proposed reading 13.190 so that it is Ithaca that Athena makes unrecognizable to him. Even when Athena tells him where he is, he suspects her of mocking him and asks to be told truly whether he has reached his own country; only when she scatters the mist does the land appear (13.324–328, 352). The man carried asleep to an island who wakes not knowing where he is was Homer's before he was Pascal's, and in Homer the unrecognized shore is home. The scene anticipates, in the order of bodies, the consolation of the *Mystère de Jésus* with which this study ends: the one who seeks has already arrived.

Defoe and the economy of salvage. If Homer gives the series its archetypes, Defoe gives its first season its texture. Crusoe's first weeks are spent salvaging the wreck in repeated raft voyages; the survivors' first weeks are spent salvaging the fuselage and its luggage, and the moral economy of the camp forms around that salvage, from Sawyer's hoard of medicines, magazines, and paperbacks to the rationing of water. Crusoe, a merchant's son, takes stock of his condition in a ledger, setting down its evils against its goods in two columns "like Debtor and Creditor"; Marx, observing in *Capital* (vol. 1, ch. 1, §4) that Crusoe's experiences were a

favorite theme of the political economists, made him the paradigm of *homo oeconomicus*, and Ian Watt's *The Rise of the Novel* (1957) made him the founder of the novel's individualist realism. *Lost* answers Crusoe through Hurley. Charged in "Everybody Hates Hugo" (2.04) with inventorying the food stored in the Swan, Hurley fears what ownership will do to the community and resolves to dynamite the pantry rather than become its master; he ends by giving the food away to everyone in a single communal meal. The Crusoe of the ledger is replaced by the steward of the feast—an early sign of the custodial sovereignty the series will entrust to him.

Two further Defoean motifs organize the first season. The first is the footprint—"the Print of a Man's naked Foot on the Shore"—whose discovery throws Crusoe into terror of cannibals and inaugurates the Robinsonade's colonial fantasy of the savage. The survivors' Others are first imagined in exactly that register, and the DHARMA Initiative calls them "the Hostiles." The fantasy is gradually dismantled as the Others are revealed to possess a submarine, a book club, and a medical research program, though not, as Chapter 12 argues, without residue. The second motif is providential reading. Crusoe, sick and terrified, opens his Bible at random and finds Psalm 50:15: "Call on me in the Day of Trouble, and I will deliver, and thou shalt glorify me." The scene inaugurates the Puritan spiritual autobiography on which the novel is built. Locke's and Eko's habit of reading the island's signs as directions—down to the inscription on Eko's staff, with its paraphrase of the command to Abram to lift up his eyes and look north—is Crusoe's bibliomancy carried into a world whose scripture is the island itself.

Wyss, Verne, and the hidden benefactor. *The Swiss Family Robinson* (1812), Johann David Wyss's pedagogical idyll, converted Defoe's solitary into a family and the island into a garden of providential abundance, in which every need finds its plant or animal and every hardship its lesson. *Lost* retains the abundance—DHARMA's pallets of food fall from the sky ("Lockdown," 2.17), and the Swan's pantry is inexhaustible until it is shared—but it abolishes the family. No intact family steps off Oceanic 815. Rose and Bernard are separated by the fuselage's rupture; Michael and Walt are strangers; Sun and Jin are estranged; Claire is pregnant and alone; Shannon and Boone are step-siblings bound by a corrosive attachment. The series' castaways must invent kinship rather than carry it, and the families of the finale are chosen, not inherited.

Jules Verne's *L'Île mystérieuse* (1874–1875) provides the most precise structural precursor of the series' first five seasons. Five Northerners trapped in besieged Richmond escape by balloon in 1865 and are cast onto an uncharted Pacific island, which they name Lincoln Island and on which, under the engineer Cyrus Smith, they rebuild industrial civilization from first principles—Verne's hymn to applied reason. Throughout, inexplicable interventions preserve them: a pellet found in the flesh of a peccary, a chest of supplies washed ashore, a castaway's message in a bottle, a ladder restored to their cliff dwelling. The benefactor is at last revealed in a grotto beneath the island: Captain Nemo, dying aboard the *Nautilus*—Nemo,

"Nobody," the Latin of Odysseus's *Outis*, and in Verne's final disclosure Prince Dakkar, an Indian rebel against British rule. After his death a volcanic eruption destroys the island, and the colonists are rescued from the last rock above the sea. The correspondences are exact enough to be instructive: an unseen benefactor dwelling beneath the island; mysterious supplies; a community of the order of minds rebuilding civilization by engineering; an island whose destruction closes the narrative and whose ruins lie beneath the sea in the opening images of the flash-sideways ("LA X," 6.01–6.02). The decisive divergence concerns the name. In Verne the hidden benefactor is the nameless one; in *Lost* the hidden benefactor bears a name, and the nameless one is the deceiver. Homer's *Outis* and Verne's *Nemo* converge in the Man in Black, but the series assigns their namelessness to the adversary and their hidden providence to Jacob. The chiasmus is theological: in the order of charity, a name is not a mask but a vocation.

A further Vernian motif illuminates the island's unlocatability. *Les Enfants du capitaine Grant* (1867–1868) opens with a castaway's message in a bottle recovered from the belly of a shark, its text so damaged by seawater that only the latitude of the wreck can be read; the searchers circle the globe along the thirty-seventh parallel. The location of the castaways is legible in one coordinate only. *Lost*'s island can be found only by calculation—Eloise Hawking's equations at the Lamp Post ("316," 5.06)—and its only certain coordinate is time. The bottle returns as well: the letters the survivors entrust to the raft in "Exodus" (1.23–1.25) wash back onto the island's own beach in the second season, where they are found and quietly buried. Communication with the outside world returns to its senders.

Ballantyne, Golding, and the dead airman. R. M. Ballantyne's *The Coral Island* (1857) offered the Victorian schoolboy a cheerful imperial Robinsonade in which three boys—Ralph, Jack, and Peterkin—master a Pacific island and its "savages." William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) borrowed two of the names and inverted the premise: the boys' order decays into tribal violence, the deliberative assembly of the conch yields to the hunters led by Jack, and the beast the boys fear proves to be within them. The rescuing naval officer, surveying the ruin of their society, can only liken it to *The Coral Island*—Golding's bitter acknowledgment of the genre he was dismantling. The series names Golding's novel on screen, through Sawyer in the first season and again in the second, when Charlie remarks that the tail-section survivors had gone "all *Lord of the Flies*" (Grade A). *Lost* names its leader Jack and makes him not the hunter who seizes power but the surgeon who refuses it until, in "White Rabbit" (1.05), he founds the community under a maxim of cooperation. The series reverses Golding's Jack while retaining Golding's question.

The most striking Golding parallel concerns the beast itself. In *Lord of the Flies* the beast the twins see on the mountain is the corpse of an airman shot down in the war overhead, entangled in his parachute lines and lifted by the wind into a ghastly bowing motion; Simon, the boys' visionary, discovers that it is a dead man and is killed by the boys, who mistake him for the beast. In the pilot of *Lost* the Monster's first act is to drag the captain of Oceanic 815

from his cockpit; his body is found high in the trees (1.01). The beast that announces itself through a dead airman thereafter appears in the forms of the dead—Christian Shephard, Yemi, Alex, Locke. *Lost* holds together what Ballantyne and Golding separate. The Monster is a real external power, not a projection; but its weapon is the projection of each person's guilt. The beast is both outside and within.

King's ensemble apocalypse. The ensemble scale and the dualism of *Lost* descend most directly from Stephen King's *The Stand* (1978; expanded 1990), a novel its producers repeatedly named as a formative influence: Carlton Cuse called it, in many ways, the model for the show (January 2007), and in 2009 Lindelof and Cuse credited it with having shown them the way, for its character writing more than its mythology. After a pandemic, the scattered survivors are drawn into two communities: one gathered around the aged Mother Abagail, who is 108 years old in the expanded edition, and one around Randall Flagg, the shapeshifting "dark man" whom King later identified with the man in black pursued across a desert in the opening sentence of the *Dark Tower* cycle (*The Gunslinger*, 1982). The series' Mother and its Man in Black, its ensemble of strangers summoned into a cosmic contest, and its conviction that flawed, ordinary people are the stakes of a war between light and darkness are King's. King also appears on screen: the first scene of the third season shows Juliet's book club, in the Others' suburban barracks, debating his *Carrie* ("A Tale of Two Cities," 3.01). The decisive revision concerns the dualism. King's dark man is a cosmic adversary without a brother; *Lost* makes the darkness the light's twin, born of the same mother and wounded by the same household—a familial theodicy that Chapter 8 develops.

Tournier, Deleuze, and the structure of the possible. Michel Tournier's *Vendredi ou les limbes du Pacifique* (1967) rewrote Defoe as a philosophical novel whose subtitle names the Pacific as a limbo. Tournier's Robinson, alone, loses the depth of the perceptual world and must reconstruct his relation to things; when a ship arrives at last, he chooses to remain on the island, while Friday secretly departs aboard it and a runaway cabin boy stays behind with Robinson, who names him Thursday. In "Michel Tournier et le monde sans autrui," appended to *Logique du sens* (1969), Deleuze drew the novel's lesson: the Other (*autrui*) is not first another person but the a priori structure of the perceptual field—the guarantee that the unseen sides of things, the margins of the visible, the regions behind the hill, are possible objects of some perception. Without Others the world collapses into a flat and pitiless present. The antagonists of *Lost* are called the Others, and Deleuze's analysis explains their narrative function with uncanny exactness. For three seasons the Others *are* the structure of the possible: they see what the survivors cannot, know what lies beyond the jungle's edge, inhabit every unseen region of the island, and hold files on every survivor's past. The terror they inspire is the terror of the possible itself. Tournier's subtitle also anticipates the series' last season, in which the Pacific's limbo becomes literal: the flash-sideways is a *limbe* in the theological sense, a borderland of the waiting dead. And Tournier's Robinson, who refuses rescue, prefigures both Locke, who throws a knife into the back of the freighter's emissary to prevent

the rescue call in "Through the Looking Glass" (3.22–3.23), and the converted Jack, whose cry in the same episode's flash-forward—that they have to go back—announces that rescue was the error.

Coetzee and the castaway's voice. J. M. Coetzee's *Foe* (1986) restored to the Crusoe story the woman Defoe omitted. Susan Barton, cast away with Cruso and Friday, seeks to have her story written by the author Foe, who wishes to rewrite it as an adventure without her; Friday, whose tongue has been cut out, cannot tell his own. *Lost*'s Danielle Rousseau is a Susan Barton: a woman castaway whose testimony—a distress call looping unanswered for sixteen years—is heard at last only as an episode in other people's story. Friday's silence has its own correlate in a series set in the South Pacific that contains no Pacific Islander among its principal characters. Chapter 12 takes up that silence.

Cast Away, Survivor, and the founding maxim. The series' immediate commission, by its makers' account, was ABC executive Lloyd Braun's request for a drama combining Robert Zemeckis's *Cast Away* (2000) and the reality competition *Survivor*. Both left visible traces, and the series negated both. *Cast Away* ends with its castaway delivering a parcel, decorated with a pair of angel wings, that he carried unopened through four years of solitude—a mystery box never opened, whose contents the film declines to reveal—and its hero keeps a world in being by inventing an Other out of a volleyball. *Survivor*'s motto, "Outwit. Outplay. Outlast.," summarizes the competitive individualism of a format in which castaways vote one another off the island. Against it the series sets its founding maxim, pronounced by Jack in "White Rabbit" and repeated as the title of the second-season finale: those who will not live together will die alone. *Lost* begins as the negation of its own commissioning genre.

The exit refused: return. The castaway narrative ends in rescue, and rescue returns the castaway to the society from which he was cast out, chastened and enriched. Crusoe returns a man of property; Verne's colonists found a new Lincoln Island in Iowa with Nemo's jewels; Golding's boys are taken off by a warship. Joseph Campbell's monomyth (*The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949) codified the pattern as departure, initiation, and return with a boon. *Lost* grants its castaways their return and makes it a catastrophe. The fourth season's flash-forwards show the Oceanic Six at home—sustaining a lie, haunted, addicted, institutionalized, estranged. The boon cannot be carried off the island; the return must be reversed; and the series' Odyssean formula, borrowed from Oz in the title of the fourth-season finale, is made to mean its opposite. There is no place like home, and home is the island. Proust supplied the paradox in *Le Temps retrouvé* (1927): "les vrais paradis sont les paradis qu'on a perdus"—the true paradises are the paradises we have lost. The castaways of *Lost* discover that their paradise is the place of their loss.

3.3

The utopian and laboratory archipelago

Atlantis and the sunken island. Plato's Atlantis (*Timaeus* 24e–25d; *Critias* 113b–121c) is the archetype of the island as polity: an empire beyond the Pillars of Heracles, founded by a divine lineage, rich in metals and engineering, which in its pride assailed Athens and sank "in a single terrible day and night." The flash-sideways opens with an Atlantean image. The camera descends through the Pacific to the island's ruins on the seafloor, among them the DHARMA barracks, the remains of a utopia; and viewers first read the image as the consequence of the detonation that closed the fifth season, a technical *hubris* that drowned the island as Atlantis was drowned ("LA X," 6.01–6.02). The finale retrospectively transforms the image. The sunken island belongs to the world the dead have made in order to find one another, and its submersion signifies not punishment but completion: in the place where the lost are gathered, the island no longer needs to be kept. Plato's sunken island is the end of a polity; *Lost*'s is the end of a custody.

Utopia: severance, concealment, toleration. Thomas More's *Utopia* (1516) bequeathed three features to the island tradition, all of which the series retains. First, Utopia is an artificial island: its founder, Utopus, had the isthmus joining it to the mainland cut through, so that the good place is constituted by an act of severance. *Lost*'s island is severed not by a channel but by an anomaly; it lies outside maps and, at times, outside time. Second, Utopia's location is concealed by a joke. In his prefatory letter to Peter Giles, More explains that when Hythloday named the island's position a servant came to whisper in his ear and a companion who had caught cold aboard ship coughed so loudly that the words were lost. The one datum the text withholds is where the island is, and the island of *Lost*, which can be found only when it consents to be found, inherits that comic reticence as a metaphysical principle. The title's double etymology, *ou-topos* and *eu-topos*, no-place and good place, describes the series' island with precision: unlocatable, and the place where, as Christian Shephard tells his son in the finale, the most important part of their lives was spent.

Third, Utopia practices religious toleration. King Utopus decreed that each citizen might follow the religion he chose and seek to persuade others by reason alone; and although the Utopians worship in many ways, they agree on a single supreme being whom, More reports, they call in their own tongue Mithras. Their common temples are kept dim, so that the mind may be more intent on devotion, and contain no images of the gods, so that each may conceive the divine according to his own religion. The finale's church, whose stained glass gathers the emblems of several traditions around a single light, is a Utopian temple. Chapter 2 argued that the window relocates the Mosaic distinction from between religions to within persons; More had already imagined a polity in which the religions are many and the light is one.

Bensalem and the Merchants of Light. The closest Renaissance precursor of the DHARMA Initiative is Francis Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627). Its narrator's ship sails from

Peru "for China and Japan, by the South Sea"—that is, across the Pacific—and, becalmed and starving, comes upon Bensalem, an island unknown to the world that knows the world perfectly. Bensalem's Christianity arrived by miracle: some twenty years after the Ascension, a great pillar of light rose from the sea, crowned by a cross of light, and beside it floated a small ark of cedar containing the Scriptures. Its learning is organized in Salomon's House, a research foundation whose purpose its Father defines in the sentence that became the charter of modern science: "The End of our Foundation is the knowledge of Causes, and secret motions of things; and the enlarging of the bounds of Human Empire, to the effecting of all things possible." Among its fellows are twelve who travel abroad under the names of other nations to gather knowledge; Bacon calls them Merchants of Light.

Lost reproduces Bensalem in two institutions. The DHARMA Initiative, according to the Swan's orientation film ("Orientation," 2.03), was conceived in 1970 by two doctoral candidates at the University of Michigan and funded by the Danish industrialist Alvar Hanso as a communal research compound in which scientists and free thinkers could pursue meteorology, psychology, parapsychology, zoology, electromagnetism—and, as the film cuts away in mid-phrase, "utopian social" something (Grade A). The cut is the series' most explicit generic signature: DHARMA is a utopia whose definition has been edited out of its own founding document. Translators felt the gap and filled it: the Spanish-language version completes the phrase as "utopian social engineering," and the dubbing studio joined the scribes of Chapter 11. The Others, for their part, are Bensalem's secret polity. They know the world—they possess a submarine, a front company, files on every survivor, and, in "The Glass Ballerina" (3.02), a recording of the 2004 World Series with which Ben proves to Jack that the outside world goes on—while the world does not know them. Their recruiters are Merchants of Light. When Richard Alpert visits the child John Locke in "Cabin Fever" (4.11) with a set of objects and asks which of them already belongs to him, the test he administers is the one by which Tibetan lineages recognize a reincarnate teacher among children who must identify their predecessor's possessions; Locke chooses the knife, and Richard leaves disappointed.

Bacon's foundation aims at "the effecting of all things possible." Jacob's tapestry, as noted above, asks the gods to grant what the heart desires. The difference is that between technique and blessing: the Baconian program transfers to a human institution a power that Homer's castaway could only pray the gods to exercise, and *Lost* stages both the transfer and its price. DHARMA drills toward the electromagnetic pocket beneath the Swan site and releases the energy whose catastrophic discharge the button must thereafter avert; the Initiative itself is annihilated in the Purge, gassed by the Others, among them Ben, who personally kills his own father ("The Man Behind the Curtain," 3.20). Salomon's House ends in a mass grave.

Laputa, Glubbdubdrib, Luggnagg. The satirical counter-tradition reaches its summit in the third book of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), and Swift's archipelago anticipates the series with startling literalness. Laputa is a flying island moved by a lodestone of prodigious size set at its center, whose attractive and repulsive poles, inclined by the island's astronomers, steer it over

the kingdom below; its king wields its mobility as an instrument of sovereignty, hovering over rebellious towns to deprive them of sun and rain. Its inhabitants are so absorbed in mathematics that servants must strike them with bladders to rouse them to conversation, and the Academy of Lagado below pursues projects such as extracting sunbeams from cucumbers. *Lost*'s island is likewise moved by its magnetic heart: in "There's No Place Like Home" (4.12–4.14) Ben descends to the frozen chamber beneath the Orchid station and turns the wheel that displaces the island in space and time—a sovereign act, performed to place the island beyond the reach of Widmore's mercenaries. The Initiative's absorption in its equation—in the paracanonical archive, the Valenzetti Equation, whose core factors are the Numbers and whose solution predicts the date of human extinction—is Laputan.

Swift's next islands complete the correspondence. On Glubbdubdrib, the island of sorcerers, the governor summons the dead to converse with Gulliver, who interrogates Homer, Aristotle, Descartes, and the great men of history and learns how much the historians have lied; the dead correct the record. The island of *Lost* is a Glubbdubdrib. Hurley speaks with the dead; Miles Straume hears the last thoughts of corpses; and in the sideways the dead, remembering, at last correct the record of their own lives. On Luggnagg, Gulliver meets the Struldbrugs, born immortal but not exempt from aging, who decline into decrepitude, are declared legally dead at eighty, and become objects of universal horror—Swift's refutation of the wish for endless life. Richard Alpert's gift is the converse, agelessness without invulnerability, but its lesson converges with Swift's: after Jacob's death Richard, convinced that his long life has been meaningless, goes to the wrecked slave ship on which he arrived intending to die and, because Jacob's gift prevents him from taking his own life, asks Jack to light the dynamite for him ("Dr. Linus," 6.07). Both texts teach the Pascalian point that the wish to escape time is a wish to escape the human condition, and that its fulfillment is misery.

Moreau, Skinner, and the conditioned animal. H. G. Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) is narrated by a shipwrecked castaway who discovers on a Pacific island a vivisector carving animals into the semblance of men. Moreau's Beast Folk are held in their humanity by a litany of prohibitions intoned by the Sayer of the Law—"Not to go on all-Fours; that is the Law. Are we not Men?"—and by the memory of the House of Pain; when Moreau dies, the Law loses its force and the Beast Folk revert. The series' Hydra station, where polar bears are kept on a tropical island, is Moreau's laboratory, and the third season opens by caging Sawyer there ("A Tale of Two Cities," 3.01): he is shocked until he learns to work the lever that dispenses a fish biscuit, and Tom observes that the bears solved the puzzle far faster. The cage is a Skinner box made literal. B. F. Skinner's *Walden Two* (1948) imagined a utopian community engineered by positive reinforcement; the Swan's button is a Skinnerian schedule, a lever pressed at a fixed interval whose reinforcement is the deferral of catastrophe. In "?" (2.21) the Pearl's orientation film suggests that the button was merely a psychological experiment, its compliance recorded in notebooks dispatched through a pneumatic tube that empties into a heap of unread canisters in the jungle. Locke's despair at this discovery is the despair of the

order of minds' suspicion. The series refutes the suspicion: when the button is not pushed, Oceanic 815 falls ("Live Together, Die Alone," 2.23–2.24). The ritual was real.

Moreau's island also supplies the law of the lawgiver's death. The Others live by rules—Jacob's rules, the rules by which the brothers cannot kill each other, the rules that, in Ben's words, Widmore "changed" when his mercenary killed Alex (4.09)—and when Jacob is killed ("The Incident," 5.16–5.17) the polity bound by those rules disintegrates: the Temple is massacred ("Sundown," 6.06), Sayid is "claimed," and Claire has become a feral Rousseau. The death of the lawgiver dissolves the Law and the humanity it sustained. Moreau's island after Moreau is the island after Jacob.

Pala and the surgeon. The last great utopian novel of the century, Aldous Huxley's *Island* (1962), describes Pala, an island state founded on a synthesis of Mahayana Buddhism, tantra, and Western science, whose citizens take a psychedelic "moksha-medicine" and whose forests are full of mynah birds trained to cry "Attention" and "Here and now." The cry anticipated by nearly a decade the title of the historical Richard Alpert's *Be Here Now*. Pala's founding is a surgical miracle: in the nineteenth century a Scottish surgeon, Dr. Andrew MacPhail, removed a tumor from the face of the island's Raja under mesmeric anesthesia, and the two men together founded the Palanese synthesis. At the novel's end Pala is invaded and destroyed by a neighboring military ruler backed by oil interests. DHARMA is Pala—countercultural Orientalism allied to science, a utopia of mind-research greeting its members with *Namaste*, destroyed by an armed neighbor. And *Lost* restages Pala's founding scene as its antithesis. In the third season Ben, the island's ruler, brings a surgeon to the island to remove the tumor on his spine; but Jack turns the operation into a hostage negotiation, cutting into Ben's kidney sac and demanding the release of Kate and Sawyer ("I Do," 3.06). Huxley's surgery founds a utopia; Jack's extorts a ransom. The utopian archipelago's founding miracle has become an instrument of coercion.

The exit refused: method. If the castaway's salvation is return, the utopian's is method: a polity constructed by reason, a nature mastered by science. *Lost* destroys its laboratories one by one, and by their own instruments. DHARMA's drilling produces the Incident, and its utopia ends in the Purge. The Others' Bensalem is undone by the ambition of its leader and annihilated in the Temple. Widmore's expedition—capital's laboratory, equipped with a physicist, a medium, an anthropologist, and mercenaries—ends when the freighter explodes offshore (4.12–4.14). Each fails because method cannot produce what the island requires. Pascal's sentence applies with full force: from all bodies and minds together one could not draw a single movement of true charity. DeLoughrey's critique applies as well. The "island laboratory" is a colonial figure, rehearsed in the scientific appropriation of Pacific islands as isolates and fulfilled in the nuclear tests at Bikini and Enewetak; the series places its own hydrogen bomb, "Jughead," on the island in 1954, the year of the Castle Bravo test ("Jughead," 5.03). The utopian archipelago of *Lost* is built upon a history of the Pacific that the series names but does not examine.

3.4

The illusionist archipelago

The Tempest: magus, mother, and abjuration. Shakespeare's last solo play gives the island of illusion its classical form, and its roles are distributed across *Lost* as the *Odyssey*'s were. Prospero raises a storm to wreck the ship carrying the men who wronged him, ensures through Ariel that "Not a hair perish'd" (I.ii.217), scatters the survivors across the island, and tests each of them by enchantments designed to bring them to repentance. The island's former sovereign was the witch Sycorax, who imprisoned the spirit Ariel in a cloven pine for twelve years (I.ii.274–281) and whose son, Caliban, contests Prospero's rule by maternal right: "This island's mine, by Sycorax my mother, / Which thou tak'st from me" (I.ii.331–332). Mother is the series' Sycorax: a prior female sovereign of uncanny powers, whose son claims a birthright and is confined by the rule that succeeds her. The Man in Black is a Caliban who wants not the island but its exit. Richard Alpert is Ariel: chained in the hold of the *Black Rock* as Ariel was locked in the pine, freed from his chains—by the Man in Black, in a reversal the play could not have imagined—and then bound to the magus's service as messenger and intermediary, yearning like Ariel for his liberty. His gray hair in the finale is Prospero's last word to Ariel: "Then to the elements / Be free, and fare thou well!" (V.i.317–318). Jacob is Prospero in his providential aspect, the magus who brings the shipwrecked to his island by design and watches them from afar. Ben is Prospero in his manipulative aspect, "the man behind the curtain" (3.20). Widmore, exiled from the island he once ruled and plotting his return, is Prospero the deposed duke, and his daughter Penelope, whom he would keep from the man she loves, is a Miranda whose Ferdinand is unwelcome.

The play's ethic is the series' ethic of trial. Prospero renounces revenge for its rarer alternative—"The rarer action is / In virtue than in vengeance" (V.i.27–28)—and Jacob, in "Ab Aeterno" (6.09), explains that he brings people to the island to prove his brother wrong: to show that they can choose the good without his intervention. The island's ordeals, like Prospero's, aim at repentance rather than punishment. The play also furnishes the series' resolution of sovereignty. Prospero abjures his art: "this rough magic / I here abjure… I'll break my staff, / Bury it certain fathoms in the earth, / And deeper than did ever plummet sound / I'll drown my book" (V.i.50–57). In the final hours of "The End," the newly anointed Hurley confesses that he does not know how to rule, and Ben suggests that Jacob's way of ruling need not be his—that there may be a better way. Hurley's custody, which begins by sending Desmond home, is the drowning of the book. Chapter 7 develops this abjuration as the culmination of the series' political theology.

The epilogue completes the analogy. Prospero, his charms o'erthrown, asks the audience to release him: "As you from crimes would pardon'd be, / Let your indulgence set me free." The magus who has staged an island for five acts ends as a petitioner, dependent on the audience's mercy and prayer. Every serial finale is such an epilogue, and Chapter 11 reads the reception of

Lost's as an audience's refusal of indulgence. Prospero also supplies the image that brackets the series: "We are such stuff / As dreams are made on, and our little life / Is rounded with a sleep" (IV.i.156–158). The life of *Lost* is rounded by an eye that opens and an eye that closes.

Morel's machine. Adolfo Bioy Casares's *La invención de Morel* (1940), which Sawyer is seen reading in "Eggtown" (4.04) (Grade A), is the twentieth century's purest island of illusion. The same episode puts a second novel on screen: Locke takes Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981) from Ben's own shelf and gives it to him in his cell in the basement of Ben's own house; when Ben says flatly that he has already read it, Locke answers that he might catch something he missed the second time around, and Ben is later seen reading it again ("The Other Woman," 4.06). *VALIS* is Dick's novel of a Gnostic revelation, and its mechanism is the one Chapter 9 finds in the sideways: Dick held that the divine signal works through disinhibiting stimuli that trigger the recollection of knowledge already possessed, a recovery from forgetting that is at once anamnesis and gnosis. A fugitive sentenced to life imprisonment hides on a deserted island in the Pacific, where a party of elegant visitors appears, ignores him, and repeats its conversations with uncanny exactness. He falls in love with one of them, Faustine. He discovers that the visitors are images projected by a machine their host, Morel, invented to record a week of their lives and replay it forever, powered by the tides—and that the recording killed those it recorded. He records himself, dying into the loop so as to stand forever beside Faustine's image. Borges, in his prologue, judged the plot perfect and praised the book as a triumph of reasoned imagination. Its devices saturate *Lost*: Rousseau's distress call, looping for sixteen years; DHARMA's orientation films, replaying for successive viewers the instructions of a vanished regime; and the Monster's apparitions of the dead, images that speak with familiar voices but are not those they show. Above all, the flash-sideways is constructed as a Morel loop: a world in which the dead perform provisional versions of their lives without knowing what they are. But Morel's images cannot wake, and the fugitive joins them only by surrendering consciousness. The sideways is an anti-Morel. Its images wake, remember, and leave the loop together. Bioy imagines eternal life as repetition without recognition; the series imagines it as the recognition that ends repetition.

The godgame. John Fowles's *The Magus* (1965; revised 1977) moves the illusionist island to the Aegean. Nicholas Urfe, a young English teacher on the island of Phraxos, is drawn into an escalating sequence of masques, impersonations, and staged scenes devised by the wealthy recluse Maurice Conchis—a "godgame," in Fowles's working title, designed to strip Nicholas of his illusions about himself. The Others conduct the same theater. Their primitive camp, as the second-season finale reveals, is a stage set, complete with costumes and false beards; Ben's imposture as "Henry Gale" is a sustained performance; Room 23 is a theater of conditioning; the Pearl watches the watchers. *Lost* is pervaded by the vocabulary of the con—"Confidence Man" (1.08), "The Long Con" (2.13)—and by the figure of the impostor. Its cosmos, moreover, is a godgame in the strict sense. Jacob and his brother play a game with rules; the pilot's backgammon board, with its two players and two sides, light and dark, announces it,

and the senet board on which the younger brother learns to dream of rules of his own confirms it.

Time out of joint. Philip K. Dick's *Time Out of Joint* (1959) offers the closest analogue to the Swan. Ragle Gumm, a man in a small American town, wins a newspaper contest every day by predicting where a little green man will appear next. Gradually the town's seams show—a soft-drink stand dissolves into a slip of paper bearing the words "soft-drink stand"—and Gumm learns that his town is a fabrication built around him decades after the era it imitates, because his daily solutions are in fact predictions of where enemy missiles will strike. A repeated daily task, whose real purpose is concealed, performed by a man whose world has been constructed around the task: this is Desmond in the Swan. The DHARMA barracks, a 1970s suburb set in a tropical jungle, is a Dickian simulacrum, and the Others who live there in 2004, with their book club and their muffins, inhabit its afterimage. Yet the series inverts Dick at the decisive point. In Dick the ordinary world is the illusion and the hidden purpose is real; in *Lost* the Pearl offers a Dickian revelation—the button is only an experiment—and the revelation is the illusion. The unmasking is unmasked.

Solaris and the visitors. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) is set not on an island but on a station hovering above an oceanic planet, and it provides the most exact model for the Monster's apparitions. The planet's ocean materializes "visitors" drawn from the most guilt-laden memories of the scientists who study it; the psychologist Kris Kelvin is visited by his wife, Harey, years after she killed herself when he walked out on her, in a form that does not know what it is. The man who shared the Swan with Desmond is named Kelvin Inman (Grade C). The Monster likewise appears to each person as the figure of his guilt: to Jack as his father, to Eko as the brother whose death his crimes occasioned, to Ben as the daughter whose death he permitted. Lem also invented modern fiction's most mordant satire of interpretation—*Solaristics*, a century-long library of rival hypotheses about the ocean, none confirmed—an uncanny prophecy of the encyclopedic exegesis that would grow around *Lost* (Chapter 11). The difference between the two oceans is instructive. Lem's ocean is opaque even to itself; its visitors are produced without evident intention. The island's Monster knows exactly what it shows, to whom, and why. Its apparitions are rhetoric.

The Village and the dome. Two screen fictions complete the archipelago. *The Prisoner* (1967–1968) confined a resigned agent in the Village, a seaside resort that is also a prison, whose numbered inhabitants are governed by a succession of administrators, each called Number Two, on behalf of a Number One whom no one has seen; escapees are pursued by Rover, a roaring white sphere that smothers them. The Others' leaders succeed one another—Widmore, Ben, Locke—in the name of an unseen Jacob, and the Monster, which Rousseau calls a security system, is the island's Rover. *The Prisoner*'s final episode, "Fall Out," unmasked Number One as a figure wearing an ape's mask over the prisoner's own face and was received with such fury that Patrick McGoohan is reported to have gone into hiding; it is the first great precedent for the reception of "The End." *The Truman Show* (1998) built an

island town, Seahaven, inside a television dome, made its hero fear the water by staging his father's drowning, and ended with Truman sailing into the painted sky until his bow strikes the wall and he climbs a staircase to a door marked EXIT. The Man in Black's yearning toward the edge of the sea, the Pearl's monitors, and the mirrors of the lighthouse through which Jacob watched the candidates belong to this genealogy. But in *The Truman Show* the exit leads from illusion into reality. In *Lost* the exit leads the other way: if the Man in Black leaves, Mother warns, the Light goes out everywhere. The island is not the set; it is the most real place in the world.

The exit refused: unmasking. The illusionist archipelago ends when the magus is unmasked, the machine explained, the dome pierced. *Lost* unmasks repeatedly, and each unmasking discloses another mask. Ben, the man behind the curtain, is revealed never to have seen Jacob; the cabin to which he leads Locke holds an empty chair and a voice that the final season implies was not Jacob's (3.20). Jacob, once revealed, is himself bound by rules he did not make and by an office he inherited from a woman who lied to him. The Man in Black, master of masks, has no face of his own, and his last face is borrowed from a corpse. At the bottom of the regress of magi there is no final director—no Christof, no Morel, no Number One—but a light that no one in the series made. The unmasking finds not a trick but a mystery, in Rudolf Otto's sense of the numinous (*Das Heilige*, 1917): a *mysterium tremendum*, embodied in the Monster's terror, and *fascinans*, embodied in the Light's attraction. Where the illusionist tradition demystifies, *Lost* remystifies the real.

3.5

The afterlife archipelago

Islands of the blessed. The oldest afterlife islands of the West are rewards. Hesiod settles the heroes of the fourth race, after death, on the Islands of the Blessed beside deep-eddying Ocean, where the grain-giving earth bears honey-sweet fruit three times a year (*Works and Days* 167–173). Proteus promises Menelaus that he will not die in Argos but be sent to the Elysian plain at the ends of the earth, where life is easiest for men—no snow, no storm, no rain, but always the clear west wind sent up by Ocean—because he is the husband of Helen and son-in-law of Zeus (*Odyssey* 4.561–569). Pindar reserves the island for those who have three times, in this world and the next, kept their souls from all injustice (*Olympian* 2.68–77). Lucian's *True History* parodied the tradition in the second century. On the Island of the Blessed its narrator meets Homer and puts to him the questions the scholars could not settle —where he was born, whether he wrote the disputed lines, why he began the *Iliad* with the wrath of Achilles—and is told that the opening simply came into the poet's head (II.20). The afterlife island is the place where the reader may at last interrogate the author, and where the author's answers disappoint. Chapter 11 finds that scene restaged at Comic-Con.

The Irish otherworld voyages, the *immrama*, introduced the time differential the series literalizes. In the *Voyage of Bran*, a companion who leaps ashore on returning to Ireland

crumbles into ashes, as though he had been dead for centuries; Oisín returns from Tír na nÓg, the land of youth, after what seemed three years, touches the ground, and becomes in an instant an old man. Charlotte's and Desmond's dislocations, the fatal disorientation of the freighter's crew, and Richard's sudden gray hair belong to this lineage. The *Navigatio Sancti Brendani* (ninth or tenth century) sends Brendan and his monks on a seven-year liturgical voyage among islands that recur each year at the same feasts: an island that proves to be a whale, on whose back they celebrate Easter; an island of birds who are spirits that fell with Lucifer without consenting to his sin and who sing the canonical hours; a rock on which Judas is granted respite from hell on Sundays and feast days; and at last the Promised Land of the Saints. The voyage is cyclical and liturgical, like the Swan's 108-minute office. Brendan's island also survived in the Atlantic imagination as San Borondón, the phantom isle sighted from the western Canaries and sought by expeditions from the sixteenth to the eighteenth centuries, which appeared and vanished and could be reached by no one who sought it. Richard Alpert is a native of Tenerife ("Ab Aeterno," 6.09) (Grade C). The man from the Canaries is carried to an island that, like the phantom of his homeland, can be found only when it wills.

Herman Melville's "The Encantadas, or Enchanted Isles" (1854) supplies the phantom island's desolate counterpart. Melville explains the Spanish name of the Galápagos by the apparent fleetingness of their location: eddying currents and calms made the islands seem to drift, so that ships could not find them where they had been charted. His most famous sketch concerns Hunilla, a widow left alone on one of the islands after her husband and brother drowned within sight of the shore, who waits for months for a ship that had promised to return and never does. The unlocatable island and the abandoned woman belong together in Melville as they do in the series, whose first castaway, Danielle Rousseau, broadcasts for sixteen years a signal that no one answers (Chapter 12).

Arthurian Avalon, the Isle of Apples to which the wounded king is borne for healing in Geoffrey of Monmouth (*Historia regum Britanniae*; *Vita Merlini*), adds the motifs of the healing island and the promised return. The island of *Lost* heals Locke's legs and Rose's cancer, kills the women who conceive there, and gives Ben a tumor. Its healing is selective, a sign of vocation rather than a reward. And the epitaph Malory records for Arthur—*rex quondam rexque futurus*, the once and future king—is parodied by the return of Locke, whose body is carried back to the island in a coffin while a figure wearing his face walks among the Others as their new leader. The once and future Locke is not Locke.

Dante's island. The master text of the afterlife archipelago is the *Purgatorio*. Dante's purgatory is an island-mountain in the uninhabited ocean of the southern hemisphere, antipodal to Jerusalem; it was formed, the *Inferno* explains, from the earth that recoiled from Lucifer's fall (*Inf.* 34.121–126). The mountain of purgation exists because of the adversary's fall, and its summit is Eden. The island of *Lost* is likewise defined by its relation to the adversary—it is the bottle that holds him—and it is likewise the place where flawed people are brought to be

changed, with an Eden in its caves and a luminous water at its heart. The viewers' purgatory hypothesis, false of the island's ontology, was true of its function.

Two Dantean figures sharpen the parallel. The first is Ulysses (*Inf.* 26). Urging his crew past the Pillars of Hercules with the most famous speech in the poem—"fatti non foste a viver come bruti, / ma per seguir virtute e canoscenza" (you were not made to live as brutes, but to pursue virtue and knowledge, 26.119–120)—he sails west and south for five months until he sees "una montagna, bruna / per la distanza" (a mountain, dark with distance, 26.133–134), and a whirlwind born of the new land sinks his ship "infin che 'l mar fu sovra noi richiuso" (until the sea closed over us, 26.142). The order of minds can see the mountain but not reach it. Every expedition of knowledge in *Lost* is Ulyssean: Rousseau's scientific team, destroyed upon arrival; DHARMA; Widmore's freighter, which explodes within sight of the island it was sent to seize. The second figure is Cato of Utica, a pagan and a suicide, whom Dante makes the guardian of purgatory's shore (*Purg.* 1–2). The keeper of the Christian threshold is an anomaly, a figure outside the economy he guards. *Lost*'s keepers are likewise outside the confessions their island gathers: Mother, a nameless woman who speaks Latin; Jacob, a weaver without a church; Hurley, a lottery winner discharged from a psychiatric hospital. At Cato's command Virgil washes Dante's face with dew and girds him with a reed, the plant of humility (*Purg.* 1.94–136); Jacob plunges Richard into the sea (6.09). The rites of the threshold are rites of water. Dante's summit, with its twin rivers of forgetting and good remembrance, Lethe and Eunoë, is the subject of Chapter 9.

The ferry of the dead. Arnold Böcklin's *Isle of the Dead* (five versions, 1880–1886), in which a rowing boat bears a white-shrouded figure and a draped coffin toward a rocky island of cypresses, fixed the island as the destination of the dead in the modern imagination; Rachmaninoff set it to music in 1909. Ajira Flight 316, carrying John Locke's coffin back to the island ("316," 5.06), is a Böcklin crossing—and the dead man it carries will not rise, though another will wear his face.

Sutton Vane's play *Outward Bound* (1923) supplied the modern template for a vessel of the unknowing dead. Its passengers, aboard a fog-bound liner with no crew but a steward, gradually realize that they are dead and that an Examiner—a former clergyman—will judge them on arrival; two of them, a young couple who attempted suicide together, hang suspended between life and death, and their steward, himself a suicide, is condemned to sail the route forever. The flash-sideways begins aboard Oceanic 815, in flight, its passengers apparently alive and wholly unaware, and the plane lands safely in Los Angeles: a vessel of the dead who do not know they are dead ("LA X," 6.01–6.02). Ambrose Bierce's "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" (1890), in which a hanged man's escape proves to be the fantasy of the instant before death, established the twist that a vast literature and cinema has since repeated: *Carnival of Souls* (1962), *Jacob's Ladder* (1990), *The Sixth Sense* (1999), and Alejandro Amenábar's *The Others* (2001), whose protagonists are ghosts who mistake the living for intruders—"the others" of the title—in a film released three years before the series introduced its own. *Jacob's*

Ladder bears particular attention. Its title is Genesis 28; its dying protagonist is told, in a speech the film attributes to Meister Eckhart, that the devils who tear one's life away become angels freeing one from the earth once one has made peace; and it ends with his dead son leading him up a staircase into light. *Lost*'s finale reverses the generations—the dead father leads the son—but keeps the staircase of recognition, the light, and the doctrine of release.

Two novels of the afterlife hold a privileged place. Flann O'Brien's *The Third Policeman* (written 1939–1940; published 1967), shown in the Swan in "Orientation" (2.03) (Grade A), follows a narrator killed by his accomplice's bomb who wanders a hellish parish of policemen, bicycles, and eternity without knowing he is dead; the novel ends where it began, its narrator approaching the same barracks with no memory of having been there before. Craig Wright, who co-wrote the episode, told the *Chicago Tribune* that readers of the novel would have more material with which to theorize about the series, and in the following weeks it sold some ten thousand additional copies in the United States. The choice had a further aptness: when publishers rejected the manuscript in 1940, O'Brien told friends that it had been lost, and the novel appeared only after his death. C. S. Lewis's *The Great Divorce* (1945) sends a busload of ghosts from a grey town to the outskirts of heaven, where the Solid People—persons they knew in life—come to meet them and invite them onward; most refuse and return. Its guide, George MacDonald, explains that heaven, once attained, works backward, so that the saved will find their whole past to have been heaven and the lost theirs to have been hell. O'Brien and Lewis mark the two poles of the afterlife archipelago. In O'Brien the dead repeat without recognition, and the end returns to the beginning as a sentence; in Lewis the dead are met by those they knew, and the end transfigures the beginning as a grace.

The exit refused: the dead-all-along twist. The afterlife archipelago's characteristic exit is a *subtractive* revelation: what we took for life was death, dream, or limbo, and the reveal withdraws reality from the narrative already seen. Bierce's hanged man never escaped; O'Brien's narrator was never alive in the parish; Jacob Singer never left Vietnam; the family of *The Others* were themselves the intruders. The most persistent fan theory of *Lost*—that the survivors died in the crash and the island was purgatory—belonged to this archipelago, and the series killed it in its first hour by feeding Gary Troup, whose name is an anagram of "purgatory," to the jet engine. In the sixth season the series appeared to resurrect the theory, and then inverted it. In the church, Christian Shephard tells his son that everything that happened to him was real, that the people gathered there are real, and that some of them died before him and some long after ("The End"). The sideways is not the truth of the island but its sequel. Its revelation is *additive*: it withdraws no reality from what was lived but adds eternity to it. Lewis, not Bierce, governs the finale. The commonest error in the series' reception—the belief that the finale revealed the castaways to have been dead all along—mistook an additive revelation for a subtractive one, reading *Lost* as one more voyage to the island of the dead when it had transformed the genre's terminal twist into its opposite.

3.6

Coda: *demeurer*

Pascal traced "tout le malheur des hommes" to a single cause: "de ne savoir pas demeurer en repos, dans une chambre" (L136/B139)—not knowing how to remain at rest in a room. The four exits of the island tradition are four forms of what Pascal called *divertissement*, four ways of fleeing the room: return, which flees the island toward home; method, which flees the human condition toward mastery; unmasking, which flees mystery toward explanation; and the dream of death, which flees history toward a twist that would cancel it. *Lost* contains Pascal's room literalized. The Swan is a chamber in which a man must remain, performing every 108 minutes an act whose meaning he cannot verify. Desmond endures it for three years—in a room where an earlier keeper, Stuart Radzinsky, had shot himself, and where Desmond himself came to the brink of doing the same—flees it, sails for days in what he believes is a straight line, and is returned by the sea to the island he tried to leave ("Live Together, Die Alone"). The island does not permit *divertissement*.

The series' alternative to the four exits is a single verb. The French *demeurer* descends from the Latin *demorari*, to linger or tarry; its spiritual sense is that of the Johannine *menein*, to abide: "Abide in me, and I in you" (John 15:4). The protector abides. Those who leave must come back. Hurley remains on the island and keeps it; Ben remains outside the church, on a bench, with things still to work out; Desmond is to be sent home because someone stays. The voyage through the four archipelagoes is thus a narrative *via negativa*, closing every door through which prior fiction let its islanders leave until only one remains: to stay, to keep, and to remember. The chapters of Part II give these three verbs their names—constancy, custody, and anamnesis—and begin with the quarrel that occupies the series' middle seasons: the dispute between a man of science and a man of faith over whether to push a button in a room.

Part II

Axes

4 *The Hatch and the Wager*

5 *Chronosophy*

6 *Constancy*

7 *Custody*

8 *The Twins and the Light*

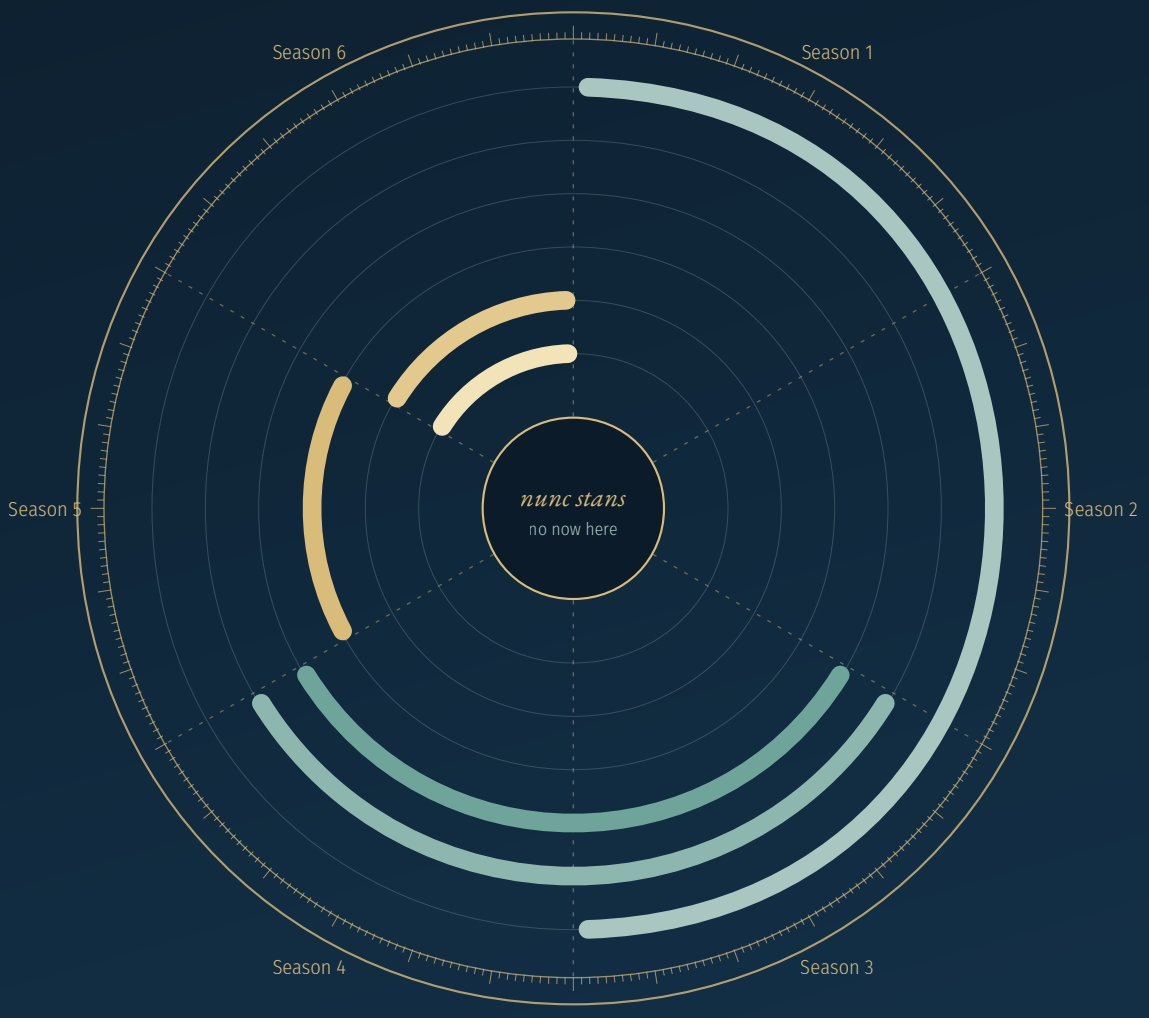
9 *Anamnesis*



Plate II

The six times of the series

Each ring a temporal regime; its arc spans the seasons it governs (5.1)



Flashback
memoria; Walkabout, 1.04

Flash-forward
expectatio; Through the Looking Glass, 3.22–3.23

Displaced consciousness
distentio animi; The Constant, 4.05

Physical time travel
Novikov's closed loops; The Incident, 5.16–5.17

Mythic flashback
illud tempus; Across the Sea, 6.15

Flash-sideways
aevum: the eternal present; The End, 6.17–6.18

Chapter 4

The Hatch and the Wager

Faith, Reason, and Discernment

The antithesis by which *Lost* is most often summarized—the man of science against the man of faith—is a Pascalian false dichotomy, and the series resolves it in a third term that neither of its champions possesses until the end. That term is *discernment*: the capacity to distinguish a true summons from its counterfeit, which the Christian tradition named the discernment of spirits (*diakriseis pneumatōn*, 1 Corinthians 12:10) and which Ignatius of Loyola codified as a method. Jack Shephard begins with critical intelligence and no faith; John Locke begins with faith and no critical intelligence; and the adversary of the final seasons exploits the second deficiency as ruthlessly as the series' skeptics deplore the first. The arc of the middle seasons runs through three phases—the wager, the counterfeit, and discernment—and it concludes not with the victory of faith over reason or of reason over faith but with a faith that has learned to judge its own apparitions. This chapter traces that arc and argues that it is Pascal's: "Soumission et usage de la raison, en quoi consiste le vrai christianisme" (L167/B269)—submission and the use of reason: that is what true Christianity consists in.

4.1

Two excesses

"Deux excès: exclure la raison, n'admettre que la raison" (L183/B253). Pascal's two-line fragment names the poles between which the series' central argument is staged. The antithesis is announced at the mouth of the hatch in "Exodus" (1.23–1.25), where Locke, preparing to blow it open, assigns the two men their roles: Jack is a man of science, and Locke, by his own

account, a man of faith. The second season takes the formula as its first title ("Man of Science, Man of Faith," 2.01), and the producers repeatedly described the opposition as the series' central argument. The dramatis personae are drawn with care. Jack is a spinal surgeon, the son of a surgeon, whose professional creed is the governance of the passions: in the pilot he tells Kate that when he tore a patient's dural sac during his first solo operation, he allowed himself to feel the terror for a count of five and then set it aside (1.01). Locke is a former paraplegic who rose from his wheelchair on the island's shore and whose creed is a refusal of limits: "Don't tell me what I can't do." Science, in the series' first framing, is the discipline of the will; faith, at least in its first form, is the will's insurrection against the given.

The antithesis is unstable from the outset, because each excess conceals the other. Jack's science harbors a faith—in his own competence, in the reparability of the world, in the proposition that everything can be fixed—and the flashbacks trace it to a son's need to justify himself before a father who told him he did not have what it takes ("White Rabbit," 1.05). His empiricism is therefore not Humean but compulsive, less a method than a defense. In "Man of Science, Man of Faith" the flashback shows Jack telling a young woman, Sarah, that her spinal injury is beyond repair, then finding that she has recovered—a cure he cannot explain and does not claim, the miracle that the man of science receives and does not know how to receive. Locke's faith, conversely, harbors a demand for proof. In "Deus Ex Machina" (1.19), with Boone dying of injuries sustained on an expedition Locke had led, Locke pounds on the sealed hatch and cries out that he has done everything asked of him; a light blazes up through the glass, and he takes it as an answer. The episode's title glosses the scene with deliberate irony. The light was a god from a machine, and the machine was operated by a man: the second season reveals that Desmond, alone below since killing his station partner, Kelvin Inman, in a struggle, had just found, hidden in the one book he was saving to read before he died, a letter from Penny promising to wait for him—a promise he believed he could never meet—and was on the point of shooting himself when he heard the pounding, and that he put the gun down and switched on the light. Locke's cry had interrupted a suicide ("Live Together, Die Alone," 2.23–2.24). The sign Locke read as addressed to himself was in truth the meeting of two despairs, each of which answered the other. A sign, the series suggests from its first season, is not a private message from providence but an event between persons; Locke's error is not that he believed in signs but that he believed them to be about him.

The series builds its arguments in such Pascalian diptychs, and a second one runs beside the first. In the *Entretien avec M. de Sacy* (1655), Pascal set Epictetus against Montaigne: the Stoic knows the duty of man but not his impotence, and so loses himself in *présomption*; the skeptic knows man's impotence but not his duty, and so sinks into *lâcheté*. Each, Pascal argued, is right against the other, and their mutual refutation clears the ground for a truth that reconciles human greatness and human misery. Jack is the series' Epictetus: a Stoic of the operating theater whose presumption is that he can fix everything. Sawyer is its Montaigne: a skeptic of every motive, whose ethic is announced by the title of his central third-season epis-

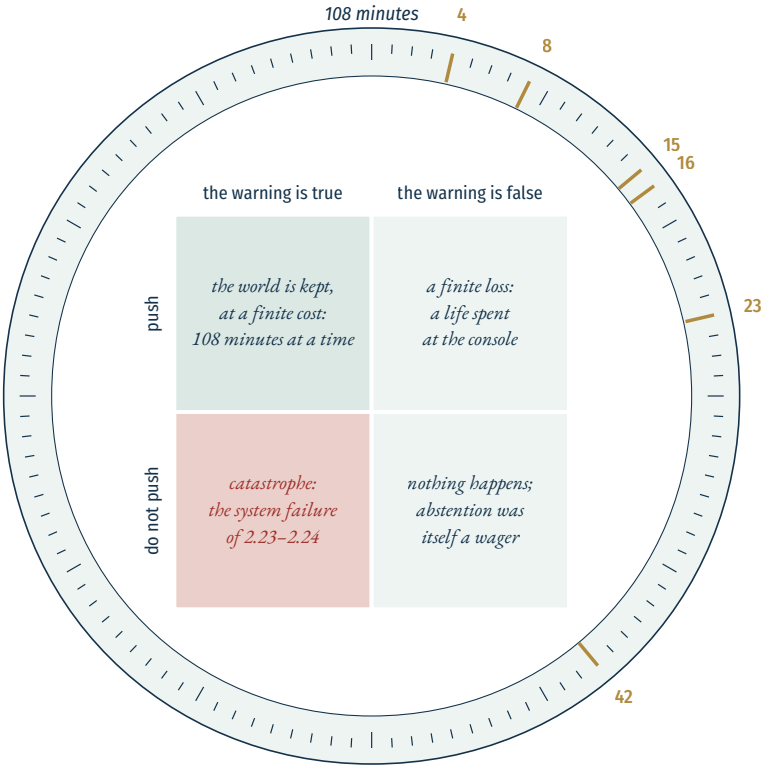
ode, "Every Man for Himself" (3.04). The two men compete for Kate as their philosophies compete for the castaways, and the series resolves neither rivalry by awarding victory to one side. In both diptychs the resolution lies in a third term, and in both it belongs to the order of charity.

4.2

Vous êtes embarqué: the Swan as wager

Pascal's wager (L418/B233) begins from the premise that reason cannot decide whether God exists and concludes that one must nonetheless decide: "Il faut parier. Cela n'est pas volontaire, vous êtes embarqué"—you must wager; it is not optional; you are embarked. The castaways are embarked in the most literal sense, and the second season gives them a wager in the shape of a machine. Beneath the hatch lies the Swan, whose orientation film instructs its occupants to enter a sequence of numbers into a computer every 108 minutes and to press a button; failure, the film implies, will bring catastrophe. The structure is Pascal's with almost diagrammatic fidelity. The stakes are infinite: if the warning is true, the world ends. The evidence is radically insufficient: a spliced film, a countdown, a sequence of numbers. The cost of compliance is finite but real: 108 minutes at a time, for the rest of one's life. And abstention is not neutrality. Not to push is to wager that the warning is false.

William James, who discussed Pascal's wager explicitly in "The Will to Believe" (1896), defined a genuine option as one that is living, forced, and momentous: both hypotheses are credible to the chooser, no third course is available, and the stakes are unique and irreversible. The button is a genuine option in all three senses, and James's argument—that where such an option cannot by its nature be decided on intellectual grounds, our "passional nature" may lawfully decide it—is the argument Locke makes. James's opponent was W. K. Clifford, whose "The Ethics of Belief" (1877) declared it wrong always, everywhere, and for anyone to believe anything upon insufficient evidence, and Clifford's founding example was a shipwreck. A shipowner, stifling his doubts about an old emigrant ship, persuades himself that she is seaworthy, sends her to sea, and collects the insurance when she sinks; he is guilty, Clifford argued, because he had no right to believe on such evidence. The debate between evidentialism and the will to believe begins with a vessel lost at sea, and *Lost* restages it beneath a hatch on an island populated by the survivors of one. In "Orientation" (2.03) the debate is compressed into three lines: Locke asks Jack why he finds it so hard to believe; Jack asks why Locke finds it so easy; and Locke answers that it has never been easy.



Il faut parier. Cela n'est pas volontaire, vous êtes embarqué.

Figure 4 *The Swan as wager (4.2). The six numbers, marked on a dial of 108 minutes, sum to the interval at which the code must be entered; within the dial, Pascal's matrix. Not to push is to wager that the warning is false.*

James added a further argument that the series makes its own. There are cases, he observed, in which faith in a fact helps to create the fact: "A social organism of any sort whatever, large or small, is what it is because each member proceeds to his own duty with a trust that the other members will simultaneously do theirs." The Swan cannot be kept by one person. It requires shifts, and shifts require the trust that the next person will arrive and push. The button is thus not only a wager about the world but a constitution of the community: the castaways who take turns at it become a polity of mutual reliance, and the maxim of "White Rabbit"—live together or die alone—acquires a liturgical form.

Pascal's counsel to the unbeliever who cannot bring himself to believe is notoriously practical. Let him act as those who believe have acted, "en prenant de l'eau bénite, en faisant dire des messes"—taking holy water, having masses said—for "cela vous fera croire et vous abêtira": that will make you believe and will tame you. The counsel rests on an anthropology. "Il y a trois moyens de croire: la raison, la coutume, l'inspiration" (L808/B245); and "nous sommes automate autant qu'esprit" (L821/B252)—we are as much automaton as mind. The

Swan is the faith of the automaton. Its rite trains the hand before it persuades the mind: Desmond kept it for three years, Locke organized the castaways into shifts, Eko took it up as a devotion. Its cadence is that of the monastic hours, which the *Navigatio Sancti Brendani* set singing on its island of birds (Chapter 3); its number is the number of the *mala*'s beads and the temple bell's strokes (Chapter 2). The button is custom in Pascal's sense: not the opposite of faith but one of its three gates, the one through which the body enters.

4.3

The defeater: the Pearl and the two faiths

The wager's crisis comes in "?" (2.21). Guided by a dream, Locke and Eko find a second station, the Pearl, whose orientation film suggests that the Swan was a psychological experiment: its occupants' compliance was observed on monitors and recorded in notebooks that, the castaways later learn, were dispatched through a pneumatic tube to a heap of unread canisters in the jungle. For Locke the discovery is annihilating. In the vocabulary of contemporary religious epistemology, the Pearl is a *defeater*. Alvin Plantinga's *Warranted Christian Belief* (2000) argued that belief in God may be "properly basic"—warranted without inference from other beliefs, as perceptual and memorial beliefs are—and that such beliefs nonetheless remain exposed to defeaters, which strip them of warrant unless they are themselves defeated. Locke's faith collapses because it was never properly basic. It was an inference—from the light in the hatch, from his healing, from the island's apparent responsiveness to his desire—and an inference can be defeated by a better one. Wittgenstein's late notes *On Certainty* (written 1949–1951; published 1969) proposed that grounded belief rests, at bottom, on belief that is not itself grounded: certain propositions function as the hinges on which our questions turn. Locke's hinge was not God but his own election, and when the Pearl suggested that he was merely a subject in an experiment, the door came off.

Eko's faith survives the same evidence because it rests on another ground. When Locke despairs, Eko declares that he will push the button himself, for he now believes that it must be pushed. He has seen the same film. His faith was never an inference from the efficacy of the rite but a fidelity to the vocation he received—from his dead brother's apparition, from the dream that sent him to the Pearl, from the long penance in which he took up his brother's priesthood in place of his own crimes. The series here distinguishes two faiths with a precision the theological tradition would recognize. Locke's is a faith in signs, which demands confirmation and is therefore defeasible. Eko's is a faith as fidelity, which demands nothing and is therefore undefeated by evidence, though not untouched by it. The first is the faith of the wager construed as a bet one expects to win; the second is the faith of the wager construed, as Pascal finally construed it, as a form of life.

The consequences are cosmic. In "Live Together, Die Alone" (2.23–2.24), Locke, now persuaded by the experiment hypothesis, resolves to let the countdown expire and seals himself inside with Desmond, while Eko, locked out, tries to blast his way in. The flashbacks disclose

that on the day Desmond once failed to enter the code, the discharge brought down Oceanic 815. When the timer runs out the station begins to implode, and Desmond saves the world by turning the failsafe key—an act that, so far as he knows, will kill him. The wager is vindicated: the button was real. But the vindication indicts the faithful as well as the skeptics. Locke, the man of faith, swung from one of Pascal's excesses to the other—from the exclusion of reason to the admission of nothing but his own reasoning—and in the second excess he nearly ended the world. It was saved by a fidelity that did not need to see (Eko's) and by a self-gift that did not calculate (Desmond's).

The series also sketches, at its margins, a third faith that neither seeks signs nor fights for rites. Rose Nadler knows from the first days that her husband, lost with the tail section, is alive ("Walkabout," 1.04); once they are reunited, she knows that the island has healed her cancer and that leaving would undo the cure, and she chooses to stay ("S.O.S.," 2.19). In the fifth season she and Bernard are found living in a hut in the jungle of 1977, having declined the war altogether. Kierkegaard's pseudonym Johannes de silentio, in *Fear and Trembling* (1843), imagined that if he ever met a knight of faith he would find a man who looked exactly like a tax collector—wholly ordinary, delighting in everything, betraying no sign of the infinite movements he had made. Rose is the series' knight of faith. She is also, with her husband and their dog, the only figure in the series who has learned what Pascal said all human unhappiness comes from not knowing: how to remain at rest in a room.

4.4

The angel of light: the capture of Locke's faith

The third, fourth, and fifth seasons transform the debate between faith and reason into a drama of counterfeit. Locke's faith, deprived of the rite that disciplined it, becomes the instrument of the adversary, and the series traces its capture with the precision of a manual of spiritual direction. The Pauline warning is its premise: "Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light" (2 Corinthians 11:14). The first epistle of John states the corresponding duty: "believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God" (1 John 4:1). The method of trying them received its classic form in the Rules for the Discernment of Spirits appended to Ignatius of Loyola's *Spiritual Exercises* (approved 1548). In the rules for the second week, addressed not to beginners but to those already advancing in the spiritual life, Ignatius warns that it is characteristic of the evil spirit to take on the appearance of an angel of light: he begins by suggesting thoughts suited to the devout soul and ends by suggesting his own (rule 4). Hence the soul must attend to the whole course of its thoughts. If their beginning, middle, and end are all good, they come from the good spirit; if the course ends in something evil, or distracting, or less good than what the soul had first proposed, it is a clear sign of the enemy (rule 5). And once the enemy has been recognized by his serpent's tail and the evil end to which he leads, the soul should retrace the course of its thoughts to learn how it was led astray (rule 6).

Locke's course can be retraced with Ignatian exactness. Its *beginning* is good and is suited precisely to his soul: the island heals him, gives him purpose, answers his pounding with light, and tells him, as no one in his life had told him, that he is special. Its *middle* is a sequence of increasingly specific commissions from a source he cannot verify. In "The Man Behind the Curtain" (3.20) Ben leads him to a cabin where Ben addresses an empty chair, and Locke alone hears a voice ask for help. In "Cabin Fever" (4.11) he returns to the cabin and finds Christian Shephard, who says that he can speak on Jacob's behalf and that Locke must move the island. At the frozen wheel in "This Place Is Death" (5.05), Christian tells him that he must bring the others back and that he will have to die. Its *end* is a Los Angeles hotel room in which Locke, having failed to persuade a single castaway to return, prepares to hang himself, until Ben arrives, talks him out of it, learns from him the name of Eloise Hawking, and then strangles him with the cord and arranges the body to look like a suicide ("The Life and Death of Jeremy Bentham," 5.07), a corpse flown back to the island in a coffin, and the use of its likeness to persuade Ben to murder Jacob ("The Incident," 5.16–5.17). The serpent's tail is visible only at the end, and only from the end can the course be read. The commission the false voice gave Locke at the frozen wheel—that he would have to die—had brought a believer to the brink of taking his own life; and the death it required came instead from the hand of the man who had just talked him back from that brink. Even the angel of light is literal. The figure who wore Christian Shephard's face on the island was, the final season implies, the adversary; and in "316" (5.06), told that the reenactment of the original flight requires proxies, Jack dresses Locke's corpse in his father's shoes. The body the adversary will wear walks in the shoes of the father whose form the adversary had worn.

The historical Locke had foretold this outcome. Enthusiasm, he wrote, takes away both reason and revelation and substitutes for them "the ungrounded fancies of a man's own brain" (*Essay* IV.xix.3). The fictional Locke's tragedy is darker still: his fancies were not even his own. His enthusiasm left him open to whatever voice addressed his longing most precisely, and the voice that did so was the adversary's. Descartes, at the outset of the *Meditations* (1641), supposed for the sake of argument an evil genius, supremely powerful and cunning, who employs all his industry in deceiving the meditator; the Man in Black is that hypothesis given a body, or rather the bodies of the dead. But the series does not answer the evil genius as Descartes did, by proving that God is no deceiver. It answers him as Ignatius did, by teaching a practice of attention to the course of one's inspirations. The difference is decisive for the series' form. Discernment in the Ignatian sense is diachronic. It cannot be exercised at a single instant, because at any single instant the angel of light looks exactly like an angel; it can be exercised only over a course, by comparing the end with the beginning. The serial narrative is therefore the natural form of discernment, and the audience of *Lost* was trained in it: viewers learned to distrust the Locke of the fifth season only as the course of his commissions bent toward murder. Chapter 10 returns to this convergence of seriality and discernment.

The series offers, finally, a criterion that converts the Ignatian rule into a test of fruits: "Ye shall know them by their fruits" (Matthew 7:16). Every commission of the Man in Black, traced to its end, terminates in a death that serves his exit from the island. Locke's death serves it, because the adversary needs Locke's form to reach Jacob. Jacob's death at Ben's hand serves it. Dogen's death at Sayid's hand strips the Temple of its protection ("Sundown," 6.06); Desmond's death would remove an anomaly the adversary fears; Widmore's death at Ben's hand removes a rival ("What They Died For," 6.16); and the bomb planted on the submarine is meant to kill the remaining candidates at a stroke ("The Candidate," 6.14). The commissions of Jacob, traced to their ends, terminate otherwise: in lives freely given for what must be kept. The criterion does not make Jacob innocent—Chapter 8 argues that he is not—but it makes the two voices distinguishable. The false voice asks for another's death and calls it freedom; the true voice asks for one's own life and calls it keeping.

4.5

The functionary's faith: Ben, the elder brother, and the second voice

If Locke is faith without discernment, Benjamin Linus is faith without belief—or, more exactly, the administration of a faith he does not possess. For twelve years Ben governs the Others in Jacob's name, speaks of Jacob's will, and enforces Jacob's lists; in "The Man Behind the Curtain" he is exposed as never having seen him, and he later admits as much. Pascal's harshest sentence on religious politics describes his regime: "Jamais on ne fait le mal si pleinement et si gaiement que quand on le fait par conscience" (L813/B895)—men never do evil so completely and cheerfully as when they do it from conscience. Ben's conscience licenses abduction, the gassing of the DHARMA Initiative, and the manipulation of everyone around him, each justified by an appeal to the island's good that he alone claims to interpret. His faith is the faith of the functionary, and its characteristic passion is resentment. When at last he stands before Jacob in "The Incident," after a lifetime of service unrewarded by any sign, his complaint is the elder brother's in the parable of the prodigal son—"Lo, these many years do I serve thee... and yet thou never gavest me a kid" (Luke 15:29)—and Cain's, whose offering was not regarded (Genesis 4:5). Ben asks what about him; Jacob answers by asking what about him; Ben stabs him. The functionary's faith ends where Cain's did, in the murder of the one whom the father seemed to prefer.

Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* asks whether there can be a "teleological suspension of the ethical"—whether Abraham, raising the knife over Isaac, is a murderer or the father of faith—and *Lost* poses the question again and again, in a dense web of sacrificed and endangered children. Locke's father, the con man Anthony Cooper, throws his son from an eighth-story window; Michael murders Ana Lucia and Libby to recover his son from the Others ("Two for the Road," 2.20); Ben, wagering that the rules protect his adopted daughter, tells a mercenary that she means nothing to him and watches her shot ("The Shape of Things to Come," 4.09); Dogen accepts exile on the island as the price of his son's life ("Sundown");

and Mother, the island's first keeper, kills the mother of the children she raises ("Across the Sea"). In every case in which a character suspends the ethical for the sake of a higher end—the island, the greater good, a child—the suspension is captured by the false voice or ends in catastrophe. The only sacrifices the series honors are self-offerings: Charlie's in the Looking Glass; Desmond's at the failsafe; Michael's aboard the freighter, where he dies keeping its bomb from detonating so that others may escape ("There's No Place Like Home," 4.12–4.14); Sayid's; Jack's.

The series' answer to Kierkegaard is therefore closer to Emmanuel Levinas's. Commenting on Kierkegaard in 1963 and again in "À propos de 'Kierkegaard vivant'" (1966; collected in *Noms propres*, 1976), Levinas proposed that the highest point of the Akedah is not Abraham's obedience to the voice that commanded the sacrifice but his attentiveness to the second voice that forbade it—"Lay not thine hand upon the lad" (Genesis 22:12)—and that what is astonishing is that Abraham kept enough distance from his obedience to hear it. Discernment, on this account, is the capacity to hear the second voice. The series stages that capacity at its climax. Sent by the Man in Black to kill Desmond at the bottom of a well, Sayid, who has already killed at the adversary's bidding to win back the woman he loved, is asked by Desmond what he will tell her when she asks what he did to get her back; he lowers the gun ("The Last Recruit," 6.13). The question is the second voice. In the next episode Sayid carries the adversary's bomb away from his friends and dies with it ("The Candidate," 6.14).

Jacques Derrida's *Donner la mort* (1992; translated as *The Gift of Death*) presses the objection from the other side. Every act of responsibility toward one other, Derrida argued, sacrifices all the others to whom one might have responded in the same instant: *tout autre est tout autre*, every other is wholly other, and so every decision is a kind of Akedah, repeated daily and without a second voice. The series registers all three readings. Its fathers who offer their children belong to Kierkegaard's account, and its refusals to Levinas's; but its custodians live in Derrida's, for the protector of the island must choose, day after day, whom to keep, and Jacob's lists, with their crossed-out names, are the ledger of a responsibility that cannot be discharged without loss. The answer the series finds is the one Levinas would have recognized. The only sacrifice it honors is never of another, only of oneself.

Ben, too, hears the second voice, and his repentance is the series' boldest wager on grace. In "Dr. Linus" (6.07), held captive by Ilana, Jacob's last emissary, and made to dig his own grave, he is offered escape and power by the Man in Black; he flees, returns, and confesses to Ilana that he killed Jacob because he felt cast aside, and that he has nowhere left to go. She answers that she will have him. The functionary who administered a faith he did not hold is received by a faith he did nothing to earn. The finale leaves him outside the church, on a bench, not yet ready to go in: the elder brother of the parable, still being entreated to come in to the feast.

4.6

The folly of the wise: Hurley's discernment

Pascal's most vertiginous sentence on reason is a sentence on madness: "Les hommes sont si nécessairement fous que ce serait être fou par un autre tour de folie de n'être pas fou" (L412/B414)—men are so necessarily mad that not to be mad would be to be mad by another twist of madness. The series' surest discerner of spirits is a former psychiatric patient. Hugo Reyes sees the dead, and the series never resolves whether his visions are illness or gift, because it does not regard the two as exclusive. What it dramatizes is that Hurley learns to tell his apparitions apart. In "Dave" (2.18) the imaginary companion of his years in the institution returns and argues that the island is a delusion and that Hurley is still lying catatonic in his ward; Dave urges him to jump from a cliff, promising that the fall will not kill him but wake him. Libby talks him back from the edge. The false voice speaks in the language of the skeptic—none of this is real—and its counsel is the counsel of exit: escape the island by escaping the body. It is the Gnostic offer of Chapter 2 in the idiom of psychiatry, and Hurley's refusal of it is his first act of discernment. The dead who visit him later speak otherwise. Charlie appears to him in the institution to tell him that the castaways need him ("The Beginning of the End," 4.01); in the final season Jacob sends him on errands to the Temple and to the lighthouse; and the dead Michael explains to him that the whispers in the jungle are souls who cannot move on ("Everybody Loves Hugo," 6.12). The voices that tell Hurley to leave are false; the voices that tell him he is needed are true.

Two conditions make Hurley's discernment possible, and both are moral rather than intellectual. The first is humility. Paul's sentence—"God hath chosen the foolish things of the world to confound the wise" (1 Corinthians 1:27)—is the epigraph of his election: the castaway whom the world certified as mad, and whom the narrative long used as comic relief, becomes the island's keeper. The second is truthfulness. Chapter 2 identified Hurley as the series' *ashavan*, the possessor of truth who cannot sustain the Oceanic Six's lie. A liar cannot discern spirits, because his own speech is a counterfeit sign; the con man and the impostor are disqualified by their trade from telling a true summons from a false one. The series stages the contrast through Sawyer, whose discernment is the con man's. Sawyer recognizes the Man in Black's offer as a con, plays along, and double-crosses both him and Widmore ("Recon," 6.08). His suspicion can unmask a deceiver, but it cannot recognize a true summons; it trusts neither brother. The discernment of suspicion belongs to the order of minds. Hurley's belongs to the order of charity, and it alone can say not only that this voice is false but that this one is true.

4.7

Thomas, called Didymus: the conversion of the man of science

The series names the faith its man of science must reach, and it does so in a church. In "316" (5.06), while Eloise Hawking calculates the island's location in the station beneath, Ben sits with Jack before a reproduction of Caravaggio's *Incredulity of Saint Thomas* (c. 1601–1602), in which the apostle, his brow furrowed in concentration, presses his finger into the wound in Christ's side while Christ guides his hand (Grade A). Ben tells Jack the story. Thomas is remembered as the doubter, but when Jesus resolved to return to Judea, where his enemies had sought to stone him, it was Thomas who said to the others, "Let us also go, that we may die with him" (John 11:16). The painting and the story together define Jack's vocation. Caravaggio's Thomas is a surgeon: his gesture is the probing of a wound, his demand the empiricist's—"Except I shall... put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe" (John 20:25). Yet the doubter is also the bravest of the disciples, and when he is given the evidence he demanded he utters the Gospel's fullest confession, "My Lord and my God" (20:28). Christ's reply blesses another kind of faith: "blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed" (20:29).

The episode surrounds the painting with the signs of the same theology. Its flight number recalls John 3:16, the verse of the Son given for the world—a reading critics proposed the week the episode aired, though the producers never confirmed it (Grade B). The conditions of the return make the allusion denser. To reproduce the circumstances of the first crash, Eloise Hawking requires that a body travel with them as Christian Shephard's had, and Locke's corpse takes Christian's place: a man named John travels in the hold in the place of a man named Christian, aboard a flight numbered for John 3:16. It opens on an extreme close-up of Jack's eye as he wakes in a bamboo grove, a deliberate reprise of the pilot's first shot, so that the man of science is returned to the island by the image with which the series began. And Jack is handed, first by Eloise Hawking and then again aboard the aircraft, the note Locke wrote when he was preparing to hang himself: a single sentence addressed to the man of science, wishing that he had believed him ("316," 5.06; "The Life and Death of Jeremy Bentham," 5.07). The empiricist goes back carrying the believer's body and his last word. The Gospel, moreover, says less than Caravaggio paints. As Glenn W. Most observes in *Doubting Thomas* (2005), John never states that Thomas touched the wounds: Christ offers them, and Thomas confesses. Jack's final faith has the Johannine and not the Caravaggesque form. When he accepts Jacob's charge in "What They Died For" (6.16), he drinks from the cup Jacob offers without having demanded, or received, a proof.

The Gospel of John twice glosses the apostle's name: he is "called Didymus" (11:16; 20:24), and *didymos*, like the Aramaic *t'ōmā*, means twin. Syriac Christianity knew him as Judas Thomas and, in the *Acts of Thomas*, as the twin of Jesus himself—the very text that preserves the "Hymn of the Pearl," whose structure of forgetting, awakening, and recognition Chapter

2 identified with the flash-sideways. The man of science has been assigned the patron of twins in a series about twins, and the patron of the hymn that will govern its afterlife. The *Gospel of Thomas*, which opens by attributing its sayings to "Didymos Judas Thomas," adds a further correspondence (Grade C). Its second saying traces a sequence: whoever seeks should not stop seeking until he finds; when he finds, he will be troubled; when troubled, he will marvel; and then he will reign over all. This is Jack's itinerary. He seeks—to fix, to save, to get home. He finds—the island, and the way off it. He is troubled—the bearded, addicted figure of the fourth-season flash-forwards, crying that they have to go back. He marvels—at the return, at the candidacy, at the light. And he is made, for the space of a single night, the keeper of the island.

The conversion is neither sudden nor simple, and the series dramatizes its false starts. In the fifth season Jack's new faith takes the form of fanaticism: he resolves to detonate a hydrogen bomb in 1977 in order to unmake the crash and erase the history that followed—a faith that, as Chapter 5 argues, is Gnostic in its hatred of what happened. In "Dr. Linus" (6.07) it takes the form of a test of providence: Richard, who has lost his faith with Jacob's death and cannot take his own life because of Jacob's gift, has gone to the wrecked slave ship to die and asks Jack to light the dynamite fuse for him; Jack lights it and sits down beside him, certain that Jacob will not let them die, until the flame goes out. The scene is the series' most audacious and most ambiguous. It is precisely the act Jesus refused when the tempter invited him to cast himself from the pinnacle of the Temple and trust the angels to bear him up—"Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God" (Matthew 4:7)—and the series lets it succeed without deciding whether providence or a damp fuse intervened. Its ambiguity is moral as well as theological. Jack's wager is also an act of company: he will not let a man who wants to die do so alone, and he stakes his own life beside him, so that the act that tempts God is also the act that keeps Richard alive. It is Levinas's substitution in the form of a wager. Only in "What They Died For" (6.16) does Jack's faith take its final form. He volunteers for the office no one else will take and drinks from the cup Jacob offers, not because he has been given a sign but because, he says, this is what he is supposed to do.

The conversion is completed by an act of discernment. Confronting the Man in Black on the cliffs in "The End," Jack tells him that he is not John Locke—that he disrespects Locke's memory by wearing his face—and adds that Locke was right about almost everything, and that he wishes he could have told him so while he was alive. The two clauses form a single act. Jack can vindicate Locke's faith only by refusing the counterfeit that wears Locke's body, and he can refuse the counterfeit only because he now believes what Locke believed. Locke had faith without discernment and was captured; Jack had discernment without faith and could not act. The Jack of the finale has both. His last confrontation with the adversary is Pascal's formula enacted: *soumission et usage de la raison*.

4.8

"Not Penny's Boat": discernment as the intellect of charity

The series' most celebrated death is an act of discernment. In "Through the Looking Glass" (3.22–3.23), Charlie, who has accepted Desmond's vision of his death as the price of Claire's rescue, swims down to the Looking Glass station to shut off the signal that jams the island's communications. There, briefly in contact with Penny Widmore by video link, he learns that the freighter offshore is not hers—that the rescuers are not who they claim to be. As the station floods, he writes three words on his palm and presses it to the porthole for Desmond to read: *Not Penny's Boat*. His last act is to tell the true rescuer from the false, and to pay for the knowledge with his life. The scene distills the chapter's argument. Discernment is not a faculty of the faithful opposed to the reason of the skeptic; it is reason placed at the service of love—intelligence exercised on behalf of others, at cost to oneself.

This is the Pascalian resolution of the faith–reason antithesis, and it explains why the debate between the man of science and the man of faith could not be settled on its own terms. Pascal's orders are hierarchical in one direction only. The lower cannot ascend to the higher—from all bodies one cannot draw a thought, and from all bodies and minds one cannot draw a movement of charity—but the higher can inform the lower. Charity can think. When it does, its thinking is discernment: the use of reason by a heart that has its reasons (*le cœur a ses raisons que la raison ne connaît point*, L423/B277) and that perceives what reason alone cannot —"Dieu sensible au cœur, non à la raison" (L424/B278). The island's sacred center is called its Heart. Jack and Locke argued for two seasons, in the order of minds, about whether to believe, and neither could win, because the question was finally not whether to believe but how to tell what is believed from what wears its face. The answer to that question belongs to the third order, and the series' last word on faith and reason is written on a drowning man's hand.

The wager and its counterfeit, however, raise a question that discernment alone cannot answer. If the button's discharge brought down Oceanic 815, if the island can be moved in time, and if Jack can resolve to erase the past with a bomb, then the faith–reason antithesis rests on a deeper problem: whether what happened can be changed, and whether anyone is free within a history that seems already written. Chapter 5 turns to the series' theory of time.

Chapter 5

Chronosophy

Augustine, Molina, Novikov; the Constant against the Variable



Few dramas in the history of American network television experimented with time as persistently as *Lost*, and none subordinated its experiments so thoroughly to a single question. The series moved from flashback to flash-forward, from a consciousness unmoored in its own past to bodies displaced into the island's history, and from there to a mythic prehistory and a world beyond time; but each innovation was a new way of asking whether the past can be changed, and whether anyone is free within a history that seems already written. Two episode titles name the poles of its answer: "The Constant" (4.05) and "The Variable" (5.14). Between them the series stages a disputation among four theories of time and freedom: the fixity of a self-consistent history, which its physicists call "whatever happened, happened"; the mutability of history by human choice, which its most brilliant physicist calls the variable; the providence of a keeper who arranges circumstances without determining choices; and the eternity of a present in which, as Christian Shephard tells his son, there is no "now." It resolves the disputation in a fifth term, which this chapter calls *constancy*. Its thesis can be put in a sentence. The series affirms that the past cannot be changed and denies that it is therefore lost: freedom, in *Lost*, is not the power to unmake what happened but the power to keep faith within it, and the redemption of time is not its revision but its remembrance.

5.1

Three presents: the Augustinian grammar of the series' forms

"Quid est ergo tempus? Si nemo ex me quaerat, scio; si quaerenti explicare velim, nescio" (*Confessions* XI.14.17): what then is time? If no one asks me, I know; if I wish to explain it to one who asks, I do not know. Augustine's answer to his own question, in the eleventh book of the *Confessions*, is that neither past nor future exists, and that what we call three times are three modes of the present in the soul: "praesens de praeteritis memoria, praesens de praesentibus contuitus, praesens de futuris expectatio" (XI.20.26)—the present of things past is memory, the present of things present is attention, the present of things future is expectation. *Lost*'s three principal narrative modes are Augustine's three presents. The flashback, which dominates the first three seasons, is *memoria*: the present of each castaway's past, summoned in every episode to interpret the island's present. The island's own present tense is *contuitus*, the attention of a community that must watch, wait, and keep. The flash-forward, introduced in the third-season finale and dominant in the fourth, is *expectatio*: the present of things future, which converts the island's present into the past of a future already decided.

The introduction of the flash-forward is the series' most celebrated formal coup, and its mechanism can be described precisely in the terms of J. M. E. McTaggart's "The Unreality of Time" (1908). McTaggart distinguished an A-series, in which events are ordered as past, present, and future, from a B-series, in which they are ordered only as earlier and later. Throughout "Through the Looking Glass" (3.22–3.23), the off-island scenes of a bearded, despairing Jack were received by viewers as flashbacks—placed, that is, in the A-series as past. The final scene relocated them to the future without altering their content: Jack meets Kate at an airfield and cries that they have to go back. The twist consists entirely in a reassignment of the A-series. What had been memory became expectation, and the island's present, which viewers had taken as the latest moment of the story, became the past of a future in which the castaways had already left. McTaggart argued that the A-series is contradictory; the series demonstrated, more modestly, that it is a function of narration, and that a narrator who controls where "now" falls controls what a viewer can hope.

Paul Ricoeur's *Temps et récit* (1983–1985) argued that narrative answers the aporias Augustine found in time: the soul's distension among memory, attention, and expectation becomes human time when it is configured into a plot. *Lost* is a laboratory of that thesis, and its later seasons multiplied its temporal regimes until each of Ricoeur's "fictive experiences of time" had a device of its own.

Table 5 *The six temporal regimes*

Regime	Dominant seasons	Correlate	Function	Paradigm episode
Flashback	1–3	*memoria* (Augustine)		"Walkabout" (1.04)

Regime	Dominant seasons	Correlate	Function	Paradigm episode
			Interprets the island's present by each castaway's past; reveals character as disposition	
Flash-forward	3–4	*expectatio* (Augustine)	Converts the island's present into the past of a future already decided	"Through the Looking Glass" (3.22–3.23)
Displaced consciousness	3–4	*distentio animi* (Augustine)	A self unmoored from the order of its own times	"The Constant" (4.05)
Physical time travel	5	Self-consistent closed loops (Novikov)	Places the castaways inside the history they had only remembered	"Because You Left" (5.01); "The Incident" (5.16–5.17)
Mythic flashback	6	*illud tempus* (Eliade)	Narrates the origin in sacred, undated time	"Across the Sea" (6.15)
Flash-sideways	6	*aevum*; eternal present (Aquinas; Boethius)	A duration outside time in which the dead remember	"LA X" (6.01–6.02); "The End" (6.17–6.18)

The last two regimes require comment, because they exceed the scheme of the *Confessions*. "Across the Sea" is set in what Mircea Eliade called *illud tempus*, "that time" of origins in which archaic religions located the exemplary acts that ritual repeats (*The Myth of the Eternal Return*, 1949). The episode carries no date; its characters speak Latin; its events—a birth, a murder, a fratricide, the transformation of a man into smoke—are the archetypes of which the island's later history is the repetition. Eliade contrasted the archaic consolation of cyclical time with the "terror of history" endured by modern persons who must suffer historical catastrophe without archetypes to redeem it, and the castaways are such persons: the Gulf War, the militias of Eko's Nigeria, the predations of a Korean industrial dynasty, and the ordinary catastrophes of American families have formed them. The island offers them its archetypes, and the series' question is whether the archetypes redeem history or merely repeat it.

The flash-sideways belongs to a stranger duration still. Frank Kermode, in *The Sense of an Ending* (1967), revived the scholastic concept of the *aevum*—the duration proper to angels, which Aquinas placed between time and eternity, participating in both—and proposed it as the time of fiction itself. Aquinas taught that the *aevum* has no before and after in itself, though before and after can be joined to it (*Summa theologiae* I, q. 10, a. 5). That is the precise structure of the sideways: a world in which events unfold in sequence, yet in which, as Christian Shephard will say, there is no "now." It is set, moreover, in the City of the Angels. Chapter 9 develops the point; here it suffices to observe that the series' final temporal regime is, by Kermode's definition, the time of fiction, and that its eschatology is therefore also a theory of what fiction is for.

5.2

Distentio animi: "The Constant"

Augustine's definition of time is the most famous sentence of his eleventh book: "inde mihi visum est nihil esse aliud tempus quam distentionem; sed cuius rei, nescio, et mirum si non ipsius animi" (XI.26.33)—it seems to me that time is nothing other than a distension; but of what, I do not know, and it would be a wonder if it were not of the mind itself. Three chapters later he describes the experience of that distension in the first person, and the description reads like a treatment for an episode of *Lost*: "ecce distentio est vita mea... ego in tempora dissilui, quorum ordinem nescio, et tumultuosis varietatibus dilaniantur cogitationes meae" (XI.29.39)—behold, my life is a distension... I have been scattered into times whose order I do not know, and my thoughts are torn apart by tumultuous variations.

"The Constant" (4.05) literalizes the sentence. Flying from the island to the freighter offshore, Desmond Hume's consciousness comes loose from its own sequence and begins to alternate between Christmas Eve of 2004 and 1996, when he was a soldier in the Royal Scots Regiment and had recently left Penelope Widmore. He is scattered into times whose order he does not know. Aboard the freighter he finds that the same affliction has already overtaken the communications officer, George Minkowski, who lies strapped to a bed, bleeding from the nose, his thoughts torn apart by alternation, and who dies of it within the episode. The cure is prescribed by the physicist. In 1996 Desmond seeks out the young Daniel Faraday in his laboratory at Queen's College, Oxford, where Faraday is experimenting on a rat he has named Eloise; and in 2004 the older Faraday tells him by telephone that to survive he must find a *constant*—something, or someone, present in both times, which can anchor a mind that has lost its order. Desmond's constant is Penny. In 1996 he goes to her, obtains her telephone number, and asks her never to change it; on Christmas Eve of 2004, on a telephone Sayid has repaired, he calls her, she answers, and he is restored.

Augustine's own remedy for distension anticipates the episode's resolution with remarkable precision. Having confessed that he is scattered among times, he prays to be gathered from his dispersal to follow the One, "non distentus sed extentus, non secundum distentionem sed secundum intentionem" (XI.29.39)—not distended but extended, not according to distension but according to intention—pressing on, in the words of Philippians 3:13–14, toward the prize of the upward call. The cure for a self torn among times is not to master time but to be stretched toward a single beloved. For Augustine that beloved is God, in whom the soul's scattered times are gathered; for Desmond it is a woman whose fidelity has survived eight years of his flight from her. The difference is real, and Chapter 6 weighs it. But the structure is identical: identity across temporal dispersal is secured by *intentio*, by a love that holds the self together because it is directed beyond the self. Minkowski, who has no constant, dies of the same distension. The episode is a controlled experiment in Augustinian anthropology.

Two further features of the episode refine its argument. First, the constant is reciprocal and networked. In the episode's final shot, Faraday's journal discloses that he had long ago written that if anything went wrong, Desmond Hume would be his constant: the physicist who prescribes the cure has entrusted his own sanity to the patient. Constancy is not a private possession but a relation in which each person may become another's anchor. Second, the episode reconciles two theories of time that the twentieth century had set at odds. On 6 April 1922, at the Société française de philosophie in Paris, Henri Bergson and Albert Einstein confronted each other over the nature of time, and Einstein declared, in effect, that there is no time of the philosophers—only the physical time measured by clocks and a psychological time that is a matter for psychology (Jimena Canales, *The Physicist and the Philosopher*, 2015). "The Constant" is the rare fiction in which the physicist and the philosopher of lived duration need each other. Faraday supplies the diagnosis, the vocabulary, and the prescription; but the prescription can be filled only in Bergson's *durée*, the lived, qualitative, unrepeatable time in which a man remembers a woman's voice. The episode's title, finally, completes the reversal of Hume announced in Chapter 1. Hume found no impression "constant and invariable" in the bundle of perceptions and concluded that the self was a fiction; Desmond finds his constant outside the bundle, in another person, and the self returns.

5.3

"Whatever happened, happened": self-consistency, course correction, and Oedipus

Faraday's first doctrine of time is the series' law. When the castaways left on the island begin to skip through its history in the fifth season, he tells them that they cannot change anything: whatever happened, happened. The episode title "Whatever Happened, Happened" (5.11) canonizes the formula, and it corresponds closely to a principle formulated in the physics of closed timelike curves. In "Cauchy Problem in Spacetimes with Closed Timelike Curves" (*Physical Review D* 42, 1990), John Friedman, Michael Morris, Igor Novikov, and their collaborators argued that the only solutions to the laws of physics that can occur locally in the real universe are those that are globally self-consistent. A traveler to the past can act there, but only in ways that have always already been part of history. The principle was tested against a puzzle posed by Joseph Polchinski—a billiard ball sent through a wormhole on a trajectory that would knock its own earlier self away from the wormhole's mouth—and its proponents showed that, for such initial conditions, self-consistent trajectories exist: the ball strikes its earlier self with a glancing blow that sends it into the wormhole on precisely the course required. Stephen Hawking's chronology protection conjecture (*Physical Review D* 46, 1992) proposed, more radically, that the laws of physics conspire to prevent closed timelike curves from forming at all. Chapter 1 observed that Eloise Hawking personifies Hawking's conjecture; Faraday personifies Novikov's.

The series' physics is more exact than its critics allowed. The Orchid station's orientation film, shown at the 2007 Comic-Con and part of the paracanonical archive, attributes the station's experiments with time to the Casimir effect—precisely the source of "exotic" negative energy that Michael Morris, Kip Thorne, and Ulvi Yurtsever had proposed in 1988 for holding a traversable wormhole open (*Physical Review Letters* 61). And Kurt Gödel's demonstration in 1949 that Einstein's field equations admit a universe containing closed timelike curves led him to conclude that time, understood as an objective lapse, does not exist—the conclusion the finale reaches by another road when Christian tells Jack that there is no "now" in the church.

Eloise's own formula is that the universe has a way of course correcting. She delivers it in "Flashes Before Your Eyes" (3.08), posing as a jeweler's clerk in Desmond's past, refusing to sell him the engagement ring he is not supposed to buy, and pointing out a stranger in red shoes who will die in a moment beneath a falling scaffold—which he does. The season then sets Desmond against the course correction. Granted visions of Charlie's death, he intervenes again and again, deflecting a lightning strike, an arrow, and the other deaths he foresees, until Charlie dies in the Looking Glass, by choice and in a manner that serves others. The universe corrects its course; but the course toward which it corrects is a self-offering.

The series' most rigorous dramatization of self-consistency is Oedipal. In "He's Our You" (5.10), Sayid, stranded in 1977, shoots the child Ben Linus in the jungle in order to prevent the murderer Ben will become. In "Whatever Happened, Happened" Kate and Sawyer carry the dying boy to Richard Alpert, who agrees to take him to the Temple to be healed but warns that the healing will cost the boy his innocence and that he will belong to the Others forever. Sayid's attempt to prevent Ben's future is its cause. The structure is Sophocles': Laius exposes his infant son to forestall the prophecy that the son will kill him, and the exposure ensures that Oedipus will grow up ignorant of his father and will kill him at a crossroads. The attempt to escape the oracle fulfills it. Sayid, the series' torturer, discovers what Oedipus discovered: that knowledge of the future confers no power over it, and that the man who acts to avert a destiny may be its instrument.

The law of self-consistency has a mother. Eloise Hawking, the series reveals, raised her son Daniel knowing that she would shoot him on the island in 1977—that the young woman she had been would kill the grown man he would become—and she steered his studies and his career toward the island regardless. In "The Variable" (5.14) the shot is fired, and Daniel, dying, tells her that she knew and sent him anyway. Eloise is the Novikov mother, the parent who chooses the integrity of the loop over the life of her child; in the terms of Chapter 4, she is an Abraham who never hears the second voice. The series grants her that voice only after death. In the sideways Eloise—now married to Widmore and mother of a gifted pianist named Daniel—recognizes what Desmond is doing as he awakens the others, and asks him not to take her son; he does not. The mother who sacrificed her son to the timeline in life is permitted, in the world beyond time, to keep him.

Self-consistency also produces objects without origin. In "Because You Left" (5.01) Richard Alpert gives Locke a compass and tells him to hand it back the next time they meet; Locke, skipping backward, gives it to Richard in 1954 ("Jughead," 5.03), tells him that he will be born on 30 May 1956, and asks Richard to come and see him. Richard visits the newborn ("Cabin Fever," 4.11), returns when Locke is a child to test whether he will choose the compass from among a set of objects—he chooses the knife—and keeps the compass until, in 2007, he hands it to Locke. No one in the series ever makes the compass. It circulates in a closed loop without beginning, like the paradoxes of Robert Heinlein's "By His Bootstraps" (1941) and "—All You Zombies—" (1959), whose protagonist is at once his own mother and father. The only uncreated thing on the island is a compass that points north.

The loop has a graver consequence. Locke's election—the conviction on which his entire faith rested, that he was special, chosen, sought out from birth by the island's ageless emissary—turns out to have been caused, at least in part, by Locke himself, traveling backward to tell Richard where and when to find him. Chapter 4 argued that Locke's faith was hinged not on God but on his own election; the fifth season reveals that the hinge was a bootstrap. A faith that rests only on itself rests on nothing, and Locke's tragedy is temporal as well as theological.

The series does not exempt its own metaphysics from comedy. Hurley disputes the logic of the loops with Miles in the idiom of time-travel cinema and, in "Some Like It Hoth" (5.13), sits in 1977 rewriting *The Empire Strikes Back* from memory, with improvements, to send to George Lucas before the film has been released. The scene is a joke about bootstrapped authorship—a sequel written by its own audience before its author has written it—and, as Chapter 11 argues, a prophecy about the relation between the series and the community of interpreters who would claim to know its story better than its writers did.

5.4

"We are the variables": Faraday's wager and the will's revenge against *Es war*

Faraday abandons his own law. In "The Variable" (5.14), returning to the island in 1977 after years away, he announces that he has spent his life attending to the constants and forgotten the variables—human beings, who can choose—and proposes to prove it by detonating the hydrogen bomb buried in 1954 at the site where DHARMA's drilling is about to release the electromagnetic energy the Swan was built to contain. If the energy is neutralized, the Swan will never be built, the button will never need pushing, Desmond's failure will never occur, and Oceanic 815 will land safely in Los Angeles. Faraday is shot before he can try; Jack takes up the plan, and in "The Incident" (5.16–5.17) the bomb is dropped down the shaft, fails to detonate on impact, and is struck by Juliet with a stone. The screen goes white.

The plan's motives deserve close attention, because they are not a physicist's. Jack embraces it because his return to the island has repaired nothing and he wants a world in which he never needed repair. Juliet embraces it for a reason the series renders with unusual tenderness: seeing Sawyer's love for Kate rekindled, she tells him that if she never meets him,

she will never have to lose him. Both desire not a better future but a different past, and Nietzsche named that desire with a precision no later philosopher has bettered. In "Von der Erlösung" ("On Redemption"), in the second part of *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883), Zarathustra identifies the will's deepest wound as its powerlessness against what has been done: the will cannot will backward, and so it takes revenge. "Dies, ja dies allein ist Rache selber: des Willens Widerwille gegen die Zeit und ihr 'Es war'"—this, yes, this alone is revenge itself: the will's ill will against time and its "it was." "Whatever happened, happened" is the series' translation of *Es war*, and the bomb is the will's revenge against it. Nietzsche's alternative was to redeem the past by recreating every "it was" into a "thus I willed it"—"So wollte ich es!"—and to love one's fate. The series will offer a third alternative, neither revenge nor *amor fati*; but its first task is to show that revenge fails.

It fails because Faraday's first law holds. The opening of the sixth season discloses that the castaways remain in 2007, that the island has not been unmade, and, on the most economical reading, that the bomb was itself the Incident whose aftermath DHARMA's records had always described. The attempt to unmake history was an event in history; the variable was a constant all along. In the terms of Chapter 2, the fifth-season finale is Gnostic: it seeks salvation by escaping a history judged to be a mistake, and its means are those Eric Voegelin identified in modern political Gnosticism—technique applied to the problem of existence. In the terms of Chapter 4, it is Jack's false faith, fanaticism in the service of erasure.

The sixth season then tempts its viewers with a solution the series had studiously avoided. "LA X" (6.01–6.02) intercuts the island of 2007 with a world in which Oceanic 815 does land in Los Angeles; the island lies beneath the sea; the castaways' lives have diverged in ways both small and large. The natural reading, which most viewers adopted, was that the bomb had split history into two branches—Borges's "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan" (1941), in which a novel admits every possible outcome of every choice, or Hugh Everett's "relative state" formulation of quantum mechanics (1957), in which every possibility is realized in a branching universe. The finale refuses the multiverse. The sideways is not a branch but a waiting place beyond death. There is only one history, and, as Jacob tells his brother at the opening of "The Incident," it ends only once.

5.5

Middle knowledge: Jacob's providence

That sentence introduces the third theory of time. In the opening scene of "The Incident," Jacob and the Man in Black watch the *Black Rock* approach the island in 1867. The Man in Black predicts what the newcomers will do: they will come, fight, destroy, and corrupt, and it always ends the same. Jacob replies that it ends only once, and that everything before the end is progress. The rest of the episode shows his method. He appears at turning points in the castaways' lives and touches them. He pays for the lunchbox the child Kate was caught stealing and asks her not to steal again; he lends the boy Sawyer a pen to finish the letter that will

bind him to revenge; he frees a candy bar from a stuck vending machine for the young surgeon Jack on the night his father taught him to count to five; he rides with Hurley in a taxi; he blesses Sun and Jin at their wedding; he distracts Sayid on a sidewalk as Nadia is struck by a car; he touches Locke as he lies broken after his fall. He compels none of them. He places them in circumstances in which he knows, or wagers, what they will freely do.

This is the providence of the Spanish Jesuit Luis de Molina, whose *Concordia liberi arbitrii cum gratiae donis* (1588) sought to reconcile divine foreknowledge with creaturely freedom by ascribing to God a *scientia media*, a "middle knowledge" between his knowledge of necessary truths and his knowledge of what he has freely decreed. By middle knowledge God knows what any free creature would freely do in any possible circumstance; by choosing which circumstances to actualize, he governs the world without determining the choices made in it. Molinism provoked a controversy with the Dominicans that a papal commission, the *Congregatio de auxiliis* (1597–1607), could not settle; Paul V closed it in 1607 without a verdict, forbidding each party to condemn the other. The series' refusal to adjudicate between freedom and providence is, in this respect, historically exact. Molina's critics raised what philosophers of religion now call the grounding objection: what, if not a creature's actual choice, could make true a statement about what that creature *would* freely do in circumstances that never arise? (Robert Merrihew Adams, "Middle Knowledge and the Problem of Evil," 1977). Jacob's knowledge has a visible ground. From his lighthouse he watches the candidates' lives through a wheel of mirrors that shows their childhood homes ("Lighthouse," 6.05). His providence is not that of an eternal God but that of a creature with a watchtower.

Pascal would have recognized Jacob as a Molinist, and he would not have meant it as praise. In his *Écrits sur la grâce* (c. 1656–1658) he distinguished three positions on grace and freedom —those of the Calvinists, the Molinists, and "the disciples of Saint Augustine"—and argued that the Molinists, by making the efficacy of grace depend on what the creature would freely do in the circumstances God supplies, gave too much to the human will and turned providence into a calculation; the *Provinciales* (1656–1657) carried the attack into a satire of Jesuit casuistry. The series' judgment of Jacob converges with Pascal's. Jacob's providence is real: his touches bring the castaways to the island where they will be tested and, in the end, redeemed. But it is a providence of management, which treats persons as moves in a wager with his brother and permits suffering it could prevent. Chapter 7 argues that the series' last regime replaces it, and Chapter 8 that the series indicts it.

One emblem of Jacob's providence shows how the series transforms fate into vocation. The Numbers—4, 8, 15, 16, 23, 42—first appear as the very figure of fate: the sequence that wins Hurley the lottery and seems to curse everyone near him, the code entered into the Swan, the digits stamped on the hatch, and, in the paracanonical archive, the core factors of an equation that predicts the date of human extinction. In "The Substitute" (6.04) they are revealed as the numbers Jacob assigned to the last candidates, written beside their names on the wall of a cliffside cave and on the dial of the lighthouse: Locke 4, Reyes 8, Ford 15, Jarrah

16, Shephard 23, Kwon 42. What appeared to be the cipher of destiny was a roll call. Pythagoras taught that all things are number; *Lost* discloses that its numbers are names. The order of minds encountered them as a mathematical fate to be calculated or feared; the order of charity reads them as persons called.

5.6

"There is no now here": eternity and the watchtower

The fourth theory of time is announced in the series' last scene. In the church, Jack asks his father where they are; when he presses for the time, Christian answers that there is no "now" there. The sentence is Boethian. In the fifth book of *The Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), Lady Philosophy resolves the problem of foreknowledge and freedom by distinguishing the time of creatures from the eternity of God, which she defines as "interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio" (V.6)—the whole, simultaneous, and perfect possession of unending life. God does not foresee the future; he sees all times at once, as in a single present, and his knowledge no more necessitates the events it sees than our seeing a man walk compels him to walk. Boethius drew the etymological consequence: divine knowledge should be called not *praevidentia*, foreseeing, but *providentia*, because, set far above the lowest things, it looks out over all of them "quasi ab excelso rerum cacumine"—as if from a lofty summit of things.

Jacob's lighthouse is a creaturely imitation of that summit. Its mirrors show the candidates' lives as from a height, and Jacob uses what he sees to time his touches. But Jacob is not eternal: he lives in time, can be killed, and must find a successor. His providence is Molinist because it is temporal; it must calculate what it cannot simply see. The series reserves the true eternal present for the church, and it marks the difference by placing the resolution of its temporal puzzles not in any revelation of Jacob's knowledge but in a place where knowledge is no longer at issue. In the church, the question whether the castaways' choices were free or foreseen is not answered; it is dissolved. They are together, they remember, and nothing that happened is undone. Boethius's eternity is the possession of a whole life all at once, and the sideways ends in precisely such a possession: the moment of awakening, for each character, is the moment in which an entire life becomes present to itself.

5.7

The Constant against the Variable: toward an ethics of time

The series' four theories of time can now be set side by side. Self-consistency—Faraday's first doctrine, Eloise's course correction—is true as physics and tragic as ethics: it makes the past unchangeable and, in Eloise, makes a mother the executioner of her son. Mutability—Faraday's variable, Jack's bomb, Juliet's wish—is false as physics and Gnostic as ethics: it seeks salvation by unmaking what happened and succeeds only in causing it. Providence—Jacob's middle knowledge—is real but compromised: it brings the castaways where they must go at

the cost of treating them as moves. Eternity—the church—is the horizon in which the other three are judged; but it is not a theory to be adopted within time. It is a gift received at time's end.

Against all four the series sets the Constant, and the Constant is not a theory but a practice. Desmond survives his distension not by understanding time but by keeping faith with a person across it; Penny survives his absence not by changing the past but by refusing to change her telephone number. Freedom, in the sense the series finally affirms, is not the power to alter *Es war* but the power to be faithful within it. Walter Benjamin's "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940) clarifies what is at stake. In its ninth thesis Benjamin describes Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. His face is turned toward the past: where we perceive a chain of events, he sees a single catastrophe that keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet. He would like to stay, to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise drives him irresistibly into the future, and that storm, Benjamin writes, is what we call progress. The island's two brothers divide Benjamin's image between them. The Man in Black sees what the angel sees: they come, they fight, they destroy, they corrupt, and it always ends the same—the wreckage of the *Black Rock*, the Beechcraft, Oceanic 815, and the DHARMA mass grave piled at his feet. Jacob speaks the storm's language: everything before the end is progress. Benjamin rejected both, and the series' finale does what neither brother could do and what the angel wished. It awakens the dead and makes whole what was smashed—not by reversing history but by remembering it. Benjamin's third thesis states the principle the finale enacts: the chronicler who recounts events without distinguishing great from small honors the truth that nothing that has ever happened should be given up as lost to history, though only a redeemed humanity receives the fullness of its past, which becomes citable in all its moments.

Kierkegaard named the corresponding movement in the life of the individual. *Repetition* (1843) opens by declaring that repetition and recollection are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward. Its exemplary figure is Job, who at the end receives everything back double—"this is called a repetition." The flashbacks of *Lost* are recollection; its sideways is repetition in Kierkegaard's sense. The castaways receive their lives back, changed and the same, and the reception is recollected forward into a future they will share.

The hinge between the Variable and the Constant is a dying woman's sentence. Juliet, who struck the bomb in the hope that she would never meet Sawyer and so never lose him, is found alive beneath the rubble at the opening of the sixth season. Dying in his arms, she murmurs that they should get coffee sometime and go Dutch, and tries to tell him something important; Miles, who hears the last thoughts of the dead, reports what it was: it worked ("LA X"). The words are unintelligible on the island, where nothing has been undone. They become intelligible only in the finale, when Juliet and Sawyer meet beside a hospital vending machine in the sideways, touch, and remember, in the exchange her dying words had anticip-

ated. What "worked" was not the unmaking of their meeting but its keeping. The Variable's hope—that love need not end in loss—is fulfilled, but only by the Constant's means. "Whatever happened, happened" is the island's law; the finale adds its gospel, that nothing which happened is lost. Chapter 6 asks what kind of self can be kept in this way, and why the series insists that it can be kept only by another.

Chapter 6

Constancy

From Tabula Rasa to Self-Constancy



Personal identity, in *Lost*, is neither a substance one possesses, nor a bundle one is, nor a blank on which one may write anew; it is a promise kept across time, and it is kept, in the end, by another. This chapter traces the series' anthropology from the Lockean offer extended in its third episode—that the crash has wiped every slate clean—through its dramatized refutations of the empiricist theories of the self that its names invoke, to the account of selfhood that its last seasons construct and its finale consummates. The guiding concepts are Paul Ricoeur's distinction between identity as sameness (*idem*) and identity as selfhood (*ipse*), the latter exemplified by the keeping of one's word; Emmanuel Levinas's claim that time itself is the relation to another; and Gabriel Marcel's distinction between constancy to a resolution and fidelity to a person. The series' own term for the conjunction of these ideas is "the constant," and the thesis of this chapter is that the constant is the anthropological center of the work. The self survives the disorder of time only as it is held in fidelity by someone outside it; and the figure who lacks such a holder—the nameless brother who can appear only in the borrowed forms of the dead—is the series' image of what a self becomes when no one keeps it.

6.1 "Tabula Rasa": the refused offer

The series' third episode bears the title of the most famous metaphor in modern epistemology, and it extends the metaphor as an amnesty. Kate, revealed to be a fugitive in the custody of a federal marshal who lies dying in the wreckage, offers to tell Jack what she did; Jack

declines to hear it. Who they were and what they did before the crash, he tells her, does not matter: three days ago they all died, and they should all be able to start over ("Tabula Rasa," 1.03). The offer is generous, and it is Lockean in the strict sense. Locke's mind begins as white paper, void of all characters; experience writes upon it; and if the writing of a former life could be erased by catastrophe, a new self could be inscribed in its place.

The series refutes the offer with its signature device. Every episode of the first three seasons interrupts the island's present with a flashback, and every flashback reveals that no castaway arrived blank. What the flashbacks disclose is not merely history but *character*: settled dispositions, formed by repeated acts, that the island will test but cannot erase. Leibniz had answered Locke's white paper with the image of a block of veined marble whose veins already mark out the shape of Hercules before the sculptor begins (*Nouveaux essais*, preface); the flashbacks are the series' veins. Aristotle had explained how such veins are formed: we become just by doing just acts and brave by doing brave ones, so that character is the sediment of action (*Nicomachean Ethics* II.1). Kate runs; Sawyer cons; Jack fixes; Locke refuses limits; Sayid tortures; Charlie relapses; Sun deceives in order to survive; Jin controls; Hurley blames himself; Michael alternately abandons and clutches his son. The island does not wipe these dispositions away. It summons them.

The relation between the flashbacks and the island's present follows with striking fidelity the structure Freud described in "Erinnern, Wiederholen und Durcharbeiten" ("Remembering, Repeating and Working-Through," 1914). The patient, Freud observed, often remembers nothing of what he has forgotten and repressed; instead "er agiert es"—he acts it out, reproducing it not as a memory but as an action, and repeating it without knowing that he repeats. Analysis seeks to convert repetition into memory and then to work it through. The series' three narrative registers are Freud's three verbs. The flashback is *Erinnern*: the present of the castaway's past, recalled for the viewer if not always for the character. The island is *Wiederholen*: a theater in which each castaway's defining situation recurs. Kate is offered flight after flight; Sawyer finds himself conned and conning; Jack is presented with patient after patient he cannot save; Locke's own father, the con man Anthony Cooper, reappears on the island, bound in the hold of the *Black Rock*, where Sawyer—whose mother Cooper seduced and swindled under the alias "Sawyer," a fraud after which Sawyer's father shot his wife and then himself—strangles him ("The Brig," 3.19). The arc of the whole series is *Durcharbeiten*, the slow conversion of compulsive repetition into remembrance, and its terminus is the sideways, where every castaway at last remembers.

In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) Freud described persons whose lives seem governed by a "fate" that repeats the same catastrophe, and he found its poetic emblem in Tasso. Tancred unwittingly kills his beloved Clorinda in battle; later, in an enchanted forest, he strikes a tree from which her blood flows and her voice complains that he has wounded her again. The island is an enchanted forest of this kind, in which every castaway strikes again the wound he

has already inflicted. Jack's offer of a clean slate was not merely false; it was the denial that precedes the repetition.

6.2

Bundle, person, and replica

If the flashback refutes Locke's white paper, the series' larger architecture tests the two classical empiricist theories of personal identity and finds both wanting. Hume's account, which Chapter 1 set against Desmond's survival, describes the self as "nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions, which succeed each other with an inconceivable rapidity, and are in a perpetual flux and movement," and it offers an image that might serve as a description of the series' form: "The mind is a kind of theatre, where several perceptions successively make their appearance; pass, re-pass, glide away, and mingle in an infinite variety of postures and situations" (*Treatise* 1.4.6). The episodic structure of *Lost*—island, flashback, flash-forward, sideways, each scene passing and re-passing in an infinite variety of postures—is a Humean theater, and the series' first question about each character is whether anything persists through the succession of scenes.

Locke's answer was memory. Personal identity extends as far back as consciousness can reach, and a person is therefore not a substance but a continuity of consciousness. Locke drew the doctrine's moral consequence explicitly: "person" is "a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit" (*Essay* II.xxvii.26), and on the great day of judgment no one will be made to answer for what he knows nothing of. Thomas Reid's *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1785) exposed the doctrine's logical weakness with the case of a brave officer who, as a boy, was flogged for robbing an orchard, who as a young officer took a standard from the enemy, and who as a general remembers the officer's exploit but has forgotten the boy's flogging. By Locke's criterion the general is the officer and the officer is the boy, yet the general is not the boy—an absurdity, since identity is transitive. The sideways is a Lockean thought experiment conducted in eschatological earnest, and it is closer to Locke than to Reid. Its characters do not remember the island; by Locke's criterion they are, until they remember, the same men but not yet the same persons. Their awakening restores the continuity of consciousness that makes them persons in Locke's forensic sense—answerable, that is, for the lives they are about to carry through the church doors. The historical Locke supplied the logic of the series' last judgment. But the series adds what Locke did not: memory is restored not by the self's own reflection but by the touch of another.

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) radicalized the empiricist tradition by means of science-fictional cases. A teletransporter destroys a body on Earth and assembles an exact replica on Mars, with all the original's memories and dispositions; in the branch-line variant, the original survives for a time alongside the replica. Parfit concluded that identity is not what matters: what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, which he called Relation R, and which a replica may possess as fully as the original. *Lost* constructs Parfit's case

and rejects his conclusion. The Man in Black, in the final season, is a replica of John Locke: he wears Locke's body, speaks with Locke's voice, deploys Locke's history, and walks among the Others as the man they believe has returned from the dead. If appearance and psychological content made a person, he would be Locke. The series' verdict, spoken by Jack on the cliffs in "The End," is that he is not.

Television had staged the case once before. *Twin Peaks* ended its original run (1991) with its hero trapped in the Black Lodge while a double, possessed by the spirit called BOB, walked out into the world wearing his face, and no one could tell the difference. The adversary in Locke's body is that double, with one difference: here the counterfeit is exposed, by a man who has learned at last what the original believed.

Ricoeur's critique of Parfit, in the fifth study of *Soi-même comme un autre* (1990), explains why the series must reach that verdict. Parfit's puzzling cases, Ricoeur argued, are imaginative variations on *sameness*: they manipulate the body and the brain as technological objects, and so neutralize the dimension of selfhood that consists in being the one who acts, suffers, promises, and answers. Literary fictions, by contrast, are imaginative variations on *selfhood*, which preserve that dimension even as they dissolve every other invariant. *Lost* is both kinds of fiction. Its premises are science-fictional—time travel, possession, a monster that copies the dead—but its resolutions are literary, and the decisive question it asks of the counterfeit Locke is not whether he has Locke's memories but whether he can keep Locke's faith. He cannot. The adversary can reproduce every quality of the man except the one that made him himself.

Pascal had posed the question in a fragment that reads, in this light, as a commentary on the Monster. "Qu'est-ce que le moi?" (L688/B323). If someone loves me for my beauty, does he love *me*? No: the smallpox, which will kill the beauty without killing the person, will end his love. If he loves me for my judgment or my memory, does he love me? No, for I can lose those qualities without losing myself. "On n'aime donc jamais personne, mais seulement des qualités"—we never love anyone, then, but only qualities. The Man in Black is the *reductio* of this skepticism: a being made entirely of borrowed qualities—the faces, voices, and histories of the dead—through which he is loved, obeyed, and feared without ever being anyone. The series' answer to Pascal's question is not a theory of the self's substance but a demonstration of its mode of persistence. The *moi* that survives the loss of every quality is the one who keeps faith and is kept in faith; and it is recognized, in the end, not by its qualities but by those who love it.

6.3

Idem and *ipse*: character and the kept word

Ricoeur's distinction gives the series' anthropology its exact terms. Identity in the sense of sameness, *idem*, is the permanence of what can be reidentified: a body, a set of habits, a *character*, which Ricoeur defined as the set of lasting dispositions by which a person is recognized—the sediment, he added, of acquired identifications. Identity in the sense of selfhood, *ipse*, is

the permanence of the one who answers "Here I am" to the question "Who?" Its paradigm is not character but the keeping of one's word: the promise, which binds a future self whose dispositions may have changed to the word a present self has given. Ricoeur called this *maintien de soi*, self-constancy; and the French *maintien*, from *maintenir*, preserves the Latin *manu tenere*, to hold in the hand.

The structure of *Lost* moves from the first kind of identity to the second. The flashbacks of the early seasons are inventories of *idem*: they show character as sediment, the residue of a childhood, a crime, a father. The later seasons are tests of *ipse*: they ask whether a person can keep a word that character would break. The series is dense with such words, and its emotional climaxes are almost all promises kept. At Sun and Jin's wedding, Jacob tells them that their love is a rare thing and that they must never take it for granted ("The Incident"). In the early seasons both break faith—Jin through the violence his father-in-law's service demands of him, Sun through deception and an affair—and the island becomes the place where the marriage is remade. Separated for three years by the flash-forwards and the time-skips, they are reunited in the sixth season; and when the submarine floods in "The Candidate" (6.14), Jin, who could escape, refuses to leave Sun trapped, telling her that he will never leave her again. They drown holding hands. Desmond's word is a telephone number he asked Penny never to change, and hers is a search she would not abandon: she tells him on Christmas Eve of 2004 that she has been looking for him for three years. Kate's word is given to a mother. Having raised Claire's son as her own for three years off the island, she returns to the island to find Claire and restore the child to her, and the series' final departure from the island carries Claire home to Aaron ("The End").

Sawyer's trajectory makes the distinction between *idem* and *ipse* legible through names. When James Ford was eight, a con man calling himself Sawyer seduced his mother and swindled the family; his father then shot his mother and himself while the boy hid beneath a bed. That year he wrote the con man a letter swearing revenge, and at his parents' funeral Jacob lent him the pen to finish it. He then became the thing he hunted, adopting the con man's name and trade—an instance of what Anna Freud called "identification with the aggressor" (*The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defence*, 1936), in which a self is formed by introjecting the figure that wounded it. "Sawyer" is *idem* as fate: the name of a persecutor, kept with the fidelity of hatred. When the revenge is consummated in "The Brig" and brings no peace, the series offers him a second name. In 1977, stranded with Juliet among the DHARMA Initiative, he becomes James LaFleur, its head of security, and for three years lives the only domestic happiness he has known. The name returned to him at the end is the one his parents gave him. Juliet calls him James; Kate, almost to the last, calls him Sawyer. In the sideways he is Detective James Ford of the Los Angeles police, still hunting the man who destroyed his family, until a woman at a vending machine calls him back to himself. The three names trace a movement from a self constituted by a wound, through a self constituted by love, to a self restored by recognition.

6.4

The constant is another

"The Constant" proposes that a self unmoored in time can be saved only by an anchor outside it, and the proposal has a philosophical genealogy that the episode's title concentrates. In the lectures published as *Le temps et l'autre* (delivered 1946–1947; published 1948), Emmanuel Levinas argued that time is not the achievement of an isolated subject but the very relationship of the subject with the other: the future, which cannot be grasped, is given in the encounter with what is absolutely other, and supremely in love and in the child. Paternity, Levinas wrote, is a relationship with a stranger who, while entirely other, is in some way oneself. Desmond's time is restored by Penny, who is the future he had fled, and the series compresses Levinas's account of fecundity into a single name. Desmond and Penny's son is named Charlie ("Jughead," 5.03), after the man who drowned writing on his palm the warning that kept them from a false rescue. The child carries forward the memory of a sacrifice: constancy across generations takes the form of a name given in gratitude.

Gabriel Marcel, in the essays collected as *Du refus à l'invocation* (1940; translated as *Creative Fidelity*), sharpened the concept in a way the series requires. Fidelity, Marcel argued, is not reducible to constancy. Constancy—perseverance in a resolution once taken—is at most the rational skeleton of fidelity, and it can be maintained in a spirit of pride, even against the person to whom it was pledged. Fidelity, by contrast, always implies another: in Marcel's sense one cannot be faithful to oneself, a thesis that passed, through Ricoeur, who counted Marcel among his teachers, into the account of self-constancy on which this chapter relies. Fidelity proper is *creative*: a presence maintained to another, which must be continually renewed because the other, and the self, continually change. The distinction divides the series' constancies into two kinds, and the two Widmore women embody them. Eloise Hawking is constant to a resolution—the integrity of the timeline—to which she sacrifices her son. Penelope Widmore is faithful to a person: she does not persevere in a plan but remains present to a man who had abandoned her, searching for him and answering his call. Ben is constant to the island's rules and sacrifices his adopted daughter to them; Danielle Rousseau is faithful to that daughter, broadcasting her distress call for sixteen years until, in "Through the Looking Glass," Alex comes to her. Locke is constant to his destiny; Rose is faithful to Bernard. The series' moral discriminations fall exactly along Marcel's line. Constancy to a program, a revenge, a role, or a law ends in the sacrifice of the other; fidelity to a person ends in the gift of the self.

The constant, then, is not a principle but a person, and the series insists that it is always another person. No character in *Lost* is saved by fidelity to himself. Desmond's constant is Penny; Faraday's is Desmond; Jin's is Sun; Rousseau's is Alex; Sawyer's is Juliet; Kate's, by the end, is Claire and Claire's child. The self is constituted, in the phrase that gives Ricoeur's book its title, *as another*: not merely in relation to others but by being held by them.

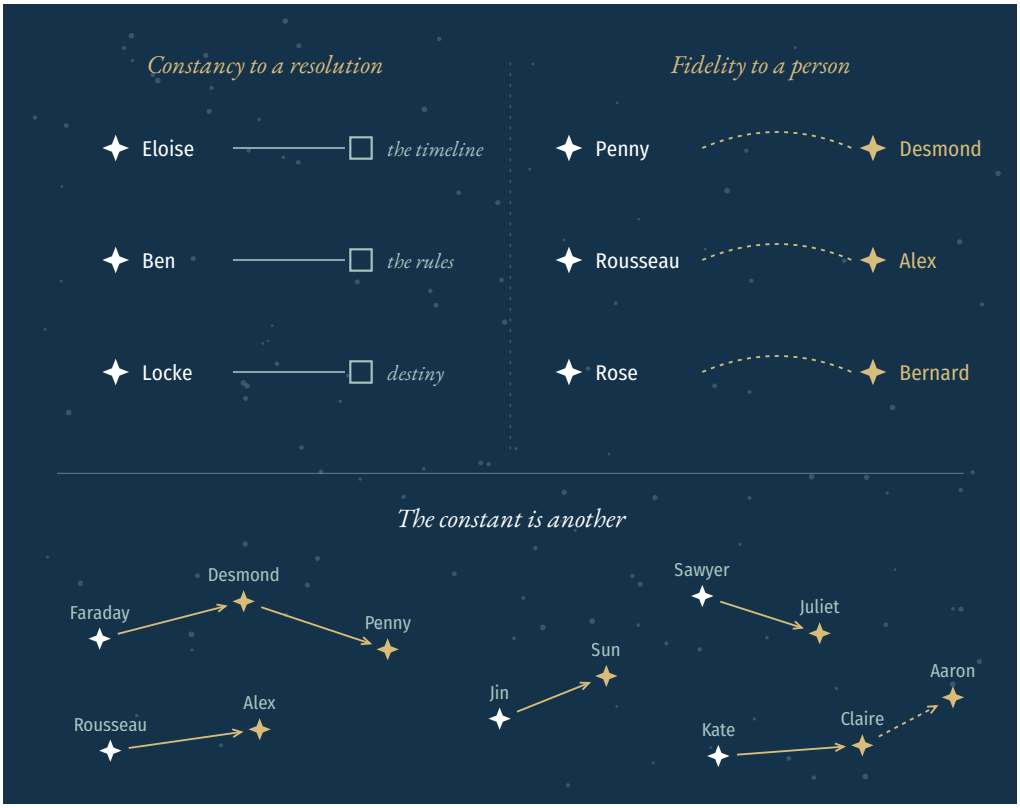


Figure 5 *Constancy and fidelity (6.4). Constancy to a resolution ends in the sacrifice of the other; fidelity to a person ends in the gift of the self. Below, each character's constant is another person.*

6.5

Broken constants and their repair

The sideways can be read, character by character, as the repair of a broken constant. Its most daring repairs concern the fathers and children whose wounds Chapter 4 traced through the Akedah. In life, Locke was the son a father maimed; in the sideways, he is the son who maimed a father. He confides to Jack, his prospective surgeon, that he crashed a small plane he was piloting with his father aboard, leaving himself paralyzed and his father in a vegetative state, and that he will not accept surgery because he believes he deserves his condition ("The Candidate," 6.14). The inversion is exact. The man whom the island taught to defy every limit must, in the world beyond time, learn to accept forgiveness for a harm he did. When he does, and Jack operates, he wakes, moves his feet, and remembers; and he tells Jack that he hopes someone will do the same for him ("The End"). The life he receives back is not the one he lost but one in which his deepest grievance has been reversed and absolved.

Ben's repair is the series' most moving. In life he sacrificed his adopted daughter to the island's rules. In the sideways ("Dr. Linus," 6.07) he teaches European history at a Los Angeles high school and is the informal mentor of a gifted student named Alex Rousseau, whom he is helping toward a place at Yale. Discovering that the principal is having an affair with the school nurse, he resolves to blackmail him and take his post; the principal counters by threatening to sabotage Alex's recommendation; and Ben surrenders the principalship for her sake. The father who chose power over the daughter now chooses the daughter over power. The sideways repairs the other line of his genealogy as well: the son who gassed his father in 1992 lives, in the world beyond time, with that father, now an invalid on oxygen, and looks after him. Later, at her family's dinner table, Danielle Rousseau tells him that he has been something like a father to her child. The functionary's constancy to a role is converted, in the world beyond time, into fidelity to a person.

The repairs extend through the ensemble. Charlie, who in life died to warn of a false rescue, begins the sideways choking on a bag of heroin in an airplane lavatory; when Jack saves him he protests that he was supposed to die, and later he explains that at the edge of death he had glimpsed a woman he loved ("LA X"; "Happily Ever After," 6.11). Claire, who in life nearly surrendered her son for adoption and then lost him for three years, gives birth to him again backstage at a concert, attended by Kate and Charlie, and the birth awakens all three ("The End"). Hurley, whose lottery fortune seemed a curse, is in the sideways the luckiest man in the world, and his awakening comes through Libby, the woman he lost on the island, who sees him and remembers first ("Everybody Loves Hugo," 6.12). Sayid's awakening, arranged by Hurley, comes through Shannon rather than Nadia, and it remains the series' most contested pairing—a reminder that the repairs of the sideways are the writers' judgments about which loves were constitutive of a life, and that such judgments can be disputed.

The principle governing the repairs is consistent. The sideways does not restore what was lost by returning the characters to the lives they had before the crash; nor does it grant them the lives they wished for. It gives them lives in which the constant that was broken in life becomes visible and can be chosen again. Locke must accept the forgiveness he was never able to give himself; Ben must choose the daughter; Charlie must want to live; Claire must hold her son. In each case the repair is an act of fidelity freely performed, and in each case it precedes, and makes possible, the recognition through which the character awakens.

6.6

Anagnorisis: the scar and the touch

The awakenings of the sideways are recognitions in Aristotle's technical sense. *Anagnōrisis*, the *Poetics* explains, is "a change from ignorance to knowledge, leading either to friendship or to enmity" among those marked for good or ill fortune (1452a29–32), and in every awakening of the sideways the change leads to *philia*. Aristotle classified recognitions by their means (ch. 16). The least artful come through signs, such as scars and necklaces; others are contrived by

the poet; others come through memory, when the sight or sound of something awakens feeling, as when Odysseus weeps at the Phaeacian court on hearing the bard sing of Troy; others through reasoning; and the best arise from the incidents themselves. The sideways uses all of them, but it privileges two: the sign upon the body and the memory awakened by sensation—a touch, a voice, a birth, a song at a concert.

The sign upon the body leads back to the West's first scene of recognition. In the nineteenth book of the *Odyssey*, the old nurse Eurycleia, washing the feet of a disguised stranger, feels beneath her hand the scar left by a boar's tusk on Mount Parnassus and knows that he is Odysseus; and Homer, at the moment of recognition, digresses for some seventy lines to tell the story of the scar (19.386–475). Erich Auerbach made the scene the subject of the first chapter of *Mimesis* (1946), where he set the Homeric style—which illuminates everything uniformly and knows only a foreground, so that even a digression at the climax creates no suspense—against the style of Genesis 22, whose sparse narrative of the Akedah is, in his term, *hintergründig*, fraught with background: its God unexplained, its motives unspoken, its silences heavy with meaning. *Lost* is a synthesis of Auerbach's two styles. Its flashbacks are Homeric: they halt the action at its climax to tell the story of every scar, illuminating each castaway's past in the uniform light of melodrama. Its mythology is Abrahamic: Jacob's motives, the Light's nature, and the island's purpose remain in the background, and the series' silences are heavy with meaning. Chapter 10 develops the narratological consequences. Here it matters that the series' recognitions, like Homer's, are written on the body.

They are. In the fourth season Juliet removes Jack's appendix on the island ("Something Nice Back Home," 4.10); in the sideways, Jack notices an appendectomy scar he cannot account for and asks his mother when the operation took place, and she answers that it was performed when he was a child ("Lighthouse," 6.05). The afterlife body bears the island's surgery, and the world beyond time supplies it with a false biography until recognition restores the true one. More uncanny still, in "LA X" Jack, aboard the flight that will land safely in Los Angeles, finds a small fresh cut bleeding on his neck; in "The End," on the cliffs, the Man in Black cuts his neck with a knife. The sideways body carries a wound the island's narrative has not yet given—a sign whose meaning becomes available only retrospectively, as in Aquinas's *aevum*, in which before and after are joined to a duration that has none in itself (Chapter 5). Odysseus's scar identifies the man by his past; Jack's identifies him by his death.

Ricoeur's last book, *Parcours de la reconnaissance* (2004), traced the concept of recognition along a path the sideways also travels: from recognition as identification, through the recognition of oneself, to mutual recognition, which Ricoeur found fulfilled not in the struggle for recognition that Hegel described but in what he called "states of peace"—the gift, the ceremony, *agapē*. The French word carries a meaning the English lacks: *reconnaissance* is also gratitude. The awakenings of the sideways are recognitions in all three senses and in the fourth. Each character identifies the other; each recognizes himself in being recognized; the recognition is mutual; and it issues, again and again, in gratitude. Locke thanks Jack and wishes him

the same mercy. Hurley tells Ben, outside the church, that he was a great number two, and Ben answers that Hurley was a great number one. And Ben, from his bench, apologizes to Locke for what he did to him—for his selfishness, his jealousy, the murder he committed—and Locke forgives him ("The End").

The forgiveness is the summit of the series' anthropology. Ricoeur's epilogue to *La mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli* (2000) called forgiveness "difficult," and Jacques Derrida argued in the same years that forgiveness worthy of the name forgives only the unforgivable—that to forgive the forgivable is merely to excuse. Ben's murder of Locke is unforgivable by every measure the series has offered: Ben strangled a man he had just talked out of killing himself, a man who had begun to trust him, and then disguised the murder as the suicide he had prevented, and it delivered Locke's body to the adversary. Only the victim can forgive it, and the victim does. Recognition, in *Lost*, culminates not in knowledge but in pardon.

6.7

The smoke and the constant

The series' anthropology has a negative image, and it is the Man in Black. Chapter 2 read him as evil in Augustine's sense, a privation of the good with no substance of its own. He can also be read as the self in Hume's sense—as what a person becomes when nothing constant and invariable holds it together. He has no name; he has no form but smoke; he can appear only in the borrowed shapes of the dead; and he has spent centuries longing for a home he has never seen. He is the bundle of perceptions personified, a theater in which faces pass, re-pass, glide away, and mingle in an infinite variety of postures, and in which there is, as Hume said of the mind, properly no identity. He is also the self that Pascal declared hateful—"le moi est haïssable"—because it is unjust in itself, making itself the center of everything, and troublesome to others, seeking to enslave them (L597/B455). And he is the one figure in the series who has no constant. His mother lied to him; his brother cast him into the Light; the people he chose to live among were massacred; in all his centuries no one keeps faith with him or is kept by him. The series' two Humes are its two answers to Hume. Desmond David Hume, who has a constant, survives the dispersal of his times. The nameless smoke, which has none, *is* that dispersal.

Against both the Lockean self that owns itself—"every Man has a Property in his own Person," Locke wrote in the *Second Treatise* (§27), founding what C. B. Macpherson called possessive individualism (1962)—and the Humean self that is nothing but its passing perceptions, the series sets a self that is held. Christian Shephard states the doctrine in the church, in five words that answer the whole tradition the series' names invoke: "Nobody does it alone, Jack." Jack needed the others, and they needed him. The self is neither a property nor a bundle but a trust, and it persists through time as it is kept by others and keeps them in turn. The pilot's maxim—live together or die alone—turns out to have been not only an ethic of survival but a metaphysics of personhood. The question that follows is political. If the self is a trust held by

others, what kind of rule could keep a community of such selves? Chapter 7 argues that the series' answer is custody.

Chapter 7

Custody

Sovereignty, Pastorate, Panopticon, Katechon



The island of *Lost* is a laboratory of regimes. Over six seasons it is governed, claimed, or contested by a survivors' commonwealth, a security state in the tail section, a technocratic utopia, a theocracy ruling in the name of an unseen patriarch, a capitalist who regards it as his property, an insurgent who promises exit, the hidden patriarch himself, a sacrificial protector who reigns for a single night, and finally a lottery winner with a former tyrant as his deputy. Each regime is a theory of sovereignty drawn from the Western canon, and the series tests each against a single criterion that its sacred vocabulary supplies: whether the regime *keeps* what is entrusted to it or disposes of it. Carl Schmitt's thesis in *Politische Theologie* (1922)—"Alle prägnanten Begriffe der modernen Staatslehre sind säkularisierte theologische Begriffe"—describes a one-way passage by which the concepts of theology became, in secular dress, the concepts of the modern state. *Lost* runs the passage in reverse. On the island the secularized concepts of modern sovereignty—decision, administration, property, legitimacy—are re-theologized, and the last regime the series stages is one for which the modern state has no name. This chapter calls it *custody*: a sovereignty that keeps without owning, restrains without dominating, and can amend its own law in equity. Its theological models are the keeper of Genesis and the restrainer of 2 Thessalonians; its literary model is Prospero after the drowning of his book; and its first holder is the least imperial man on the island.

7.1

Who keeps the keeper? The vocabulary of custody

Chapter 2 located the scriptural matrix of custody in the Hebrew verb *shamar*, to keep or guard, which Genesis employs at three decisive points: Adam is placed in the garden "to dress it and to keep it" (2:15); the cherubim are stationed "to keep the way of the tree of life" (3:24); and Cain, asked where his brother is, answers, "Am I my brother's keeper?" (4:9). The verb recurs at the heart of Israel's liturgy. The priestly blessing begins, "The LORD bless thee, and keep thee" (Numbers 6:24), and the psalmist's confidence rests on a sleepless guardian: "he that keepeth Israel shall neither slumber nor sleep" (Psalm 121:4). The island's office belongs to the same register. Jacob is not its king, lord, or owner but its protector, and the Others' shibboleth names the one in the statue's shadow not as the one who will rule them but as *ille qui nos omnes servabit*, the one who will keep—or save—us all. The Latin *servare* holds both senses, and the series exploits the ambiguity: to keep a people is to save it.

Custody raises at once the oldest question of political theory, which Juvenal posed in a satire on the guarding of wives: "sed quis custodiet ipsos custodes?" (*Satires* VI.347–348)—but who will guard the guardians themselves? Every regime the island hosts gives an answer, explicit or implicit, and the answers can be set side by side.

Table 6 *The nine regimes of the island*

Regime	Seasons	Theory of sovereignty	Ground of legitimacy	Characteristic instrument	End
Survivors' commonwealth (Jack)	1–2	Contract and the reluctant sovereign	Consent; necessity	The founding maxim; control of the marshal's guns	Dispersed by departure and the flash-forwards
Tail section (Ana Lucia)	2	Hobbesian security	Fear	The pit	Dissolved; Ana Lucia killed (2.20)
DHARMA Initiative	5 (the 1970s)	Technocracy; biopolitics	Rational-legal	Stations, orientation films, the truce	The Purge (3.20)
The Others (Ben)	2–4	Theocracy; pastoral power	Tradition, hollowed out	Lists, files, abductions, noble lies	Fractured; the Temple massacred (6.06)
Widmore	4–6	Proprietary sovereignty	Money	Freighter and mercenaries	Widmore shot (6.16)
The Man in Black	6	Insurgent charisma	Charisma; the promise of exit	Recruitment, answers, impersonation	Killed (6.17–6.18)
Jacob	1–6, hidden	Providential rule	The sacred; election	Touches, rules, the lighthouse	Killed (5.16–5.17)
Jack, protector	6	Sacrificial kingship	Vocation	The cup; the stone	Dies restoring the Light (6.17–6.18)
Hurley, with Ben	6 and epilogue	Custody	Trust; care	Equity; "a better way"	Open

The table's final column records a pattern that the rest of the chapter interprets. Every regime founded on possession, decision, or management ends in violence; the only regime whose end the series leaves open is the one founded on care.

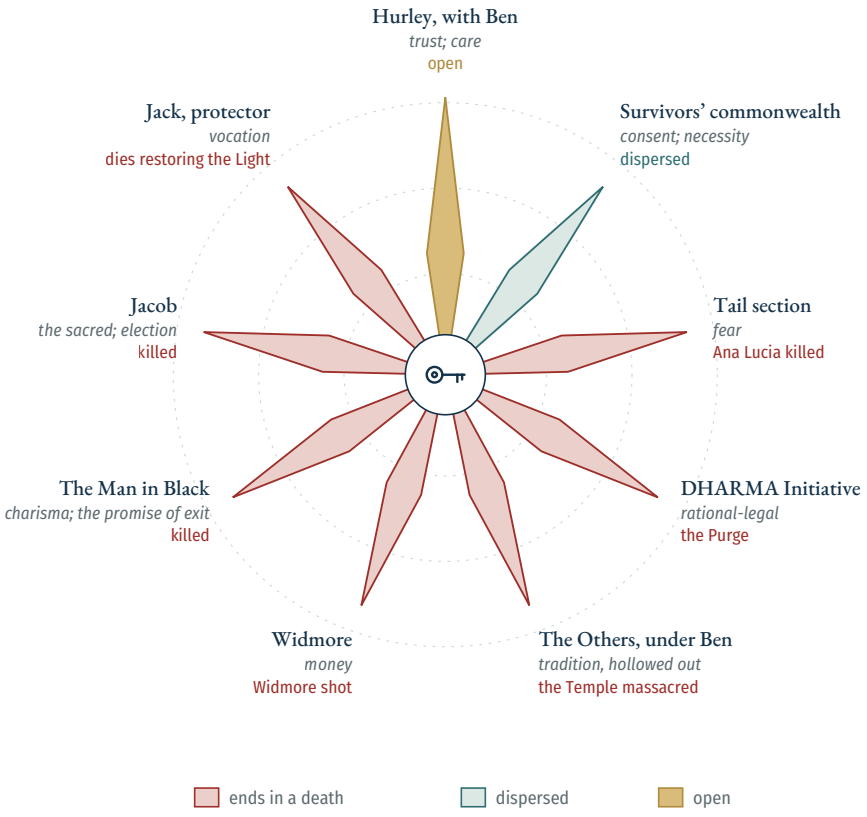


Figure 6 *The nine regimes of the island (7.1), each with the ground of its legitimacy and its end. Seven end in a death; the commonwealth disperses; Hurley's custody alone remains open.*

7.2

The exception on the beach

The first polity on the island begins in a Hobbesian condition. In the days after the crash the castaways compete for water, salvage, and medicine; Sawyer hoards; a pistol circulates; and the threat of the jungle—the roaring thing that tore the pilot from his cockpit—makes life what Hobbes said life without a common power would be, "solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short" (*Leviathan*, ch. 13). The commonwealth that emerges is founded, as Hobbes's is, by the transfer of authority to a sovereign, but its sovereign does not want the office. In "White Rab-

bit" (1.05) Jack protests that he is not a leader, and he accepts the role only when he returns from the jungle having found fresh water and tells the castaways that, unless they learn to live together, they will die alone. The maxim is the commonwealth's covenant. It also anticipates with uncanny exactness Hannah Arendt's definition of power in *On Violence* (1970): power corresponds to the human ability not merely to act but to act in concert; it belongs not to an individual but to a group and exists only so long as the group holds together. Power and violence, Arendt argued, are opposites, and where the one rules absolutely the other is absent. "Live together, die alone" is a theory of power in Arendt's sense, and its antithesis is the violence that every subsequent regime on the island will substitute for it.

The commonwealth's first sovereign act, however, is a decision on the exception. When Shannon suffers an asthma attack and her inhalers cannot be found, Jack, believing that Sawyer has hidden them, permits Sayid—a former interrogator in the Iraqi Republican Guard—to torture him; Sawyer never had them, and Sayid, ashamed, leaves the camp ("Confidence Man," 1.08). Schmitt's definition—"Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet," sovereign is he who decides on the state of exception—was meant to expose the decision that grounds every legal order, and the island's first order is grounded exactly so: its sovereign suspends its norms in an emergency, and the suspension falls upon a body. The question of sovereignty then becomes, as Max Weber's definition of the state predicts, a question of the monopoly of legitimate force ("Politik als Beruf," 1919). The marshal's case of firearms passes into Jack's control and then into the Swan's armory, and Sawyer's elaborate scheme to seize the guns in "The Long Con" (2.13) is the commonwealth's first coup.

The tail section offers the alternative the commonwealth avoided. Its survivors, led by Ana Lucia Cortez—a former police officer who bears a conquistador's surname—live forty-eight days in fear, abducted one by one by the Others; when Ana Lucia discovers an infiltrator among them, she kills him ("The Other 48 Days," 2.07). Her regime is pure security: a perimeter, a pit in which suspected enemies are held, and a readiness to shoot that ends in her killing Shannon by mistake ("Abandoned," 2.06). Arendt's distinction divides the two beaches. Jack's commonwealth, for all its exceptions, rests on power; Ana Lucia's rests on violence, and it disintegrates when the fear that held it together meets an object it cannot master.

7.3

DHARMA: the administration of things

Chapter 3 read the DHARMA Initiative as Bacon's Salomon's House. Politically it is a technocracy, and its theory of rule is the one Friedrich Engels, paraphrasing Saint-Simon, ascribed to the society of the future, in which "the government of persons is replaced by the administration of things" (*Anti-Dühring*, 1878). DHARMA governs by procedure: stations with assigned functions, jumpsuits stamped with station logos, rations dropped by parachute, and orientation films that instruct each new occupant in his task. Its form of power is what Michel Foucault called biopower, which seeks not to take life but to manage it—to "make live

and let die," in the formula of his lecture of 17 March 1976 (*Il faut défendre la société*)—and its laboratories of meteorology, psychology, zoology, and electromagnetism treat the island and its inhabitants as populations to be measured.

Its emblem is the Panopticon. Bentham's circular prison, in which an unseen inspector observes every cell, became in Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) the diagram of disciplinary modernity: the prisoner who cannot know when he is watched comes to watch himself, so that power operates without being exercised. The Swan is a panoptic cell and the Pearl its inspection tower, whose monitors recorded the button-pushers' compliance in notebooks ("?," 2.21). The series then extends the diagram into an infinite regress. On one of the Pearl's monitors Locke and Eko glimpse a man with an eyepatch watching from yet another station: the observers were themselves observed. Above the Others' surveillance stands Jacob's lighthouse, whose mirrors watch the candidates' homes across the world; and above Jacob, the series implies, nothing—or a light. Panopticism on the island has no center. Every inspector is inspected, and the apex of the tower is empty.

DHARMA's sovereignty is also bounded, and its boundary is a treaty. The Initiative lives behind a sonic fence under a truce with the island's older inhabitants, negotiated with Richard Alpert and enforced along a line neither party may cross ("LaFleur," 5.08). The administration of things depends, in other words, on an unadministered remainder—the "Hostiles"—whose sovereignty it cannot abolish and whose sacred claims it cannot understand. The truce ends in the Purge. In 1992 the Others gas the Initiative and leave its dead in a pit; Ben, who had grown up within it, takes part, and personally kills his own father, Roger, with the gas ("The Man Behind the Curtain," 3.20). The technocracy that would replace the government of persons with the administration of things is destroyed by a theocracy that governs persons in the name of a person no one has seen.

7.4

The Grand Inquisitor: Ben's theocracy

The regime that destroys DHARMA is the series' study of religious power, and its literary model is the most searching analysis of such power in modern fiction. In the fifth book of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan tells his brother Alyosha the legend of the Grand Inquisitor, the aged cardinal of Seville who arrests Christ upon his return and explains to him why the Church has corrected his work. Christ offered human beings a freedom too terrible for them to bear; the Church has relieved them of it by ruling through "miracle, mystery, and authority," giving them bread and something to worship, and keeping from them the secret that their rulers no longer serve the one in whose name they govern. Ben Linus is the Grand Inquisitor of the island. He rules the Others in Jacob's name without ever having seen Jacob. He governs by miracle—he can summon the Monster, as he does from a hidden chamber in his own house to destroy the mercenaries who have killed his daughter ("The Shape of Things to Come," 4.09)—by mystery, in the form of lists, files, and the unexplained will of an invis-

ible patriarch, and by authority, which he exercises with a mixture of tenderness and contempt for the flock that Dostoevsky's cardinal would have recognized. When the one in whose name he rules at last receives him, the parallel breaks in the most violent way possible. Dostoevsky's Christ answers the Inquisitor with a kiss, and the Inquisitor releases him into the night. Ben stabs Jacob.

Ben's regime also rests on what Plato called the noble lie. The *Republic* permits the rulers of the just city to lie for the city's good (389b) and proposes a founding myth—that the citizens were fashioned in the earth with gold, silver, or bronze in their souls—to reconcile each class to its station (414b–415d). The island's first noble lie is maternal. Mother tells her sons that there is nothing and no one across the sea, in order, she believes, to protect them from the corruption of other people; the lie provokes the younger son's revolt and the series' founding catastrophe ("Across the Sea"). Ben's regime multiplies such lies. The Others costume themselves as primitives, invent a stranded balloonist named "Henry Gale," conceal a submarine and a suburb, and assure their captives that they are, in Tom's phrase, the good guys. In the second season the captive "Henry Gale" passes his days in the Swan's armory with a copy of *The Brothers Karamazov* from its shelves. Every regime on the island founded on a noble lie collapses, and the series draws the conclusion Plato did not: a polity kept by lies cannot keep anyone.

The form of Ben's rule is what Foucault, in his lectures *Sécurité, territoire, population* (1977–1978) and his Tanner Lecture "Omnes et singulatim" (1979), called pastoral power: the power of a shepherd over a flock, which differs from the power of a city's magistrate in being exercised over each individual as well as all—*omnes et singulatim*—and in requiring the shepherd to know every soul and to answer for it. The Others' power is pastoral in this precise sense. Ethan infiltrates the castaways in the first season to compile a list; the Others hold files on every survivor's history; Juliet keeps a dossier on Jack; and the lists by which Ben decides whom to take and whom to leave claim to sort the good from the rest. The series names the true pastor and the false. Jack's surname is Shephard and his father's name Christian, and the Johannine Good Shepherd lays down his life for the sheep (John 10:11). Ben is the hireling of the following verse, "whose own the sheep are not," who governs the flock for his own ends.

Ben's sovereignty is broken from within, and the series marks the breaking with a child. After Alex's death he vows to kill Widmore's daughter in revenge. In "Dead Is Dead" (5.12) he finds Penny at the marina where Desmond's boat is moored, shoots Desmond, and raises his gun at her—and then sees her small son, Charlie, and hesitates; Desmond beats him and throws him into the water. The face of a child stays the sovereign's hand. It is the second voice of Chapter 4, heard by the series' most practiced liar, and it inaugurates the long repentance that ends with his reception by Ilana and his bench outside the church.

7.5

"The island was mine": proprietary sovereignty

Charles Widmore's claim to the island is at once the oldest and the most modern of the series' theories of sovereignty, and it is Lockean. In the chapter "Of Property" of the *Second Treatise* (1690), Locke argued that whatever a man removes from the common state of nature by mixing his labor with it becomes his property, and that government exists chiefly for the preservation of property. Widmore once led the Others, until Ben exiled him for leaving the island and fathering a child beyond it ("Dead Is Dead"); thereafter he regards the island as stolen goods. Visited in his London bedroom by Ben, he tells him that the island was his, that Ben took it from him, and that he will take it back ("The Shape of Things to Come"). The instruments of reclamation are those of capital. He buys at auction the logbook of the *Black Rock*, whose wreck lies on the island ("Live Together, Die Alone," 2.23–2.24); according to the Others, he stages a counterfeit wreck of Oceanic 815 at the bottom of the Sunda Trench, complete with exhumed bodies, so that the world will stop looking for the real one ("Meet Kevin Johnson," 4.08); and he charters a freighter, hires a physicist, a medium, and an anthropologist, and arms a company of mercenaries under Martin Keamy. Proprietary sovereignty defends its claim with private violence, and Keamy's execution of Alex is the logical terminus of a theory in which the island is a thing to be owned rather than a place to be kept.

The series' verdict on the proprietor is severe but not without mercy. In the final season Widmore returns to the island claiming that Jacob visited him and persuaded him of his errors, and he brings Desmond as an instrument against the Man in Black. The conversion, if it is one, comes too late to redeem the method: he still treats Desmond as a weapon to be tested, exposing him to lethal electromagnetic radiation to confirm his immunity ("Happily Ever After," 6.11). In "What They Died For" (6.16), at the moment he agrees to tell the Man in Black why he has come, Ben shoots him, remarking that Widmore does not get to save his daughter. The proprietor's secret dies with him.

7.6

The adversary's charisma

Max Weber distinguished three pure types of legitimate domination: rational-legal authority, grounded in enacted rules and exercised through bureaucracy; traditional authority, grounded in the sanctity of inherited orders; and charismatic authority, grounded in devotion to the extraordinary qualities of a person (*Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, 1922). The island's regimes map onto Weber's types with diagrammatic clarity. DHARMA is rational-legal: its authority resides in procedures, stations, and films. The Others under Ben are traditional authority hollowed out: their legitimacy rests on the sanctity of an order transmitted from Jacob through Richard, but its present administrator has no access to its source. The Man in Black, in the

final season, is charismatic. He gathers followers—Claire, Sayid, the remnant of the Temple's Others, and for a time Sawyer and Kate—by the force of his person and by two promises: that he will answer every question they have asked since they arrived, and that he will take them off the island. His recruiting gives the series an episode title ("The Last Recruit," 6.13), and his rhetoric is that of the charismatic leader as Weber described him, whose characteristic formula is "It is written..., but I say unto you."

Weber observed that charismatic authority is inherently unstable: it must either prove itself continually through success or be "routinized" into a traditional or legal order. The Man in Black's charisma cannot be routinized, because its promise cannot be kept without destroying the world. His program is the Gnostic exodus of Chapter 2 converted into politics—freedom defined as exit—and Mother had warned that if the Light goes out on the island, it goes out everywhere. The charismatic insurgent offers his followers what no regime can lawfully grant: escape from the very condition the regime exists to keep.

7.7

The hidden sovereign and the King of the Wood

Above all these regimes stands one whose sovereign is never seen. For five seasons Jacob is a name, a list, a cabin ringed with ash, and a voice that may not be his. Chapter 2 called him the *Deus absconditus* of Isaiah 45:15, and his mode of rule has a precise analogue in the political theology of Twelver Shi'ism. When the twelfth Imam entered the Lesser Occultation in 874, he was held to communicate with the community through four successive deputies; with the death of the fourth in 941 the Greater Occultation began, in which no designated deputy speaks for him, and the question of who may exercise his authority became a central problem of Shi'i jurisprudence. The island passes through the same two phases (Grade C). Richard Alpert is the true deputy, the intermediary who has seen the hidden sovereign and conveys his will; Ben is the claimant of a deputyship he never received, ruling in an occultation he exploits. The structural problem is the same in both cases: a sovereign who governs by absence must be represented, and every representative is open to the charge of usurpation.

Jacob's succession follows a darker pattern, and its anthropology is Frazer's. *The Golden Bough* (1890) opens in the sacred grove of Diana at Nemi, where a priest called the King of the Wood prowls with drawn sword around a certain tree, awaiting the challenger who will slay him and take his office; the challenger's right is won by plucking a branch from the tree—the golden bough that, in the sixth book of the *Aeneid*, is Aeneas's passport to the underworld (VI.136–148). Frazer made the priest of Nemi the emblem of a sacred kingship transmitted by violence, in which the king's vigor is the land's and his death the condition of its renewal. The island's office passes in this way. Mother acquired her children by killing their mother; her favored son killed her; Jacob is killed by Ben at the instigation of the brother he wronged. René Girard, in *La violence et le sacré* (1972), generalized the pattern into a theory of the founding murder, on which a community's order rests upon a collective violence that its

myths conceal. "Across the Sea" is a founding myth of exactly this kind, and its concealed violence is maternal: the island's sacred order begins with the killing of a mother.

The last protector before Hurley breaks the pattern. Jack is chosen not by killing a predecessor but by volunteering; he receives the office from Jacob's hand in a liturgy of water ("What They Died For"); and he reigns for a single night, dying not as a slain king but as a self-offered one, after descending into the Heart to restore the stone that Desmond had lifted. Girard argued that the Gospels break the sacrificial cycle by revealing the innocence of the victim and replacing the founding murder with a voluntary death. Jack's death is of the second kind. The office that had passed by violence passes, through him, by gift.

7.8

The cork: the island as *katechon*

The island's theology of sovereignty culminates in an image Jacob offers Richard Alpert in "Ab Aeterno" (6.09). He holds up a bottle of wine and explains that the wine is darkness—malevolence, evil—swirling inside, unable to get out; the island is the cork that keeps it where it belongs. The image condenses a figure that has haunted Western political theology since Paul. In the second letter to the Thessalonians, the apostle tells his readers that the day of the Lord will not come until the "man of sin" is revealed, and that something now restrains him: "And now ye know what withholdeth that he might be revealed in his time. For the mystery of iniquity doth already work: only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way. And then shall that Wicked be revealed" (2 Thessalonians 2:6–8). The restraining power—*to katechon*, "what withholds," and *ho katechōn*, "he who withholds"—was identified by patristic commentators with the Roman Empire, whose order held back the final chaos; and Carl Schmitt, in *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950), made the *katechon* the key to Christian political theology, the historical power that restrains the Antichrist and thereby makes history possible.

The island is a *katechon* in the most literal sense the series could devise. It is the cork that withholds the darkness; Jacob is the one who withholds; and the sequence of the fifth and sixth seasons follows Paul's prophecy with uncanny exactness. Only he who now withholds will do so until he be taken out of the way: Jacob is killed in "The Incident." Then shall the lawless one be revealed: in the same episode Ilana's party brings a crate to the foot of the statue and tips from it the corpse of John Locke, and the figure who has worn Locke's face stands disclosed as the adversary. In "The End" the cork is literally drawn. Desmond is lowered into the Heart of the Island and lifts the stone from its socket; the light goes out, the water drains away, the ground begins to split, and the adversary, become mortal, can be killed. Jack descends and replaces the stone, and the light returns.

Giorgio Agamben, in *Il tempo che resta* (2000), turned the Pauline passage against Schmitt: the *katechon*, he suggested, is any power—above all the state—that delays and conceals the messianic, and Christian political theology's attachment to it is a refusal of the time that remains. *Lost* sides with neither. Its *katechon* is not an empire, as Schmitt wished, nor a state,

as Agamben feared, but a keeper; and the restraint it exercises is not domination but custody. Jacob's custody, however, is compromised by his Molinism and his manipulations, and the series does not leave the office in his hands, or even in Jack's.

7.9

Custody: the reign of the heart-king

In the final hour of "The End," Jack, mortally wounded, gives the office to Hurley. He fills a bottle with water from the stream, speaks the words Jacob spoke to him, has Hurley drink, and tells him that it is supposed to be him. Hurley protests that he does not know what to do. Ben, who has stayed with him, answers that he should do what he does best: take care of people. Hurley objects that Jacob's rule was that no one could leave the island, and Ben observes that that was how Jacob ran things—that there might be another way, a better one—and that they could begin by helping Desmond go home. The exchange is the series' political resolution, and it is an abjuration in Prospero's sense (Chapter 3). The new keeper renounces the rough magic of his predecessor—the touches, the tests, the rule that no one leaves—and begins his reign with an act of release.

Three features distinguish Hurley's custody from every regime the island has hosted. The first is *equity*. Aristotle defined *epieikeia* as the correction of law where it errs by reason of its universality—a justice that does what the lawgiver would have done had he foreseen the case (*Nicomachean Ethics* V.10). Jacob ruled by rules, and the brothers' war was a war of loopholes; Hurley, advised by Ben, can amend the rule that no one leaves when keeping it would do harm. The second is *collegiality*. Juvenal's question—who will guard the guardians?—receives on the island its first satisfactory answer: the keeper is kept. Hurley rules with a deputy, and the deputy is the island's former tyrant, now repentant. Outside the church in the sideways each names the other's office with affection: Hurley calls Ben a great number two, and Ben calls Hurley a great number one. Custody is not a solitary sovereignty but a mutual trust. The third is *truthfulness*. Chapter 2 identified Hurley as the series' *ashavan*, the man who cannot sustain a lie. His reign is the first on the island not founded on a noble lie, and his first act of custody was performed long before his accession. In "Raised by Another" (1.10) he took a census of the survivors—not, like the Others, in order to sort them into lists, but in order to know who they were—and his census exposed Ethan as an impostor absent from the flight manifest. The custodian's knowledge of each, *omnes et singulatim*, is pastoral power purified of domination.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) supplies the political theory of such a reign. Action, Arendt argued, suffers from two predicaments: it is irreversible, because what has been done cannot be undone, and it is unpredictable, because its consequences cannot be foreseen. The remedy for irreversibility is the faculty of forgiving; the remedy for unpredictability is the faculty of making and keeping promises. Both depend on plurality—no one can forgive himself or be bound by a promise made only to himself—and together they make

political community possible. The series' anthropology has already supplied both: forgiveness in Locke's pardon of Ben, promise in the constancy of Chapter 6. Hurley's custody is a polity of promise and forgiveness, founded by the two men whose relation required both. Arendt ended her account of action with natality, the fact that new human beings are born, which she called the miracle that saves the world and whose highest expression she found in the Gospels' announcement that a child has been born unto us. The central awakening of the sideways is a birth.

The paracanonical epilogue "The New Man in Charge" (2010) adds a coda that confirms the character of the new regime. Ben, acting on Hurley's behalf, shuts down the DHARMA facility that has gone on shipping food to the island for decades; then he visits Walt—the boy the Others once abducted for his gifts, and whom the series itself had left behind—in a psychiatric hospital, apologizes for having taken him, and tells him that he cannot change the past but can take responsibility for it, and that although Walt's father is dead, Walt can still help him; Hurley, waiting in the van outside, assures Walt that he is not crazy, that the island is his home, and that there is a job for him there. The new keeper's first recorded act of government is to retrieve the child whom the old regimes had used and the narrative had forgotten. Its agent is the man who once ruled by abduction: Ben's first errand under the new regime ends in an apology to the child he took. The Others' shibboleth has found its meaning at last. The one who lies in the shadow of the statue, *ille qui nos omnes servabit*, is not the patriarch who manipulated them nor the protector who died for them, but the heart-king—Hugo, mind and heart; Reyes, kings (Chapter 1)—who keeps them by caring for them, one by one. Custody does not, however, answer the question Jacob's regime raises most sharply: how a keeper who permitted so much suffering can be called good. Chapter 8 turns to the twins and the Light.

Chapter 8

The Twins and the Light

Theodicy, Dualism, and the Chthonic Good

"Across the Sea" (6.15), broadcast less than two weeks before the finale and the most divisive episode of the final season, is the series' theodicy. It narrates, in sacred and undated time, the birth of the twins, the origin of the Monster, and the nature of the Light, and it answers the question the castaways had been asking since the pilot—why is there evil on the island, and why does its keeper permit it?—in a form the theological tradition would not have predicted. Its answer is not Manichaean: the twins are not principles of good and evil but brothers, each marked by the other's quality. It is not Leibnizian: the island is not the best of possible worlds but a wounded one. And it is not, finally, a defense of the keeper at all. *Lost* places its god on trial, lets the plaintiffs' complaints stand, extracts a confession, and then transfers the keeping of the Good from the god to his accusers. This chapter argues that the series' theology rests on two innovations. The first is a *familial theodicy*: evil originates not in a cosmic principle but in a household—a mother's lie, a mother's partiality, a brother's rage. The second is a doctrine of the *chthonic Good*: the Good is not the sun above the cave, as in Plato, but a light within the cave, beneath the earth and in its waters, real and life-giving but vulnerable, and dependent for its continuance on those who keep it. Theodicy, in *Lost*, is not answered. It is transfigured into custody.

8.1

Epicurus on the island

The problem the series confronts received its classical formulation in an argument Lactantius attributed to Epicurus (*De ira Dei* 13.20–21) and Hume restated in the tenth part of the *Dia-*

logues concerning Natural Religion (1779): "Is he willing to prevent evil, but not able? then is he impotent. Is he able, but not willing? then is he malevolent. Is he both able and willing? whence then is evil?" On the island the question acquires a defendant. In "What They Died For" (6.16), the dead Jacob appears beside a fire to the four surviving candidates and explains why he brought them to the island. Sawyer protests that he was doing fine until Jacob dragged him to this rock; Kate demands to know why her name was crossed off the cave wall; and behind their questions stand the dead—Sun and Jin, drowned only hours before, Sayid, Juliet, Charlie, Boone, Shannon, Libby, Ana Lucia, Charlotte, Daniel, Ilana, and the rest.

Jacob's defense is a theodicy of vocation. He did not pluck any of them from a happy existence, he tells them; they were all flawed, all alone, all looking for something they could not find in the world; he chose them because they were like him, and because they needed the island as much as it needed them. The argument belongs to the tradition John Hick called Irenaean (*Evil and the God of Love*, 1966), after Irenaeus of Lyon's teaching that human beings were created immature, in God's image but not yet in his likeness, to grow toward perfection through struggle (*Adversus haereses* IV.37–39). Keats gave the tradition its most memorable phrase in a letter of April 1819: "Call the world if you Please 'The vale of Soul-making.'" Jacob's island is a vale of soul-making, and the series' arcs bear him partial witness: Sawyer becomes James, Ben becomes a penitent, Hurley becomes a keeper, Jack becomes a believer.

The witness is partial because soul-making has casualties who were not made. Boone dies in the first season, Shannon and Libby and Ana Lucia in the second, before their stories had run their course. The Irenaean theodicy justifies suffering by its fruits, and the dead bear no fruit on the island. The series acknowledges the objection by refusing to let Jacob's answer stand alone. It supplements his theodicy with an eschatology—the sideways, in which the dead too are gathered and remembered—and it subjects him to a trial whose verdict Section 8.5 reconstructs. First, however, it tells the story of the household in which the island's evil began.

8.2

A household of origins

"Across the Sea" opens on a beach, in Latin. A shipwrecked woman named Claudia, heavily pregnant, staggers ashore and is found by a woman the credits call only Mother. She gives birth to a son she names Jacob—and then, unexpectedly, to a second son, for whom, having chosen only one name, she has none. Mother takes the second child in her arms, and soon afterward she kills Claudia with a stone and raises the boys as her own. Everything in the island's subsequent history descends from this scene, and its components are worth enumerating, because each will recur: a birth of twins, the second unexpected and unnamed; a substitute mother who acquires her children by killing their mother; and a lie to cover the killing.

The lie becomes doctrine. Mother teaches the boys that there is nothing across the sea, that the island is the whole world, and—when they discover that there are other people, the survivors of Claudia's ship—that people are greedy, manipulative, and untrustworthy. She shows them the Light at the island's heart and tells them that they must protect it, and she makes it so, she says, that they can never hurt each other. Her preference for the younger, more curious son is evident enough that Jacob asks whether she loves his brother more. When the younger son is thirteen, the ghost of Claudia appears to him and tells him the truth: she is his mother, the woman who raised him killed her, and the people across the island are his people. He leaves to live among them. Thirty years later he has discovered that metal behaves strangely at certain places on the island, has sunk wells, and is building a wheel to channel the Light and carry him away. Mother visits him, knocks him unconscious, fills in his well, and kills everyone in his village. He kills her with a knife; dying, she thanks him. Jacob, whom Mother has meanwhile designated her successor—telling him that it was always supposed to be him—beats his brother and throws him into the stream that flows into the Light, though Mother had warned that to go there would be worse than dying. A column of black smoke erupts from the cave. Jacob finds his brother's body downstream and lays it in a cave beside Mother's, with a pouch containing a black and a white stone from the boys' game. These are the skeletons that Jack and Kate discover in the first season and that Locke names Adam and Eve.

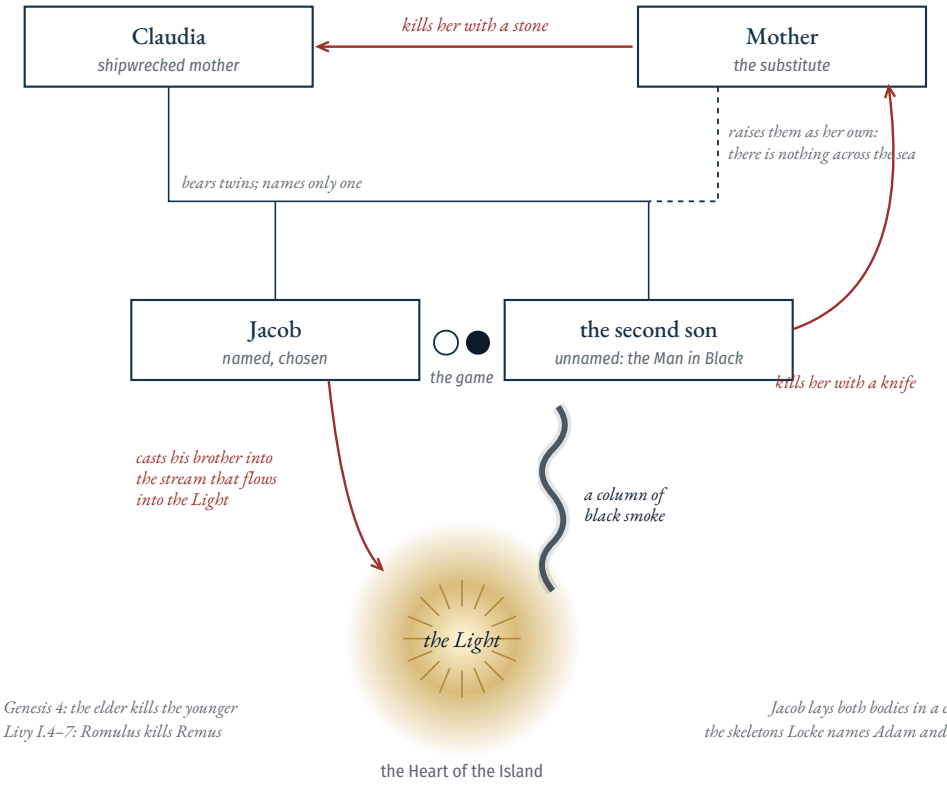


Figure 7 *A household of origins (8.2): a birth of twins, the second unnamed; a substitute mother who acquires her children by killing their mother; and the fratricide that makes the Man in Black.*

The myth inverts the founding fratricide of the West. In Genesis the elder brother, Cain, kills the younger out of jealousy of the divine regard Abel received; God then sets a mark upon Cain so that none who find him will kill him (4:15). In "Across the Sea" the elder brother, Jacob, destroys the younger in grief and rage at the death of the mother who had chosen him; and the mark of Cain becomes Mother's law that the brothers can never hurt each other. The island's god is Cain, and its devil is Abel—or rather, the thing Abel became when his brother cast him into the source of life. A second fratricide stands behind the episode's Latin. Romulus and Remus, twin sons of a mother punished for their birth, were suckled by a she-wolf, and Romulus killed his brother at the founding of Rome (Livy I.4–7). Augustine set the two founding murders side by side: the first founder of the earthly city was a fratricide, and so was the founder of Rome (*De civitate Dei* XV.5). Claudia bears a Roman name, the episode speaks Latin, and its twins are raised by a substitute mother who is, in her way, a she-wolf. The island's sacred order is founded, like Rome's, on the violence of brothers—and, beneath that, on the violence of a mother.

The Gnostic tradition offers a closer image still. In the *Apocryphon of John*, Sophia, the last of the divine aeons, conceives without her consort and brings forth an imperfect son, Yaldabaoth, a lion-faced serpent; ashamed, she casts him away from her and hides him in a luminous cloud, so that no one will see him. Yaldabaoth becomes the demiurge, the ignorant and jealous maker of the material world. The series' dark son is likewise the issue of a mother's desire to possess, and he too is hidden in a cloud—though here the cloud is smoke, and the son is not the maker of the world but its would-be fugitive. Chapter 2 noted the Zurvanite version, in which a father's doubt engenders the dark twin. In each variant the origin of evil is parental. *Lost* sharpens the motif into a principle. Its evil is not a substance, not a co-eternal principle, and not the inexplicable fall of a free creature; it is the fruit of a household's wounds —a mother's lie, her killing, her partiality, and a brother's rage.

This is what the chapter calls a familial theodicy, and its moral consequences are considerable. If evil is born in a household, it is neither necessary, as the Manichaeans held, nor wholly gratuitous, as some free-will defenses imply. It has a history, and what has a history can, in principle, be repaired. The repair the series envisions is not the abolition of the Monster's history but its remembrance: the Man in Black is never redeemed, but the households he wounded are gathered in the sideways, and the brother who cast him into the Light confesses that what he became was his doing.

8.3

Milton's mist and the refusal of dualism

The Monster's origin rewrites, with remarkable precision, the most famous return of the adversary in English poetry. In the ninth book of *Paradise Lost*, Satan, having circled the earth in darkness for seven nights, re-enters Eden by an underground river:

> There was a place, Now not, though Sin, not Time, first wrought the change, Where Tigris at the foot of Paradise Into a Gulf shot under ground, till part Rose up a Fountain by the Tree of Life; In with the River sunk, and with it rose Satan involv'd in rising Mist, then sought Where to lie hid. (IX.69–76)

He finds the serpent asleep, and "in at his Mouth / The Devil enter'd," possessing its brute sense and inspiring it with intelligence (IX.187–190). The sequence—a river that runs underground and rises as a fountain beside the Tree of Life; an adversary who emerges from it as rising mist; a search for a hiding place; and the occupation of a body not his own—is the sequence of the Man in Black's career (Grade C). He emerges as smoke from the stream that flows into the Light at the Heart of the Island, the series' Tree of Life; he lies hidden in the jungle for centuries; and he enters the island's history at last in the form of a dead man, John Locke, through whose body he speaks and acts. Milton's Satan confesses on Mount Niphates, "Which way I fly is Hell; my self am Hell" (IV.75), and every one of the Man in Black's attempts to fly is a flight from what he has become.

The Romantic reception of Milton anticipated the reception of "Across the Sea." Blake wrote that Milton was "of the Devils party without knowing it" (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, c. 1790–1793), and Shelley judged that Milton's Devil, as a moral being, was far superior to his God (*A Defence of Poetry*, 1821). Many viewers responded to the episode in the same spirit. The younger twin is wronged from birth: unnamed, lied to, deprived of his mother's people, his village destroyed, cast into the Light by his brother. His desire to know the truth and to go home is not evil but Odyssean (Chapter 3). C. S. Lewis's *A Preface to Paradise Lost* (1942) answered the Romantics by tracing Satan's steady degradation—from archangel to general, from general to politician, from politician to spy, to a toad squatting at Eve's ear, and finally to a snake—and the Man in Black's career descends by the same stages: from wronged boy to engineer, from engineer to murderer, from murderer to smoke, and from smoke to an impersonator of corpses. Both readings are invited, and the series does not choose between them. It shows how a wronged son becomes a devil, and it insists that the devil is no less a devil for having been wronged.

The refusal to choose is the series' refusal of dualism. Chapter 2 argued that the series moves, as Augustine did, from Manichaean imagery toward the doctrine of evil as privation; it also promised that the twins would finally be read through a figure other than the Manichaean, and that figure is the *taijitu*, the Taoist emblem of yin and yang, in which a seed of each principle lies within the other. The emblem fits the twins with uncomfortable precision. Jacob's light contains darkness: his rage created the Monster; his providence manipulates; his rule permits suffering he could prevent; and he condemns his brother to an eternity of confinement. The Man in Black's darkness contains a seed of light: his love for the mother he never knew, his longing for home, his refusal of the lie. Their game—the senet board found on the beach, continued in the backgammon Locke teaches Walt in the pilot—has two sides, one light and one dark, and its pieces end in a pouch beside the brother's corpse. The *Tao Te Ching* teaches that being and non-being produce each other, and that to recognize the beautiful as beautiful is already to posit the ugly (ch. 2). The island's protector and its prisoner are such a pair: the office of keeping exists because the darkness does, and the darkness exists because a keeper made it. The series' final images are not those of a light that has defeated darkness forever, but of a light restored and a darkness ended—by a mortal man who, unlike either twin, has a name, a constant, and friends.

8.4

The chthonic Good

Plato placed the Good above. In the sixth book of the *Republic*, Socrates compares the Form of the Good to the sun, which gives visible things both their visibility and their coming-to-be (508a–509b); in the seventh, the prisoners of the cave ascend from shadows and firelight to the open air and, at last, to the sun itself (514a–517a). The Western imagination of the highest good has been ouranic ever since: transcendent, self-sufficient, reached by ascent. *Lost* places

its Good below. The Light is in a cave at the island's heart, reached by descent—Desmond is lowered into it on a rope, and Jack climbs down after him—and it is bound up with water, a stream that flows into the cave and drains away when the stone is lifted. The ascent from the cave to the sun is replaced by a *katabasis* to a light within the earth. The Good of *Lost* is chthonic.

Mother names it in "Across the Sea." Showing the boys the glowing cave, she tells them that a little of this same light is inside every person, but that they always want more; that people will try to take it; and that if it goes out here, it goes out everywhere. Three properties follow, and each separates the series' theology from Plato's. The Light is *participated*: every human being carries a portion of it. It is *coveted*: its participants seek to possess more of it, and their covetousness—the Man in Black's wheel, DHARMA's drilling, Widmore's expeditions—endangers it. And it is *vulnerable*: it can go out, and if it does, the world goes dark. Plato's Good can be ignored but not extinguished. The island's Light can be extinguished, and the series stages its extinction in "The End," when Desmond lifts the stone, the glow turns to a dull red, the water drains away, and the island begins to break apart.

The closest structural parallel is the cosmology of Isaac Luria, the sixteenth-century kabbalist of Safed, as transmitted by his disciple Hayyim Vital and interpreted for the twentieth century by Gershom Scholem (*Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 1941). In the Lurianic myth, God first contracts himself (*tsimtsum*) to make room for a world; the divine light then streams into vessels that cannot contain it, and the vessels shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*), scattering sparks of holiness (*nitzotzot*) into the realm of the husks (*kelipot*), where they lie captive. The work of the world is *tikkun*, repair: the gathering of the scattered sparks through human acts. The Light at the Heart of the Island is the series' unbroken vessel, and the light within each person is the Lurianic spark (Grade C). The Incident—DHARMA's drilling into the electromagnetic pocket in 1977—is a breaking of the vessels in miniature: light released by covetous technique, which the Swan must thereafter be built to contain. And the protector's office is a perpetual *tikkun*, a keeping that holds the vessel whole.

Hans Jonas drew the theological consequence of such a cosmology in "Der Gottesbegriff nach Auschwitz" (delivered 1984; published 1987). Confronting a catastrophe that he held no theodicy could justify, Jonas proposed a myth: that God, for the sake of a world that could become itself, renounced his own omnipotence and gave himself over to the becoming world, so that he has nothing more to give, and it is now for human beings to give to him, by keeping what he entrusted to them. Jonas's God is not omnipotent but vulnerable, not the guarantor of the world but its ward. Etty Hillesum, writing in occupied Amsterdam in July 1942, had reached the same thought in prayer: that God could not help her, but that she must help God, by safeguarding the part of him that dwelt in her. Simone Weil spoke of creation as an act of divine withdrawal, an abdication in which God hides himself so that the world may be (*La pesanteur et la grâce*, 1947). The island's Light is such a Good: real, luminous, and life-giving, yet dependent on keepers. Mother's warning that its extinction here would be its extinc-

tion everywhere is Jonas's thesis in mythic form. The Good does not need to be defended; it needs to be kept.

The chthonic Good also clarifies the series' handling of its own enigmas. To the order of minds the Light appears as an electromagnetic anomaly, measurable and exploitable: DHARMA studies it, Widmore pursues it, Faraday theorizes it. To the order of charity it appears as the light of which every person carries a share. The series never reconciles the two descriptions, because they belong, in Pascal's terms, to orders separated by an infinite distance. John's prologue states the relation from the side of the higher order: "In him was life; and the life was the light of men. And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not" (John 1:4–5). The Greek verb, *katelaben*, means both to understand and to overcome. The darkness on the island neither understands the Light nor, in the end, overcomes it—but only because someone climbs down to keep it.

The Light also closes a circle opened in the Introduction. Pascal's *Mémorial* begins with a single word, *FEU*, set apart on the parchment, and the Introduction observed that fire belongs, in the series, to Jacob's center. The fire of the *Mémorial* is the fire of the God of Jacob, encountered not by ascent but by visitation, at night, between about half past ten in the evening and about half past twelve. The island's Light is likewise not reached but found—in the dark, in a cave, by those who descend.

8.5

The trial of Jacob

The island's theodicy has a frame, and it is the frame of the Book of Job. In Job's prologue the Satan—*ha-satan*, "the adversary," a prosecutor in the heavenly council rather than the devil of later tradition—challenges God's confidence in his servant: "Doth Job fear God for nought?" (1:9). God permits him to strip Job of wealth, children, and health to test whether his integrity will hold. The island rests on the same wager. In "Ab Aeterno" Jacob explains to Richard Alpert that his brother believes everyone is corruptible, because it is in their nature to sin, and that he brings people to the island to prove him wrong; at the opening of "The Incident" the brothers rehearse the wager over the approaching *Black Rock*. The island is the land of Uz, the castaways are Job, and the Man in Black is the Satan whose thesis about human nature the suffering of the tested is meant to refute.

Job's story also supplies the shape of the trial. His friends defend God with a theology of retribution—the righteous prosper and the wicked suffer, so Job must have sinned—and the island's early seasons are full of such readings: the island punishes, the island demands sacrifices, the Monster judges the guilty. Job rejects them and demands that God answer him. God speaks from the whirlwind, answering none of Job's questions but displaying the wild magnificence of creation—the foundations of the earth, the treasuries of the snow, Behemoth and Leviathan (38–41)—and then, astonishingly, vindicates the protester against his defenders: "ye have not spoken of me the thing that is right, as my servant Job hath" (42:7). Kant, in "Über

das Mißlingen aller philosophischen Versuche in der Theodizee" (1791), treated theodicy as a lawsuit in which reason undertakes to plead God's cause, declared every philosophical defense a failure, and found in Job the only "authentic" theodicy: not a better argument but an honest heart, whose sincerity God preferred to the friends' flattery. Carl Gustav Jung's *Antwort auf Hiob* (1952) pressed further, arguing that in the encounter it is Job who proves morally superior, and that his protest compels the divine to grow in consciousness.

Lost follows Job and his modern readers closely. Its plaintiffs are not condemned for their complaints. Sawyer's anger and Kate's challenge in "What They Died For" are met not with rebuke but with explanation, and the explanation includes a confession: Jacob concedes that they are on the island because he made a mistake—the mistake that made his brother what he is, and since which his brother has sought to kill him—and he tells them that he chose them because they were flawed, like him. He then offers the candidates what Mother never offered him—a choice. The office is not imposed but offered, and the one who accepts it does so freely. Jacob's answer at the campfire, like God's from the whirlwind, does not justify the suffering; it moves the question from the justification of the past to the keeping of the future.

The sharpest protest against any such move is Ivan Karamazov's. In the chapter "Rebellion," Ivan tells Alyosha that he will not accept a future harmony purchased with the tears of a single tortured child, and that even should the mother of such a child embrace her child's torturer, she would have no right to forgive him the child's suffering—only her own. "It's not God that I don't accept, Alyosha," he concludes, "only I most respectfully return Him the ticket." The island has its tormented children—Walt, abducted for his gifts; Alex, shot within sight of her father; Aaron, taken from his mother—and the finale's harmony in the church is precisely the kind of harmony Ivan refused. The series' answer honors Ivan's rule in two ways. First, the forgiveness of the sideways is given by victims, not decreed by the god who permitted their suffering: Locke forgives Ben, and no one forgives on another's behalf. Second, the harmony is incomplete. Jacob is absent from the church. Ben remains outside it. Ana Lucia, Desmond reports, is not ready; Michael is among the whispers that cannot move on; Eloise keeps her son in the waiting world. The church does not cancel the debt of suffering by decree; it gathers those who are ready and leaves the door open for those who are not.

Emmanuel Levinas, in "La souffrance inutile" (1982), argued that the justification of the neighbor's suffering is the source of all immorality, and that the only ethical response to another's useless suffering is to suffer for it—to take it upon oneself. Jacob's theodicy of vocation justifies the castaways' suffering by its fruits; the series' ethics of substitution answers it otherwise. Sayid carries the bomb; Jack takes the office and the wound; Hurley takes care of people. The series does not ask its viewers to accept Jacob's justification. It asks them to watch what the justified do with it.

8.6

From theodicy to custody

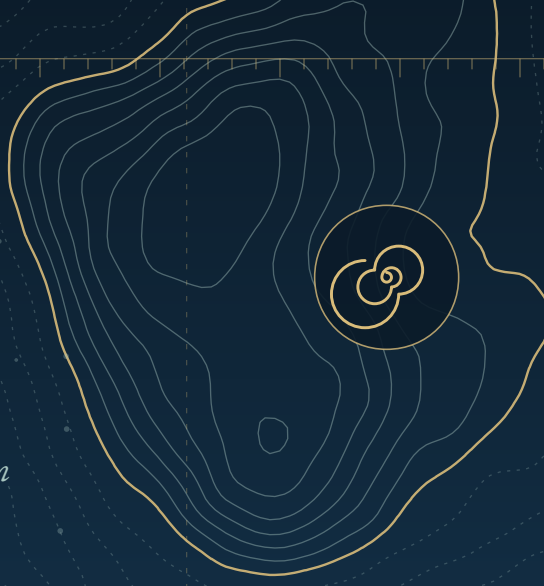
Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) staged the eighteenth century's great theodicy and its great objection as two tutors. Pangloss teaches that all is for the best in the best of all possible worlds; Martin, the impoverished scholar Candide takes on in Surinam, declares himself a Manichaean and holds that evil prevails everywhere (ch. 20). After shipwreck, earthquake, war, and the Inquisition have refuted the one and exhausted the other, Candide closes the book with a sentence that rejects both: "Cela est bien dit, mais il faut cultiver notre jardin"—that is well said, but we must cultivate our garden. The island's twins are Pangloss and Martin. Jacob holds that everything before the end is progress; his brother holds that it always ends the same, in corruption. The series' resolution rejects both, and it rejects them in Voltaire's way. Its last regime is a garden kept: Hurley and Ben tending the island as Adam was placed in Eden "to dress it and to keep it" (Genesis 2:15).

The series' theology may now be summarized. Evil, in *Lost*, is real but not original: it has a history, and its history is familial. The Good is real but not omnipotent: it is a light within the earth, shared by all, coveted by all, and capable of going out. The god who kept it is neither justified nor condemned but tried, and he confesses. And the question of theodicy—how a good keeper could permit such suffering—is answered not by an argument but by a transfer of office. The Good passes from a keeper who manipulated to keepers who care, and its keeping becomes the work of those who suffered. Whether such a resolution would satisfy Ivan Karamazov is a question the series leaves open, as it should. What it does not leave open is where the suffering ends. It ends only once, and Chapter 9 turns to the end.

Chapter 9

Anamnesis

The Flash-Sideways as Eschatology of Recollection



The flash-sideways is the series' most audacious invention and its most misunderstood. Introduced in the sixth season's premiere as an apparent alternate timeline, it is disclosed in the finale as an intermediate state: a duration after death and before whatever lies beyond the church doors, in which the dead, not knowing that they are dead, live provisional versions of their lives until they are brought to remember. When they remember, they recognize one another, forgive, and—in the series' phrase—move on. This chapter argues that the sideways is an eschatology of *anamnesis*, of recollection, and that it is the most original element of the series' thought. The Western imagination has conceived the end of history chiefly in two modes: as apocalypse, a rupture in which the old world is destroyed and a new one revealed, and as escape, a liberation of the soul from history altogether. *Lost* conceives the end as a gathering in memory. The sideways is structured by the oldest eschatologies of recollection—Plato's Myth of Er, Dante's paired rivers, the Tibetan *Bardo Thödol*, Swedenborg's world of spirits, the Islamic *barzakh*, Proust's time regained, and the Gnostic "Hymn of the Pearl"—and it transforms them all in one decisive respect. What its dead recover is not a Form, a universal Self, or a lost divine origin, but persons and a shared history. Its anamnesis is personal, and its gnosis is custodial: an awakening that leads not out of the world but back into its memory.

9.1

The intermediate state

"LA X" (6.01–6.02) opens aboard Oceanic 815 in flight. The turbulence passes, the plane lands safely in Los Angeles, and the camera descends through the Pacific to show the island lying on the seafloor. The passengers' lives have diverged from those the series had shown, in ways both small and large. Jack has a teenage son. Locke is engaged to Helen, the woman who in life had left him. Sawyer is a police detective; Ben teaches European history; Hurley is the luckiest man in the world; Nadia is married to Sayid's brother; Desmond works for Charles Widmore and has never met Penny; Claire is pregnant and alone; Charlie is a heroin addict who tries to swallow his stash in the airplane's lavatory. For most of the season viewers read the sideways as the branch of history created by the bomb (Chapter 5). The finale discloses what it is. In a back room of a church, Christian Shephard tells his son that he died; that everyone dies sometime, some before him and some long after; and that this is a place they all made together so that they could find one another.

Theology has a name for such a place: an intermediate state, a *status intermedius* between death and final destiny. The Latin Church defined its version as purgatory at the Councils of Florence (1439) and Trent (1563). Islam speaks of the *barzakh*, the barrier that stands behind the dead until the day they are raised (Qur'an 23:100), which Ibn ʿArabī developed into an intermediate world of imagination in which spirits take bodies and bodies are spiritualized, and which Henry Corbin called the *mundus imaginalis*—carefully distinguishing the "imaginal," a real world apprehended by the active imagination, from the "imaginary," which is unreal ("Mundus Imaginalis," 1964). Christian's description of the sideways as a place the castaways made together is Corbin's distinction in a sentence. The sideways is imaginal, not imaginary: it is made of the dead's need to find one another, and yet the persons in it are real.

Two further intermediate states describe the sideways with particular precision. Emanuel Swedenborg's *De Caelo et ejus Mirabilibus* (*Heaven and Hell*, 1758) describes a "world of spirits" midway between heaven and hell, into which every person enters after death. The newly dead often do not know that they have died: they find themselves in a world like the one they left, with houses, cities, and companions, and with their memories intact. In that world there are no times, only states, and nearness is a matter of likeness, so that those who love alike are drawn together. Over a period the dead are brought to their "ruling love," and they pass at last to the society that answers it. No one is cast into hell, Swedenborg insists; each goes where his love draws him. And true marriages, he taught, endure. The sideways is a Swedenborgian world of spirits: its dead live as if alive; they are drawn together across a city by affinities they do not understand; they are brought, one by one, to the loves that defined them; and they are not judged but go, or stay, as they choose.

The *Bardo Thödol*, the Tibetan text revealed by the fourteenth-century treasure-finder Karma Lingpa and published in English by W. Y. Evans-Wentz as *The Tibetan Book of the*

Dead (1927), is read aloud to the dying and the dead to guide them through the intermediate states, or *bardos*, that follow death. It addresses the deceased by name, again and again, because the dead often do not realize that they have died; it urges them to recognize the clear light that dawns at death as their own true nature; and it warns that failure to recognize leads to wandering. Recognition is liberation. Chapter 2 noted that Richard Alpert's namesake co-authored a modern adaptation of the text. The sideways has its reader of the *Bardo*—Desmond, who goes from person to person bringing about the encounters in which they recognize what they are.

The principal traditions on which the sideways draws can be compared directly.

Table 7 *The intermediate state across traditions*

Tradition	Text	Condition of the dead	What awakens them	What follows	What *Lost* keeps or changes
Plato	*Republic* X (Myth of Er); *Phaedo*	Souls drink from the river of forgetting before rebirth	Recollection triggered by likenesses	A new life chosen by lot	Keeps the forgetting and the trigger; refuses rebirth
Dante	*Purgatorio* 28–33	Souls purged on an island-mountain	Lethe removes the memory of sin; Eunoë restores the memory of good	Ascent to the stars	Keeps the beloved's recognition; restores all memory, then forgives
Tibetan Buddhism	*Bardo Thödol*	The dead do not know they are dead	A guide's voice; recognition of the clear light	Liberation or rebirth	Keeps the guide and the light; persons are not dissolved into it
Swedenborg	*Heaven and Hell* (1758)	The dead live as before, unaware	Gradual disclosure of each one's ruling love	Free passage to the society one loves	Keeps self-sorting, enduring marriages, "states" in place of times
Islam; Ibn ʿArabī	Qur'an 23:100; the *barzakh*	An imaginal interworld between death and resurrection	—	Resurrection	Keeps the imaginal: "a place you all made"
C. S. Lewis	*The Great Divorce* (1945); *The Last Battle* (1956)	Ghosts invited onward by those they knew	Persuasion by the Solid People	"Further up and further in"	Keeps the invitation and the free refusal; inverts Lewis's Platonism
Proust	*Le Temps retrouvé* (1927)	A life lost to habit and time	Involuntary memory from a sensation	The vocation of the work	Keeps the sensory trigger and the final gathering

The table's last column is the argument of the chapter in summary. *Lost* takes from each tradition its structure of forgetting and recollection, and from none of them its resolution. Its dead are not reborn, not dissolved, and not lifted into a more real world. They remember their one shared life, and then they go on together.

9.2

Lethe and Eunoë

The oldest eschatology of recollection in Western philosophy concludes the *Republic*. Er, a Pamphylian soldier killed in battle, revives on his funeral pyre on the twelfth day and reports

what he saw (614b–621d). The souls of the dead are judged; after a thousand years they gather before the spindle of Necessity, where the Fates sing of past, present, and future; and they choose their next lives from lots spread before them. The choices are revealing. The soul of Orpheus, out of hatred for the women who killed him, chooses the life of a swan. The soul of Odysseus, cured of ambition by the memory of its former toils, searches a long time and chooses, gladly, the life of a private man who minds his own business (620c–d). Then the souls march through scorching heat to the Plain of Lethe, camp beside the river of Unmindfulness, and drink a measure of its water—some, unchecked by wisdom, more than the measure—and forget everything before they are born again. Er alone is not permitted to drink, and so he remembers.

The myth is the eschatological form of the doctrine Plato elsewhere calls *anamnesis*: the soul, having known all things before birth, forgets them in being born, and learning is recollection (*Meno* 81c–d; *Phaedo* 72e–77a). In the *Phaedo* Socrates gives an example of how recollection is triggered, and it is an erotic one. Lovers, he observes, when they see a lyre or a cloak or anything else their beloved used to use, recognize the lyre and at the same time form in their minds the image of the boy to whom it belonged; and this is recollection (73d). The sideways' mechanism is Plato's: a sensible thing—a touch, a song, a scar—awakens the memory of a beloved. Its object is not. Plato's recollection leads away from the particular toward the Forms, of which the beloved and his lyre are only reminders; the series' recollection leads from the particular to the particular, from the touch of a hand to the person whose hand it is. It is the beloved that Plato leaves behind and *Lost* goes back to find.

The series also recalls the choices of the *Republic*'s last pages. Odysseus's choice of a quiet private life, made by a soul that remembers its labors, is the choice Rose and Bernard make in 1977, when, alone among the castaways, they decline the war and live in a hut in the jungle with their dog. And the life Orpheus chooses gives its name, by a coincidence the series never remarks, to the station in which men spent years repeating a single act: the Swan.

Dante doubled Plato's river. At the summit of his island-mountain, in the Earthly Paradise, Matelda explains to him that a single fountain feeds two streams: "Da questa parte con virtù discende / che toglie altrui memoria del peccato; / da l'altra d'ogne ben fatto la rende. / Quinci Letè; così da l'altro lato / Eünoè si chiama" (*Purgatorio* 28.127–131)—on this side it descends with the power to take away the memory of sin; on the other, it restores the memory of every good deed; here it is called Lethe, and on the other side Eunoë. The order of the rite is exact. Dante first meets Beatrice, confesses his failings under her reproach, and is drawn through Lethe (31.91–102); only at the end of the cantica does he drink from Eunoë, from which he returns, in its last line, "puro e disposto a salire a le stelle"—pure and ready to rise to the stars (33.145).

The sideways follows Dante's sequence and corrects it. Its first phase is Lethean: the dead live without memory of the island, and the island itself lies drowned beneath the sea. Its second is a recognition of the beloved, as Dante's was. Its third is a Eunoë, a restoration of

memory. But the memory the sideways restores is not only the memory of every good deed. It is the memory of everything: Ben remembers that he murdered Locke, and Locke remembers that he was murdered. What the sideways removes is not the memory of sin but its debt, and it removes the debt by forgiveness. Ricoeur, at the close of *La mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli*, described the horizon of such forgiveness as a "happy memory," in which the past is remembered whole but no longer weighs as a debt. That is the sideways' Eunoë. Its dead do not drink forgetfulness of their sins; they remember them, are forgiven them, and go on—as the church doors open onto light—pure and ready to rise.

9.3

The signs of the ancient flame

When Beatrice appears to Dante at the summit, veiled and crowned with olive, he does not yet see her face; but before his eyes recognize her, his spirit feels "d'antico amor… la gran potenza"—the great power of the old love—and he turns to tell Virgil, in words borrowed from Dido's confession of her love for Aeneas ("agnosco veteris vestigia flammae," *Aeneid* IV. 23), "conosco i segni de l'antica fiamma" (*Purgatorio* 30.39, 48): I know the signs of the ancient flame. Virgil, at that moment, is gone. The awakenings of the sideways are recognitions of this kind, in which an old love is known by its signs before the mind knows what it knows.

They follow a pattern the series repeats with liturgical regularity. Two people who were bound on the island meet in the sideways as strangers; one touches the other, or a sensation recalls a shared moment; a montage of island memories floods both faces; and they know each other. Charlie, choking on the plane, glimpses at the edge of death a woman he loved ("LA X"; "Happily Ever After," 6.11). Hurley is kissed by Libby, who has already begun to remember ("Everybody Loves Hugo," 6.12). Sun and Jin, watching an ultrasound performed by Juliet—the fertility specialist who on the island had first shown them their child—see their daughter on the monitor and remember ("The End"). Sawyer and Juliet meet at a stalled vending machine; Sayid steps between Shannon and an assailant; Kate, delivering Claire's son backstage at a concert, remembers together with Claire and with Charlie, who has come to the concert to play; Locke wakes from Jack's surgery and moves his feet. Each recognition repeats, in a changed key, a defining moment of the island—Kierkegaard's repetition recollected forward (Chapter 5)—and each issues in *philia*, as Aristotle required (Chapter 6).

The literary master of such recognitions is Proust. *Du côté de chez Swann* (1913) introduced the madeleine whose taste, dipped in tea, restores the whole of the narrator's childhood at Combray; *Le Temps retrouvé* (1927) multiplies the experience into the novel's climax. Arriving at a matinée given by the Princesse de Guermantes, the narrator stumbles on uneven paving stones and is flooded with the memory of Venice; the clink of a spoon against a plate restores a halt on a railway journey; a starched napkin restores the sea at Balbec. These involuntary memories reveal to him that lost time can be regained, and with the revelation comes his vocation. He then enters the salon to find his acquaintances so transformed by age that he must

recognize each of them anew beneath the masks time has given them—the scene critics call the *bal de têtes*. Proust's climax is a gathering of the living in which each must be recognized; the sideways' climax is a gathering of the dead in which each must be recognized. Both are preceded by a sequence of sensory awakenings, and both culminate in a revelation of what a life was for. Proust's narrator concludes that "la vraie vie, la vie enfin découverte et éclaircie, la seule vie par conséquent pleinement vécue, c'est la littérature"—the true life, life at last discovered and illuminated, the only life therefore fully lived, is literature. Christian Shephard tells his son that the most important part of his life was the time he spent with these people. The true life, for the series, is the island remembered—and Chapter 5 observed that the duration in which it is remembered, the *aevum* of the sideways, is the duration of fiction.

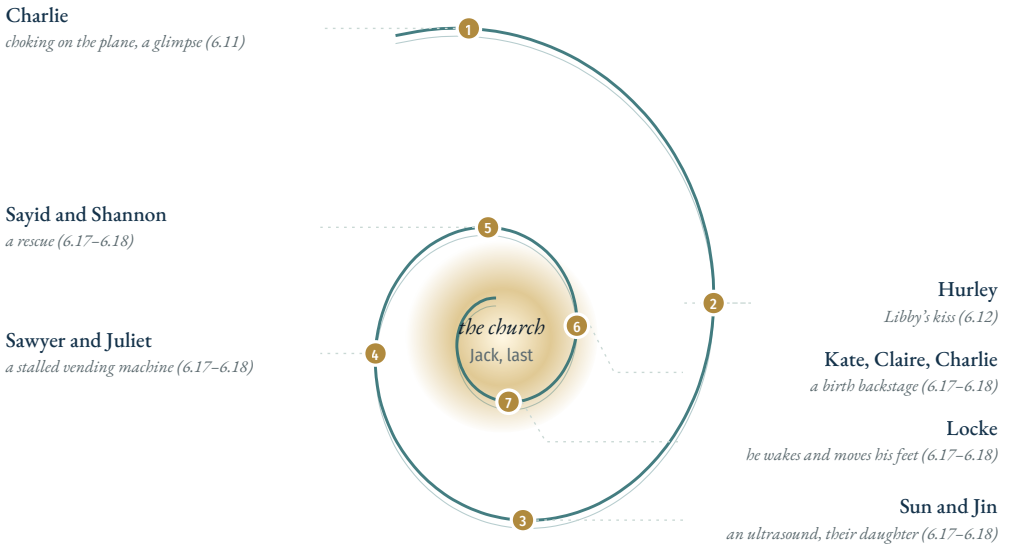


Figure 8 *The signs of the ancient flame (9.3). The awakenings of the sideways, in the order the series gives them, each set off by a touch or a sensation, spiral inward toward the church.*

Proust also supplied the musical form of involuntary memory: the *petite phrase* of Vinteuil's sonata, which recurs throughout the novel to recall Swann's love and returns, transfigured in Vinteuil's septet, at the threshold of the narrator's vocation. *Lost* works the same way through

Michael Giacchino's score, whose themes return at the moments of recognition, so that the audience remembers by ear what the characters remember by touch; and it is at a concert that the sideways gathers its castaways for their climactic awakenings.

Walter Benjamin, in "Zum Bilde Prousts" (1929), called Proust's involuntary memory a *Penelopewerk des Eingedenkens*, a Penelope-work of remembrance, and then corrected himself: it is rather the counterpart of Penelope's work than its likeness, since in Proust the day unravels what the night has woven. The image completes a circle the series has been drawing since its fourth season. The awakener of the sideways is Desmond, whose constant is Penelope; and Penelope's weaving, which suspended time in fidelity to an absent husband (Chapter 3), becomes in Benjamin's figure the work of memory itself. Remembrance, on this account, is a weaving that fidelity performs against the forgetting of time. In the sideways the weaving is done not by one woman for one man but by everyone, for one another.

9.4

The messenger

The sideways has a guide, and his offices are three: he is the messenger of the "Hymn of the Pearl," the reader of the *Bardo*, and the psychopomp of Greek religion. In the last book of the *Odyssey*, Hermes calls forth the souls of the slain suitors with his golden wand, and they follow him gibbering like bats, past the streams of Ocean and the White Rock, past the gates of the Sun and the land of dreams, to the meadow of asphodel where the dead dwell (24.1–14). Desmond Hume is the series' Hermes. He is the first of the dead to wake fully. In "Happily Ever After" (6.11), Widmore, on the island, exposes the living Desmond to a lethal electromagnetic discharge, and his consciousness passes into the sideways and back, so that he alone, while still alive, has seen the world beyond time. In the sideways, meanwhile, Charlie wrenches the wheel of Desmond's car and drives it off a pier into the marina; underwater, Charlie presses his palm against the window, and Desmond sees, superimposed upon it, the palm of the drowning man in the Looking Glass with its three-word warning. A glimpse of Penny during a hospital scan, and then her handshake at a stadium, complete his awakening. Thereafter he goes from person to person arranging the encounters through which they remember: he runs Locke down with his car to deliver him to Jack's operating table; he provokes Ben; he gathers the others at a concert. He is the letter of the "Hymn of the Pearl," which flew from the king's house as an eagle, alighted beside the sleeping prince, and became speech, so that the prince awoke and remembered (*Acts of Thomas* 110–111). And he is the voice of the *Bardo*, calling each of the dead by name.

The series had marked Desmond for this office long before. In the Swan he keeps a single unread book, saved to be the last he reads before he dies: Dickens's *Our Mutual Friend* (1864–1865) (Grade A). Its hero, John Harmon, is presumed drowned when a body pulled from the Thames is taken for his, and he lives for most of the novel under assumed names among the people of his former life, unrecognized, until the moment he can make himself

known. When at last, in despair, Desmond opens the book, he finds that Penny has hidden inside it a letter promising to wait for him, placed where she knew he would turn in his darkest hour ("Live Together, Die Alone," 2.23–2.24). The book Desmond saved for his death is the story of a man thought dead who lives an unrecognized life among those who knew him, and of the recognition that ends it—the plot of the world he would one day guide.

Desmond's guidance also stages, within the series, the misreading of the sideways that its audience would commit. Having seen the sideways while alive, Desmond concludes in "The End" that it is an escape: if he descends into the Light and moves the stone, he believes, he and the others will pass into the world where Charlie is alive and he is with Penny, and nothing on the island will matter. Jack, now a believer, tells him that he is wrong. There are no shortcuts and no do-overs, Jack says; what happened, happened, and all of this matters. Desmond descends, lifts the stone, and is carried nowhere; the light goes out, and Jack must restore it. The scene is the series' correction of its own most tempting interpretation. The sideways is not an alternative to the island, a better life into which one may escape from the real one. It is the place in which the real life is remembered. Jack's sentence joins the two laws the dissertation has traced: Faraday's law of time, that what happened, happened, and the gospel the finale adds to it, that because it happened it matters. The eschatology of recollection rests on the irrevocability of history.

The messenger, it should be noted, is the man whom the island set apart by exposure to its Light. He turned the failsafe key at the center of the Swan's discharge and survived it; he alone could be lowered into the Heart and live. And the guide of the dead is the man whose consciousness had already been scattered among times and saved by a constant. He knows how to call the others back because he was called back himself.

9.5 The church

The sideways ends in a church, and its iconography is precise. The stained glass gathers the emblems of several religious traditions—the cross, the Star of David, the crescent, and the yin–yang among them—around a single light, and in a back room lies the coffin that Jack has waited all season to receive. Jack touches it, remembers, and opens it, and it is empty, as his father's coffin was empty in "White Rabbit" (1.05). In the first season the empty coffin was an enigma, a sign that seemed to announce resurrection and turned out, as Chapter 2 argued, to mark the place where the adversary would borrow the dead man's form. In the sideways it is fulfilled. Christian Shephard stands behind his son—the true Christian, the icon rather than the idol—and tells him where he is.

The theology of Christian's speech can be reconstructed from its sentences. Everyone dies sometime; some of those gathered died before Jack, and some long after him. Everything that happened to him was real, and the people in the church are real. The most important part of his life was the time he spent with them. Nobody does it alone; he needed them, and they

needed him. The place is one they made together so that they could find one another—in order to remember, and to let go. Where they are going, they will find out together; there is no "now" here (Chapter 5). The two verbs at the center of the speech—remember and let go—name the structure Freud called the work of mourning. In "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917), Freud described mourning as a labor in which each of the memories and expectations that bound the survivor to the lost object is brought up and invested with feeling, one by one, and then released, until the ego is free. The sideways is a work of mourning performed not by the living for the dead but by the dead for their own lives. Each memory is summoned in its awakening and invested with its full feeling; then, in the church, it is released. The dead must mourn their lives before they can leave them.

Thornton Wilder's *Our Town* (1938) offers the sharpest modern contrast. Its dead sit on the hill above Grover's Corners, gradually weaning themselves from the earth and forgetting the living; when the newly dead Emily is permitted to relive a single ordinary day, she finds it unbearable that the living do not notice their lives while they live them, and she returns to the dead. Wilder's dead are released by forgetting. The dead of *Lost* are released only by remembering, and what they remember is not a day they failed to notice but a life they shared.

The sideways' made-ness explains its stranger features. Jack's teenage son, David, who appears throughout the sideways and with whom Jack repairs the failed relation he had with his own father, is not in the church. The place the dead made together contained what each needed in order to let go; it was imaginal, in Corbin's sense, and some of its figures belonged to the work of mourning rather than to the gathering that work served. Not everyone, moreover, is ready. Desmond reports that Ana Lucia is not; Eloise keeps her son in the waiting world; and Michael, as his ghost told Hurley on the island, is among the whispers who cannot move on. The church's freedom is Swedenborgian: no one is turned away, and no one is compelled to enter.

The most eloquent refusal is Ben's. Outside the church, on a bench, Ben apologizes to Locke and is forgiven; Hurley tells him that he was a great number two; and Ben says that he will stay outside for a while, because he has some things he still needs to work out—perhaps, as many viewers inferred, in the company of Alex and her mother, the daughter he sacrificed in life and the woman whose family he destroyed. Dante met a figure like him in the fourth canto of the *Purgatorio*: Belacqua, a Florentine maker of musical instruments notorious for his indolence, who sits with his arms about his knees in the shade of a great rock below the gate of purgatory, condemned—because he repented only at the last—to wait there as long as he had lived. Asked why he does not climb, Belacqua answers with a weary question: "O frate, l'andar in sù che porta?" (4.127)—brother, what's the use of going up? Ben's bench is Belacqua's rock. The late penitent is not condemned; he is waiting, and the door is open.

The church doors open at last onto a white light that fills the frame, and the series cuts to the bamboo grove, where Jack lies dying. Vincent lies down beside him; an aircraft carrying his friends crosses the sky; and the eye that opened in the pilot closes. C. S. Lewis's *The Last*

Battle (1956) ends in a similar key, with the revelation that the children have died in a railway accident and are now in Aslan's country, where, Aslan tells them, school is over and the holidays have begun. But Lewis's eschatology is Platonic: the old Narnia, the children learn, was a mere copy of the real one, and the dead pass from the Shadowlands into a world more real than the one they left—"further up and further in." *Lost* inverts the hierarchy. Its world beyond death is less real than the island, not more: it is a place the dead made in order to remember the real, and its reality is borrowed from the history it recalls. The island was the true life; the sideways is its memory; and what lies beyond the doors is not shown. The series' eschatology is not further up and further in, but further back and further together—a return to what happened, in order to go on.

9.6

Custodial gnosis: the Hymn of the Pearl fulfilled

Chapter 2 proposed that the series' eschatology preserves the most beautiful structure of Gnosticism while discarding its acosmism, and it named the result *custodial gnosis*. The "Hymn of the Pearl" in the *Acts of Thomas* (108–113) can now be read against the sideways in full. A prince is sent from his father's kingdom in the East down into Egypt to recover a pearl that lies in the sea, guarded by a serpent. In Egypt he puts on the garments of the Egyptians, eats their food, forgets that he is a king's son, and falls into a deep sleep. His parents send a letter, which flies as an eagle, alights beside him, and becomes speech; he wakes, remembers who he is, charms the serpent to sleep by naming his father's name, seizes the pearl, and sets out for home. On the way he is met by the robe of glory he had left behind, and when he sees it, it seems to him a mirror of himself: he sees himself whole in it and receives himself whole in it, for, the hymn says, they were two in distinction and yet one in a single likeness. He puts it on and returns to his father's house.

Every element has its correlate. Egypt is Los Angeles, the city of forgetting, where the dead wear the garments of lives they do not know to be provisional. The sleep is the sideways' Lethe. The letter that becomes speech is Desmond. The pearl guarded by a serpent in the sea is the island, lying at the bottom of the Pacific with the darkness at its heart. The robe that is a mirror is the beloved other, in whom each character, recognizing the other, recognizes himself: Sawyer in Juliet, Desmond in Penny, Charlie in Claire, Jin in Sun—two in distinction and yet one in likeness. And the father's house is the church, where a father waits.

The transformation lies in what the prince recovers. In the Gnostic reading of the hymn, the pearl is the soul itself, fallen into matter, and its recovery is an escape from the world into the realm of light. In the series, the pearl is the island—the world itself, the history lived there, the persons met there—and its recovery is not an escape from that history but its remembrance. The Man in Black's gnosis was acosmic: his knowledge that the island was a prison issued in the desire to leave it, at the price, Mother warned, of the Light everywhere. The sideways' gnosis is custodial: its knowledge that the island was real issues in the keeping of its

memory. This is also how the series holds together the two senses of "oceanic" introduced in Chapter 3. Freud diagnosed the oceanic feeling as a regressive longing for undifferentiated union. The communion in the church is oceanic, but it is not undifferentiated: its members keep their names, their histories, and their particular loves, and they are united precisely as two in distinction and one in likeness. The oceanic island of second origins and the oceanic feeling of communion meet in a gathering of persons who are not dissolved into one another.

9.7

Nothing is lost

Augustine, in the tenth book of the *Confessions*, wanders the vast hall of his memory, "in aula ingenti memoriae meae" (X.8.14), marveling that "magna ista vis est memoriae" (X.8.15)—great is this power of memory—and at last finds God there: "ecce quantum spatiatus sum in memoria mea quaerens te, domine, et non te inveni extra eam" (X.24.35)—see how far I have ranged in my memory seeking you, Lord, and I have not found you outside it. The sideways is an *aula memoriae*, and what its dead find there is, first, one another; whatever they find beyond its doors, the series leaves unshown. Walter Benjamin's principle, recalled in Chapter 5, states the eschatology the sideways enacts: nothing that has ever happened is to be given up as lost to history, though only a redeemed humanity receives the fullness of its past, which becomes citable in all its moments. The montages of the finale's awakenings are such citations—each a recitation of a life's moments, received whole by the one who lived it.

The series' title now discloses its final sense. A perditology, as the Introduction defined it, is a thought of what it means to be lost and of the conditions under which the lost may be kept, remembered, and found. Its last chapter is a recognition scene, and the English stage's most famous model for such a scene supplied this dissertation's third epigraph. At the end of *The Winter's Tale*, the oracle's condition—that the king shall live without an heir "if that which is lost be not found"—has been met: the lost daughter, Perdita, has been found. Paulina then leads the king to a statue of the queen he wronged and believed dead, and before the statue moves she lays down a condition of her own: "It is requir'd / You do awake your faith" (V.iii.94–95). The statue descends and embraces him. The finale of *Lost* is a winter's tale. It requires of its characters, and of its viewers, that they awake their faith; and when they do, the lost are found, the dead embrace the living, and those who were wronged forgive. The series called itself *Lost*. Its last word is that nothing is.

The three conceptual innovations of Part II—constancy, custody, and anamnesis—are now complete, and they answer the three questions that Pascal's islander asked on waking. Who am I? A promise, kept by another. Who placed me here, and to what end? A keeper, flawed and confessing, who brought me to keep what he could not keep alone. What will become of me in dying? I will remember, and be remembered, and go on with those I loved. Part III turns from the series' thought to its form and its reception: to the poetics of the hatch, the shipwreck of its audience, and the limits of its island.

Part III

Receptions and Limits

10 *The Poetics of the Hatch*

11 *Shipwreck with Spectators*

12 *The Limits of the Island*

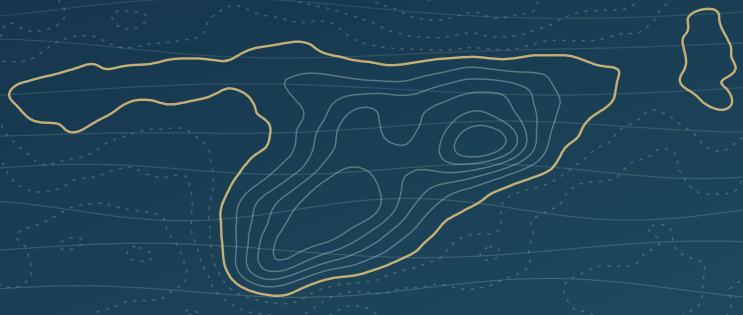
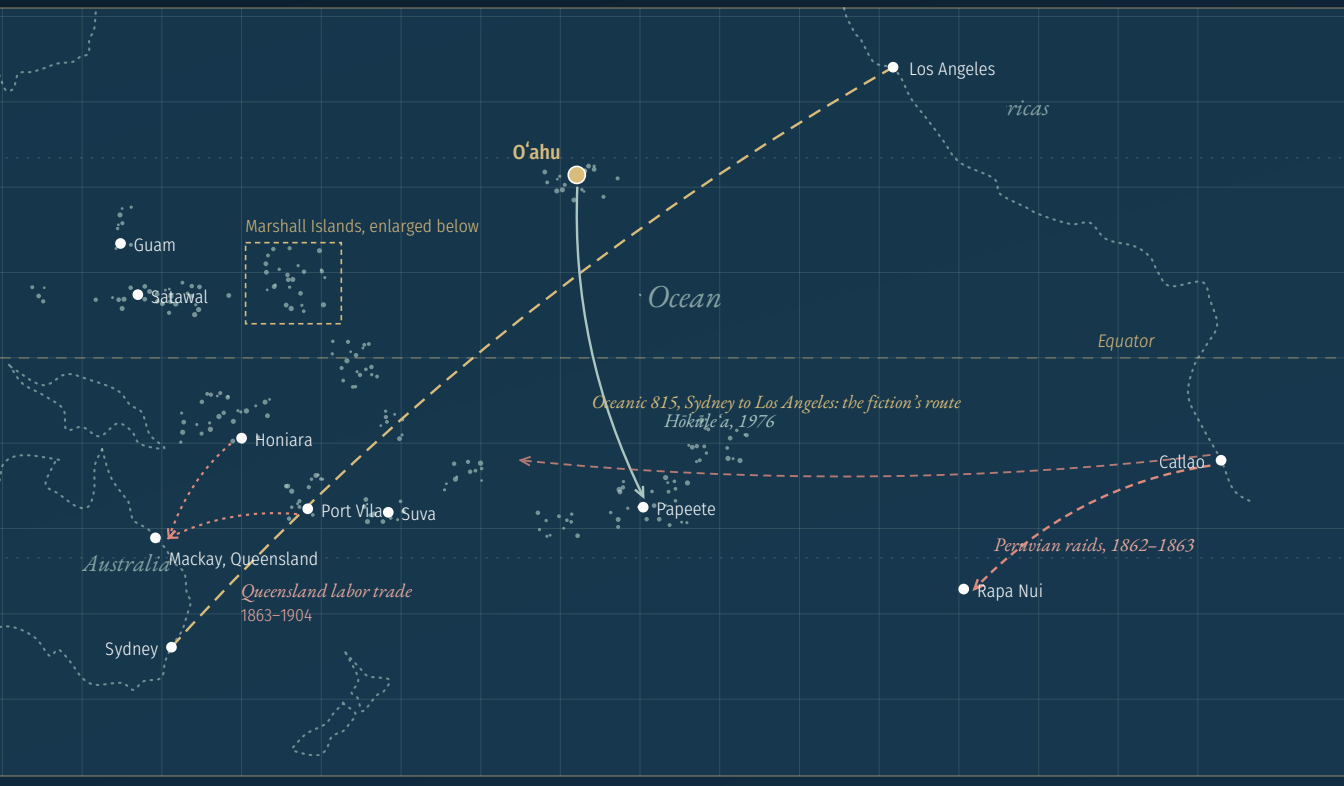
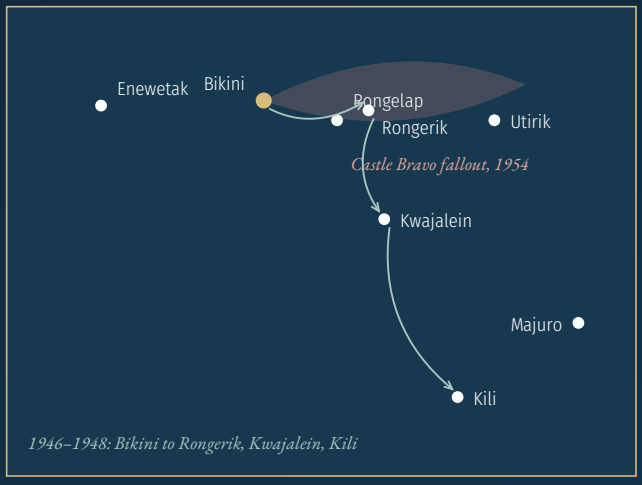


Plate III

A sea of islands

The Pacific of Chapter 12, drawn schematically; the series' island appears on no chart





O‘ahu
where the series was filmed, standing in for every place (12.1)

Hōkūle‘a
the voyaging canoe navigated without instruments to Tahiti, 1976

Rapa Nui
some 1,400 people taken by Peruvian raiders; 111 left by 1877 (12.2)

Queensland
about 62,000 indenture contracts, 1863–1904 (12.2)

Bikini
167 people removed in 1946 for the good of mankind (12.3)

Chapter 10

The Poetics of the Hatch

Seriality, Enigma, Achrony

The form of *Lost* is not a container for its thought but an enactment of it. Its seriality is the form of discernment, which can be exercised only over a course; its anachronies are the grammar of a theory of time; its recognitions are the narrative shape of its anthropology; and its economy of enigma—its notorious art of withholding—is the form of a theology of hiddenness. This chapter analyzes that poetics with the instruments of narratology—Roland Barthes's codes, Gérard Genette's account of narrative order, Erich Auerbach's two styles, Mikhail Bakhtin's polyphony and chronotope, Northrop Frye's theory of romance, Frank Kermode's hermeneutics of secrecy, and the work of television scholars on complex seriality—and it proposes that the series' formal trajectory can be summarized in a single image. *Lost* begins with the opening of a hatch and ends with the closing of one. The poetics of curiosity, which pries open a sealed door in the jungle and descends from station to station in search of answers, gives way to a poetics of custody, in which the last aperture—the socket of the stone at the Heart of the Island—is closed again by a man who has learned that some things are to be kept rather than opened. The movement from the hatch to the cork is the movement from the order of minds to the order of charity, performed in the series' form.

10.1

The hermeneutic code

In *S/Z* (1970), his reading of Balzac's novella *Sarrasine*, Roland Barthes distinguished five codes by which a narrative signifies, and he called one of them hermeneutic: the code that proposes an enigma, formulates it, delays its answer, and finally discloses it. Barthes listed the

code's units with a taxonomist's relish: the thematization of an enigma, its proposal and formulation, the promise of an answer, the snare that misleads, the equivocation that mixes truth and falsehood, the jamming that declares an answer impossible, the suspended answer, the partial answer, and at last the disclosure. Between question and answer lies what he called the dilatory space of the narrative, and the art of the hermeneutic narrative is the management of that space. *Lost* is arguably the most extended experiment in the hermeneutic code ever mounted on network television, and every one of Barthes's units can be illustrated from it. Its enigmas are thematized in the first hour (what is the thing in the jungle?); formulated as explicit questions by the characters (who are the Others?); promised answers by those who claim knowledge (Rousseau, Ben, the Man in Black, who offers to answer every question); snared by false solutions (the button as psychological experiment); equivocated by partial truths (the Others are "the good guys"); jammed by refusals and by the habitual promise that an explanation will come later; suspended across hiatuses; partially answered in installments (the Monster is a security system, a judge, a dead man's brother); and disclosed, sometimes, in the final season.

Peter Brooks, in *Reading for the Plot* (1984), gave the dilatory space a psychoanalytic depth. Reading Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* as a model of narrative, Brooks argued that plot is driven by a desire for the end that must nevertheless be delayed: as Freud's organism seeks to die only in its own way, choosing the long detour of life over a premature return to the inanimate, so a plot resists the short circuit of an early ending in order to reach the right one. The series' middle seasons are such a detour, and their length was a matter of constant complaint; but the detour has a destination. The series ends where it began, in a bamboo grove, with the death of the man whose eye opened there, and it is the right death—chosen, given, and reached by the long way. Brooks's model explains why the series could not have ended sooner without ending wrongly: its end required the whole of its middle.

The hermeneutic code also generated the series' characteristic pleasure and its characteristic risk. Barthes observed that the code works by making truth desirable—by constituting the answer as the object of the reader's appetite. A narrative that multiplies enigmas multiplies appetites, and appetites, unlike questions, are not satisfied by information. The series' viewers came to want not answers but the pleasure of awaiting them, and the disclosure of an answer could disappoint precisely because it ended the waiting. Chapter 11 examines the consequences for the finale. Here it is enough to note that the series was aware of the danger and named it. Its antagonist, in his final incarnation, is the character who promises to answer every question—and his promise is a temptation.

10.2

The mystery box and the hidden God

The series' co-creator gave the hermeneutic code a public emblem. In a talk delivered at the TED conference in March 2007, J. J. Abrams displayed a box he had bought as a child at

Tannen's magic shop in New York—"Tannen's Magic Mystery Box"—and explained that he had never opened it, because the unopened box represented infinite possibility: mystery, he argued, is a catalyst for imagination, and the box's value lies in its remaining closed (Grade A). The talk became the manifesto of a poetics, and critics have used "mystery box" ever since as a name for narratives that generate interest by withholding. The emblem is exact, and it is double-edged. The box was bought in a shop. Its value is the value of a commodity whose use is deferred indefinitely, and its mystery is a mystery for sale: the purchaser pays for the promise of something unseen. In Marx's terms, the mystery box is a fetish, an object whose power derives from the concealment of what it is.

The series' theology offers a different account of withholding, and its source is Pascal. The *Pensées* devote an entire bundle to the proposition that God has willed to hide himself ("Que Dieu s'est voulu cacher," L242/B585), and Pascal's explanation of the divine hiddenness is not commercial but moral. God, he argues, has given signs sufficient to be recognized by those who seek him and obscure enough to be missed by those who do not: "Il y a assez de lumière pour ceux qui ne désirent que de voir, et assez d'obscurité pour ceux qui ont une disposition contraire" (L149/B430)—there is light enough for those who desire only to see, and darkness enough for those of a contrary disposition. The purpose of the hiddenness is to engage the will rather than merely to inform the mind: "Dieu veut plus disposer la volonté que l'esprit" (L234/B581). The hidden God hides in order to be sought, and the seeking is itself the relation.

The two accounts of withholding coexist in *Lost*, and the series' achievement and its failure lie in the relation between them. Many of its enigmas are mystery boxes: devices that sustain the appetite of a weekly audience and whose answers, when they come, are information. Others are hidden in Pascal's sense: their obscurity is calibrated to the disposition of the seeker, and their resolution is not an explanation but a transformation of the one who seeks. The Light at the Heart of the Island is never explained. The series shows what it does and what it asks of those who keep it, and it leaves its nature in the dark—light enough for those who desire to see, darkness enough for those who desire only to know. The distinction anticipates the finale's divided reception. Viewers who had received the series' enigmas as mystery boxes demanded that they be opened; viewers who had received them as signs found that they had been answered in another order.

Frank Kermode's *The Genesis of Secrecy* (1979) is the indispensable theory of such a division. Kermode began from the most unsettling sentence in the Gospel of Mark, in which Jesus tells the disciples that to them is given the mystery of the kingdom, but that to those outside everything is in parables, "That seeing they may see, and not perceive; and hearing they may hear, and not understand" (Mark 4:11–12). Narratives, Kermode argued, are radiant and obscure at once; they generate insiders who believe they hold the key and outsiders excluded from it; and every interpreter is in the end an outsider, denied the final key that would make the text wholly transparent. Kermode's prime exhibit was the ending of Mark

itself, which in the oldest manuscripts breaks off at 16:8: the women find the tomb empty, are told that the crucified one has risen, and flee, "for they were afraid" (*ephobounto gar*). The ending so dissatisfied early readers that scribes supplied longer ones, with appearances, commissions, and an ascension. The first gospel was the first narrative to provoke its audience into writing its conclusion. *Lost*, whose first season turns on an empty coffin and whose last scene opens onto a light the camera does not enter, belongs to Mark's genre. Chapter 11 follows the scribes.

10.3

Anachrony and achrony

Gérard Genette's "Discours du récit" (*Figures III*, 1972) supplies the vocabulary of the series' temporal form. Genette distinguished the order of events in a story from the order of their presentation in a narrative and called every discordance between the two an *anachrony*: an *analepsis* evokes an event earlier than the point the narrative has reached, a *prolepsis* a later one. He reserved the term *achrony* for events that cannot be situated in any temporal relation to the story at all. *Lost* is a treatise on Genette's categories. Its first three seasons are built on analepsis, each episode interweaving the island's present with a single castaway's past; its fourth reverses the device into prolepsis; its fifth makes analepsis literal, sending the castaways bodily into the past; and its sixth introduces, in the flash-sideways, a narrative strand that proves achronic in the strictest sense. The sideways is neither before nor after the island; it stands in no temporal relation to it. Christian Shephard's sentence—there is no "now" here—is Genette's definition in the mouth of a character.

Genette's account of withholding is equally exact. He called *paralipsis* the omission of information that the narrative's focalization would normally include, an omission made to preserve an enigma. The series' flash-forwards are built on paralipses. In "Through the Looking Glass" (3.22–3.23) Jack visits a funeral parlor where no one has come to mourn; the narrative withholds the name of the dead man, which Jack knows, until the fourth-season finale opens the coffin to disclose Locke ("There's No Place Like Home," 4.12–4.14). In the same episode Kate tells Jack that she must get home because "he" will be wondering where she is; the identity of "he," which Kate knows, is withheld until "Eggtown" (4.04) discloses Claire's son, Aaron. The paralipsis is the technical form of Pascal's partial light: the narrative shows enough to be followed and conceals enough to be sought.

The series also practices what Genette called *metalepsis*, the transgression of the boundary between narrative levels, and it does so to reflect on its own reception. "Exposé" (3.14) inserts two previously unseen castaways, Nikki and Paulo, into scenes from earlier seasons, as though they had always been there; Nikki, an actress, had appeared on a fictional television series called *Exposé*; and the episode ends by burying the pair alive, paralyzed but not dead, in a macabre acknowledgment of the audience's hostility to characters it had not been asked to want. "Some Like It Hoth" (5.13), discussed in Chapter 5, shows a castaway in 1977 rewriting a

canonical sequel for its author. And the electronic whoosh that marks every passage between times—the series' sonic signature—announces each anachrony as an anachrony. The form never pretends to be transparent. It calls attention to its own construction, and in doing so it invites the forensic attention that Chapter 11 examines.

10.4

Homer's scar and Abraham's background

Chapter 6 proposed that *Lost* synthesizes the two styles Erich Auerbach distinguished in the first chapter of *Mimesis* (1946), and the synthesis has consequences for the whole of its poetics. The Homeric style, as Auerbach described it, externalizes everything: it renders phenomena in a uniformly illuminated foreground, connects them without gaps, and leaves nothing in shadow, so that even the long digression on Odysseus's scar at the moment of his recognition creates no suspense. The style of the Elohist in Genesis 22 externalizes only what the narrative's purpose requires; everything else—the thoughts and feelings of Abraham and Isaac, the motives of God, the time and space between the command and the mountain—remains in a background whose silence is charged with meaning. The Homeric style seeks to please; the biblical style, Auerbach argued, claims authority over the reader's reality and therefore demands interpretation.

The series' two great narrative strata correspond to Auerbach's two styles. Its character narratives are Homeric. The flashbacks halt the action at moments of crisis to tell the full story of each scar—how Locke came to be in the wheelchair, why Kate runs, what Sayid did in the war—and they illuminate each castaway's past in the uniform light of melodrama, leaving no motive obscure. Its mythology is Abrahamic. Jacob's motives, the Light's nature, the rules of the brothers' game, and the island's purpose remain in the background, and the series' silences about them are charged with meaning. The producers spoke constantly of balancing "character" and "mythology," and the audience divided along the same line. Auerbach's distinction explains why the division was inevitable. The Homeric stratum invites enjoyment and is satisfied when every scar has its story. The Abrahamic stratum invites interpretation and is never satisfied, because the authority it claims cannot be discharged by information. When the finale brought the Homeric stratum to its resolution—every character recognized, every story concluded—and left the Abrahamic stratum in its background, it satisfied the first audience and frustrated the second. It did so not by accident but in obedience to the logic of the two styles it had joined.

The synthesis has a further consequence. Auerbach observed that the biblical narratives, because they are fraught with background, call forth a tradition of interpretation that continually rewrites their meaning; the Homeric poems call forth none. A narrative that combines the two produces both a community of enjoyers and a community of exegetes. *Lost* produced both, and the second built an interpretive apparatus without precedent in television: a fan wiki of thousands of articles, a weekly literature of theory and commentary, and an official

podcast in which the producers answered their exegetes. The Abrahamic background did what Auerbach said it would. It called forth midrash.

10.5

Polyphony and the threshold

Mikhail Bakhtin's *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics* (1929; revised 1963) defined the polyphonic novel as a plurality of independent and unmerged voices and consciousnesses, each with full validity, none subordinated to the author's monologic truth. *Lost* is polyphonic in its architecture. Its ensemble—fourteen regular characters in the first season—has no single hero; Jack is first among equals, and the series' episodes are distributed among its castaways, each of whom becomes, for an hour, the center of consciousness through whom the island is seen. The worldviews these consciousnesses carry—the surgeon's science, the hunter's faith, the con man's suspicion, the lottery winner's sense of a curse, the torturer's guilt, the fugitive's flight—collide without authorial adjudication for five seasons, and the series' refusal to declare a winner in its debates is the formal correlate of what Bakhtin called the "great dialogue."

The finale has been accused of abandoning polyphony for a monologic resolution in which every voice is gathered into a single chorus. Bakhtin's own terms suggest otherwise. Polyphony requires voices that remain unmerged, and the church is a gathering of unmerged voices: its members keep their names, their histories, and their particular loves, and they are united, as the "Hymn of the Pearl" put it, as two in distinction and one in likeness (Chapter 9). The gathering is an assembly, not a fusion. Its closest analogue in Dostoevsky is not a resolved argument but the scene at the end of *The Brothers Karamazov* in which Alyosha and the boys gather by the stone where Ilyusha wished to be buried and promise to remember him and one another.

Bakhtin also supplied the series' emblematic chronotope. In the concluding remarks to "Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel," he described the chronotope of the *threshold*—stairways, corridors, doorways, the edges of rooms—as the chronotope of crisis and break in a life, highly charged with emotion and value, in which time seems to fall out of biographical duration and become instantaneous. The hatch is the series' threshold. Discovered at the end of "All the Best Cowboys Have Daddy Issues" (1.11), it is the object of half a season's desire; it is blown open at the end of the first season, when Jack and Locke peer down a dark shaft ("Exodus," 1.23–1.25); and the second season begins on its far side, in a room where a man has spent three years in a time measured by 108-minute intervals. The threshold recurs at every level of the series: the sonic fence, the door of Jacob's cabin, the circle of ash, the mouth of the Temple, the lip of the Heart. The series' final threshold is the church door, which opens onto a light into which the camera does not pass. The last threshold is crossed by the characters but not by the narrative. Its time is the instant; its duration is not shown.

10.6

Romance: the secular scripture

Northrop Frye's *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) classified fictions by the power of their heroes relative to ours—myth, romance, high mimetic, low mimetic, and ironic—and by four pre-generic narrative movements, or *mythoi*, which he associated with the seasons: comedy with spring, romance with summer, tragedy with autumn, irony and satire with winter. *Lost* traverses Frye's modes in the reverse of his historical sequence. It begins in the low mimetic, with ordinary people surviving an ordinary catastrophe; it rises into romance, in which its heroes acquire vocations, enter enchanted spaces, and confront supernatural adversaries; and it reaches myth in "Across the Sea," whose characters are gods in all but name. The modal ascent is the series' most underrecognized structure, and much of its audience's disorientation in the final season derives from it: a drama that began among people like us ended among beings like gods.

Its dominant *mythos* is romance, and Frye's account of romance describes its plot. The complete form of the romance, Frye wrote, is the successful quest, which has three stages—a perilous journey with preliminary adventures, a crucial struggle in which hero or foe or both must die, and the exaltation of the hero—corresponding to the Greek terms *agon*, *pathos*, and *anagnorisis*, with a phase of *sparagmos*, the tearing apart of the hero, between struggle and recognition. The series' last movement follows the pattern exactly: the journey to the Heart; the struggle on the cliffs, in which both hero and foe die; Jack's mortal wounding; and the recognition in the church. Frye's late book *The Secular Scripture* (1976) refined the account into a cosmology of descent and ascent. Romance, he argued, descends into a lower world through themes of broken consciousness, amnesia, doubles, twins, enchantment, and the labyrinth, and ascends again through the recovery of original identity, escape, and recognition. The sideways is Frye's ascent: amnesia overcome, identity recovered, recognition achieved.

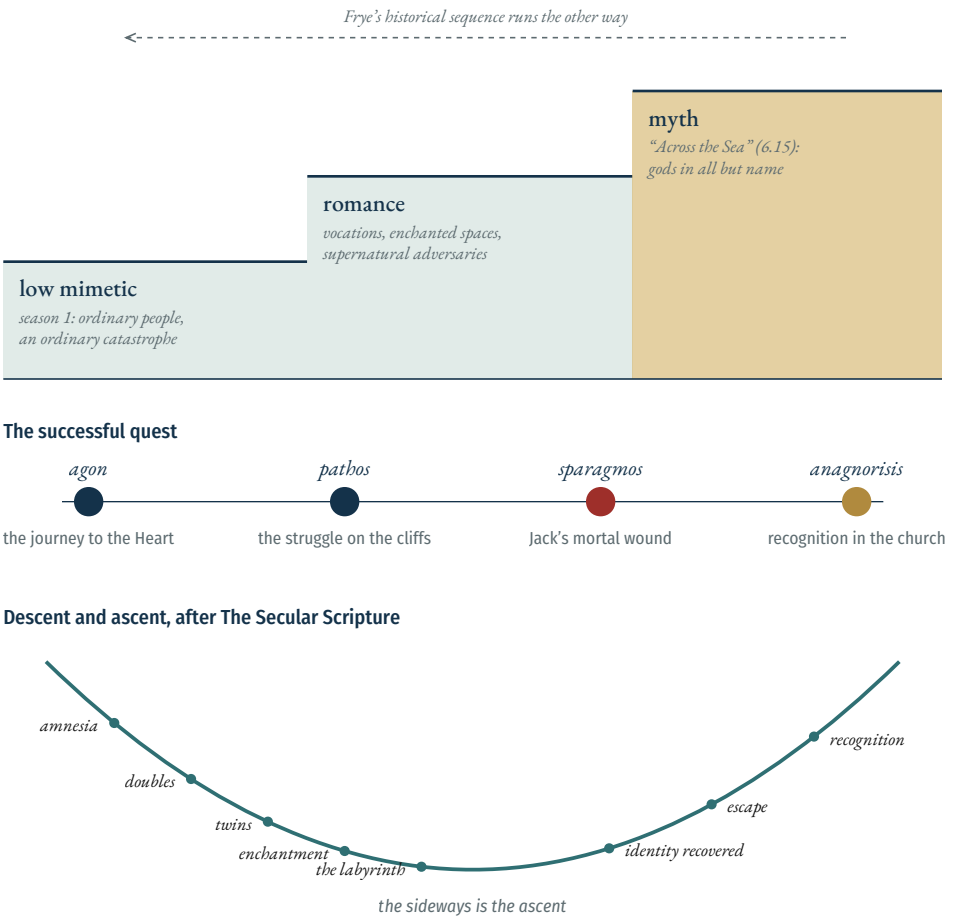


Figure 9 *Frye's modes and the romance quest (10.6). The series climbs Frye's modes in the reverse of his historical sequence, its last movement follows the stages of the successful quest, and the sideways enacts the ascent of The Secular Scripture.*

The island, finally, is what Frye, in "The Argument of Comedy" (1948), called the green world —the forest of Arden, the wood near Athens, Prospero's island—into which the characters of Shakespearean comedy and romance withdraw to be transformed before returning to the ordinary world. *Lost* revises the pattern in one decisive respect. Its characters do not finally return from the green world to the ordinary one; they return to the green world from the ordinary one, and they remember it as the place where their true life was lived. Chapter 9 called the finale a winter's tale. Frye would have called it a romance in which the green world becomes home.

10.7

Seriality as discernment

Chapter 4 argued that discernment in Ignatius's sense is diachronic: the true spirit and its counterfeit can be told apart only over a course, by comparing an inspiration's end with its beginning. Serial television is the narrative form in which a mass audience experiences a story as such a course—in weekly installments separated by intervals of days and, between seasons, of months. *Lost* exploited the form with unusual self-consciousness, and its seriality was not a delivery system but a discipline. Its viewers learned, as its characters did, to distrust a voice that addressed their desires too precisely; they learned to read the course of a character's commissions rather than any single scene; and they learned it slowly, because the form made them wait. The hiatus was the space of the audience's discernment. Between episodes, and above all between seasons, viewers reconsidered what they had seen, tested hypotheses against one another, and revised them when the next installment arrived. The disclosure of the Man in Black's impersonation of Locke—planted in the fifth-season finale and unfolded across the sixth—was an exercise in Ignatian attention conducted on a public scale.

Umberto Eco's theory of the "open work" (*Opera aperta*, 1962) anticipated the poetics of such participation: works in movement, whose completion is entrusted to the interpreter. Eco later distinguished, in "Innovation and Repetition" (1985), among the forms of serial narrative —the retake, the remake, the series, the saga, and the intertextual dialogue—and argued that the pleasure of seriality lies in the dialectic of the expected and the new. *Lost* is a saga in Eco's sense, the history of a group across generations, crossed with an intertextual dialogue of extraordinary density. Jason Mittell's "Narrative Complexity in Contemporary American Television" (2006) and *Complex TV* (2015) supplied the concepts with which television studies has described its audience: an "operational aesthetic," borrowed from Neil Harris's study of P. T. Barnum, in which viewers take pleasure in watching how the narrative machine works; "forensic fandom," which dissects episodes frame by frame; and "drillability," the capacity of a text to reward such dissection. Pierre Lévy's "collective intelligence" (*L'intelligence collective*, 1994), adapted by Henry Jenkins in *Convergence Culture* (2006), named the distributed reasoning of the communities that formed around the series online. Each of these concepts describes the order of minds at work on a narrative. The series' wager was that the order of minds could be trained, by the very form that engaged it, to recognize where its competence ended.

10.8

Constitutive and contingent incompleteness

The Introduction distinguished constitutive incompleteness, in which the withholding of an answer belongs to the work's meaning, from contingent incompleteness, in which it reflects

the accidents of production, and it promised that the theological reading defended here would not absolve the series of the latter. The promise must now be kept. *Lost* was made under industrial conditions that shaped its narrative visibly. For three seasons it had no fixed end, because its network wished to extend a commercial success indefinitely; the producers' negotiation, in May 2007, of an end date three seasons away transformed its pacing and its ambitions. The Writers Guild strike of 2007–2008 reduced the fourth season to fourteen episodes. The physical growth of the child actor who played Walt, on an island where only weeks were supposed to have passed, removed from the narrative a boy whom the first two seasons had marked as uniquely gifted and whom the Others had abducted for that reason; his story was left to a paracanonical epilogue. The departure of actors foreclosed planned arcs: Mr. Eko's death came sooner than his story warranted. Other threads were simply dropped. The series never explained why Libby had been a patient in Hurley's psychiatric hospital, who fired on the castaways' outrigger from another boat in "The Little Prince" (5.04), or why the island prevented women who conceived there from bearing their children.

These are contingent incompletenesses, and no theology of hiddenness redeems them. They are not Pascalian obscurity but narrative debt, and the series' critics were right to call it in. The constitutive incompletenesses are of another kind. The nature of the Light, the origin of the rules, the history of Mother before Claudia's arrival, and above all what lies beyond the church doors are withheld not because the writers ran out of time but because the series' theology requires that they be withheld. A Light explained would no longer be the Good of Chapter 8 but an energy source; a history of Mother's origins would only push the question back a generation; and a vision of what lies beyond the doors would convert the series' eschatology of recollection into a picture of heaven, which is precisely the conversion it refuses. The critical task is to keep the two kinds of incompleteness apart—to refuse both the apologist's temptation to read every loose thread as a mystery and the skeptic's temptation to read every mystery as a loose thread. The distinction is not always easy to draw, but it is the condition of judging the series fairly.

10.9

From the hatch to the cork

The series' formal history can now be told as a history of apertures. It begins with a sealed door in the jungle. Locke and Boone strike metal in the first season; for the rest of that season the castaways dig around it, argue over it, and finally blow it open with dynamite carried from the *Black Rock*; and the season ends with two men staring down a shaft into the dark. The second season descends. Beneath the hatch lies a station, beyond it another, and then others—the Pearl, the Arrow, the Flame, the Hydra, the Looking Glass, the Orchid—each a box within a box, each promising to explain the last. The third and fourth seasons descend further, into the Others' barracks, their submarine, and the frozen chamber beneath the Orchid where the wheel that moves the island turns. The fifth descends into time itself. The sixth des-

cends into the Temple, into the cliffside cave of the candidates' names, and at last into the Heart, the lowest place on the island, where a luminous stream flows around a carved stone set in an aperture at the bottom of the world.

This is the poetics of curiosity, and for five seasons it is the series' engine. Its emblem is the hatch, and its ethic is the one Dante's Ulysses preached to his crew: not to live as brutes but to follow virtue and knowledge (Chapter 3). The series' audience shared that ethic, and the series rewarded it with box after box. The sixth season reverses the direction of the series' desire. The last aperture on the island is not to be opened. When Desmond, believing that it will carry him to a better world, lifts the stone from its socket, the Light goes out, the water drains away, and the island begins to break apart. Jack, who in the first season stood at the mouth of the hatch as the man of science demanding to know what lay below, descends into the Heart and puts the stone back. The series that began by opening a door ends by closing one.

Hesiod told the story of the first such door. In the *Works and Days*, Pandora lifts the great lid from the jar the gods had filled, and the evils within scatter over the earth; only Hope remains inside, beneath the jar's lip, because Pandora replaces the lid before it can fly out (90–99). The hatch is Pandora's jar opened, and the island's six seasons are the scattering of its contents: the button, the Others, the bomb, the Purge, the freighter, the war of the brothers. Jack's last act is Pandora's second gesture. He replaces the lid, and what remains within is the Light. The movement from the hatch to the cork is the movement from the order of minds to the order of charity, performed not in an argument but in a plot. Curiosity opens; custody closes. And the one who closes is the man who first insisted on knowing, and who has learned on the island what Pascal's islander had to learn: that not everything that can be opened should be, and that some things are known only by being kept.

The audience, however, had been formed by five seasons of opening, and many of its members did not wish the last lid replaced. Chapter 11 turns to them.

Chapter 11

Shipwreck with Spectators

Gnosis, Charity, and the Finale's Disproportion of Orders

On Sunday, 23 May 2010, ABC broadcast "The End," a two-and-a-half-hour finale that divided its audience as few works of popular fiction have done. For some viewers it was a consummation: a work that had begun with a man waking alone in a jungle ended with that man dying in the same place, having saved what he had been called to save, while the people he loved gathered in a light. For others it was a betrayal: six years of enigmas had been abandoned for sentiment, and the questions the series had trained its audience to ask were left unanswered or answered in a currency they would not accept. The dispute has outlived the series by more than a decade, and its intensity is itself a datum to be explained. This chapter argues that the reception belongs to the work's meaning. The audience of *Lost* was its last castaway, and the finale tested whether that castaway could do what the series had asked of its characters: pass from the order of minds, in which it had been schooled for five seasons, to the order of charity, in which the series chose to end. Pascal predicted the result. The goods of the third order, he wrote, are invisible to *esprits curieux*—to curious minds.

11.1

Suave mari magno: the spectator's shore

The second book of Lucretius's *De rerum natura* opens with the most famous image of spectatorship in Latin literature: "Suave, mari magno turbantibus aequora ventis, / e terra magnum alterius spectare laborem; / non quia vexari quemquamst iucunda voluptas, / sed quibus ipse malis careas quia cernere suave est" (II.1–4)—it is sweet, when the winds are troubling the

waters on the great sea, to watch from the land another's great struggle; not because anyone's distress is a joy, but because it is sweet to see from what evils you yourself are free. Hans Blumenberg made the image the paradigm of a history of metaphor in *Schiffbruch mit Zuschauer* (1979), tracing how the spectator's secure position on the shore was progressively eroded until it became untenable. Its decisive dissolution, in Blumenberg's account, is Pascal's: *vous êtes embarqué*. There is no shore from which to watch; everyone is already at sea. The book ends with Otto Neurath's image of modern epistemology, in which we are like sailors who must rebuild their ship on the open sea, never able to bring it into dry dock and reconstruct it from the best materials.

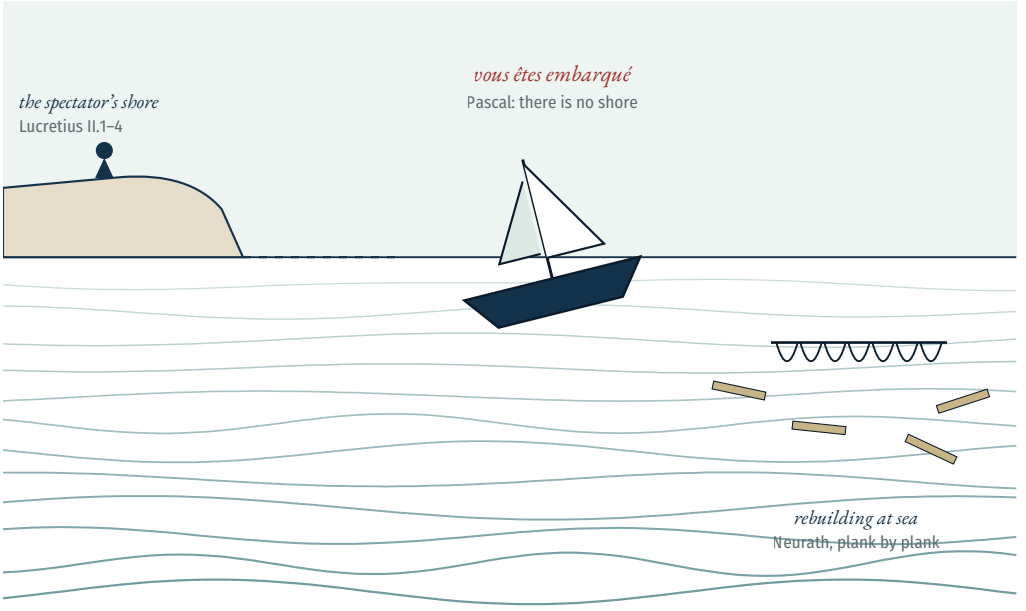


Figure 10 *The spectator's shore (II.1). Lucretius watches a shipwreck from land; Pascal abolishes the shore; Neurath's sailors rebuild their ship at sea, plank by plank.*

Television is Lucretius's shore industrialized. Its viewers watch, from the safety of their homes, other people's shipwrecks, and *Lost* began with the most literal of them: a fuselage burning on a beach, survivors screaming, a man drawn into a jet engine. But the series spent six years denying its viewers the shore. It made them work—decode, theorize, rewatch, argue—and rebuild their hypotheses at sea in exactly Neurath's sense, plank by plank, never permitted to take the whole construction into dry dock. Its alternate-reality games, hidden glyphs, numbers, and paratexts made viewing a form of participation, and its seriality, as Chapter 10 argued, made the participation a discipline. The audience was embarked. The question the finale posed was whether an embarked audience would accept the condition of the embarked

—that the voyage, not the view from shore, is where meaning is found—or whether, at the last, it would demand the spectator's satisfaction.

11.2

The scribes: an interpretive community

No television series before *Lost* had generated an interpretive apparatus of comparable scale, and its institutions reproduce, with uncanny fidelity, those of scriptural exegesis. The fan wiki *Lostpedia*, founded in September 2005, became a collaborative commentary of thousands of articles, cataloging every name, number, glyph, and allusion, cross-referencing every episode, and adjudicating rival theories; Chapter 2 compared its labor to Champollion's. Weekly columns and message boards functioned as schools of interpretation, each with its masters, its heresies, and its canonical readings. The producers' official podcast became a magisterium in which the authors answered—or declined to answer—the questions of their exegetes, and their annual panels at San Diego's Comic-Con became something like councils, at which thousands gathered to interrogate the makers of the text about its meaning.

Two literary precedents illuminate the institution. The first is Lucian's, cited in Chapter 3. On the Island of the Blessed, the narrator of the *True History* meets Homer and puts to him the questions the scholars had disputed for centuries—where he was born, whether he wrote the lines the critics had marked as spurious, why he began the *Iliad* with the wrath of Achilles—and receives answers that settle nothing: the poet was a Babylonian, he wrote all the disputed lines, and the opening simply came into his head. The scene satirizes the interpretive community's fantasy that the author, if only he could be questioned, would supply the key. The Comic-Con panel realized the fantasy and confirmed the satire: the authors could be questioned, and their answers, like Homer's, were rarely the key. In July 2006 the scene was briefly inverted. During the producers' panel an actress playing Rachel Blake, a character from the alternate-reality game *The Lost Experience*, rose from the audience to accuse them of complicity with the game's fictional Hanso Foundation: a creature of the fiction interrogated its authors in public, a metalepsis (Chapter 10) performed in a convention hall. The second precedent is Lem's *Solaris*, whose Solaristics—a century of rival hypotheses about an ocean that confirms none of them—anticipates the theoretical literature of the fandom with almost prophetic precision. Lem's library of hypotheses grew in inverse proportion to its progress, and Lem's point was not that the ocean was meaningless but that the mode of knowing brought to it was the wrong one.

Stanley Fish's concept of "interpretive communities" (*Is There a Text in This Class?*, 1980) explains why the series' audience produced not one reading but several incompatible ones: meanings are produced not by texts alone but by the shared strategies of the communities that read them. Wolfgang Iser's account of the gaps (*Leerstellen*) by which a text provokes its reader's constitutive activity (*Der Akt des Lesens*, 1976) explains why the series' withholdings generated so much interpretation: each gap was an invitation. And Hans Robert Jauss's

"horizon of expectations" (*Literaturgeschichte als Provokation der Literaturwissenschaft*, 1967) explains the finale's shock: a work that departs too far from its audience's horizon is experienced as a provocation, and only later, if at all, reshapes the horizon it disappointed.

The interpretive community of *Lost* also had a structure that the series' own theology would have recognized as Gnostic. Its knowledge was esoteric, available to initiates who had pursued the alternate-reality games, mastered the Numbers, and parsed the glyphs: *The Lost Experience* (2006) disclosed, to those who followed it across websites, telephone lines, and fictional corporate documents, a Valenzetti Equation that predicted humanity's extinction. Its theories proliferated as Irenaeus said the Valentinian systems did, each adding aeons to the last (*Adversus haereses* I). And its hope was salvation by knowledge: the conviction that the series' meaning would be possessed when its enigmas were solved. Hurley's rewriting of *The Empire Strikes Back* in 1977 (Chapter 5) was the comic emblem of this hope. The fan who knows the story writes it better than its author, and sends it to him before he has written it.

11.3

Des esprits curieux: the disproportion of orders

The finale's structure makes the disproportion of orders visible on screen. "The End" intercuts two narratives. On the island, the order of bodies and the order of minds reach their climax: a race to the Heart, the lifting and replacing of the stone, a fight on a cliff in a storm, a plane repaired and flown, the adversary killed. In the sideways, the order of charity reaches its consummation: a birth, a sequence of recognitions, a gathering in a church, forgiveness, a light. The island narrative answers the question of what happens; the sideways answers the question of what it was for. Many of the series' mythological questions—the nature of the Light, the origin of the rules, the purpose of the Numbers beyond the roll of candidates—had been answered, if at all, in the preceding episodes, and the finale devoted much of its last hour to the second narrative.

Pascal's fragment on the three orders explains, with startling exactness, why so many viewers could not see what the finale showed. Having declared that the distance between minds and charity is infinitely greater than the distance between bodies and minds, Pascal describes the splendor proper to each order. The great of the flesh—kings, the rich, captains—have a grandeur visible to bodily eyes. The great geniuses have their empire, their brilliance, their victory, which are seen "non des yeux, mais des esprits"—not by the eyes but by minds. And the saints have their empire, their brilliance, their victory, which need neither carnal nor intellectual greatness, for "ils sont vus de Dieu et des anges, et non des corps ni des esprits curieux"—they are seen by God and the angels, and not by bodies or by curious minds (L308/B793). The goods of each order are invisible from the order below. A mind looking for intellectual goods sees, in a gathering of persons recognizing one another in love, nothing at all; it sees sentiment, evasion, the absence of an answer.

The audience of *Lost* had been schooled for five seasons as curious minds. The series had asked them to decode, to theorize, to want answers; it had rewarded them with stations, equations, and paradoxes; it had made curiosity the engine of its form (Chapter 10). The finale then asked them to see with another faculty, and Pascal's sentence predicts the outcome. Viewers who could make the passage saw the series' meaning disclosed; viewers who could not saw nothing, because what was disclosed was invisible to the faculty they brought. The finale's reception is therefore not simply a verdict on its craft. It is a dramatization of the disproportion of orders, performed by an audience.

The argument is not that dissatisfied viewers were wrong to want answers, nor that their dissatisfaction can be dismissed as a failure of spiritual vision. Some of what they wanted was owed them, and Chapter 10 conceded the series' contingent debts. Nor did every satisfied viewer see with the eyes of charity; sentiment, too, is a pleasure of the body. The argument is that the series' central wager—that a narrative conducted in the order of minds could be completed only in the order of charity—made a divided reception inevitable, because the passage between orders cannot be compelled. It can only be offered.

11.4

The subtractive misreading

The most widespread misreading of the finale confirms the diagnosis. Large numbers of viewers concluded that the finale had revealed the castaways to have died in the original crash, and the island to have been a purgatory all along—the theory the series had dispatched in its first hour, in the anagram of Gary Troup, and that its producers had repeatedly disavowed. The misreading was encouraged by an accident of broadcast. Over the closing credits ABC ran images of the wreckage of Oceanic 815 on an empty beach—footage inserted by network executives, not by Lindelof and Cuse, to soften the passage to the late local news—and many viewers took them as a final disclosure that no one had survived. Two days later an ABC spokesperson told the *Los Angeles Times* that the images had been a visual aid to let viewers decompress before the news and were no part of the final story; Lindelof later said that it had never occurred to the producers that the footage might be taken for a revelation. The misreading nonetheless survived the correction, and its persistence is instructive.

Chapter 3 distinguished subtractive from additive revelations. The afterlife archipelago's characteristic twist is subtractive: it withdraws reality from what was seen, revealing life to have been death or dream. *Lost*'s revelation is additive: it adds eternity to a history it insists was real. Christian tells his son that everything that happened to him was real, and Jack tells Desmond that all of it matters. The misreading converted the additive revelation into a subtractive one, and the conversion followed the logic of the order of minds. A subtractive twist is information: it supplies a new fact that reorganizes the old ones, and a curious mind can receive it as an answer. An additive revelation is a gift: it supplies no new fact about what happened, only a new relation to it, and a curious mind looking for an answer finds none. A

century of fictions from Bierce to *The Sixth Sense* had trained the audience to expect the twist, and it saw the twist where the series had refused to put one. The misreading is the disproportion of orders in miniature: offered a gift, the mind received a fact, and the fact was false.

11.5

Prospero's epilogue and the withholding of indulgence

Chapter 3 read the epilogue of *The Tempest* as the model of every serial finale. Prospero, his charms o'erthrown and his strength reduced to his own, asks the audience to release him from the island—"But release me from my bands / With the help of your good hands"—and, at the last, "As you from crimes would pardon'd be, / Let your indulgence set me free." The magus who has governed an island for five acts ends as a petitioner whose release depends on the audience's mercy; his ending, he says, is despair unless he is relieved by prayer. The epilogue changes the relation between maker and audience from one of craft judged to one of mercy asked. It does not argue that the play deserves applause; it asks for applause as one sinner asks another for pardon.

The finale of *Lost* made a similar request, and much of its audience withheld indulgence. The relation the series had cultivated with its viewers was, in part, a relation of debt: six years of questions had been framed as promissory notes, and the producers' interviews, podcasts, and panels had confirmed that answers were coming. A finale received as the settlement of a debt is judged by an audit, and an audit finds every unpaid item. Prospero's petition presupposes a different relation, in which the audience, having been given a gift, is asked to receive it as one. The series' reception history is the history of these two relations colliding. Its makers would speak publicly of the reaction for years afterward, and the finale became, in popular discussion, a byword for the disappointing ending.

The disputed finale has its own lineage, and *Lost* belongs to it. *The Prisoner*'s "Fall Out" (1968) answered the series' central question—who is Number One?—with a surreal unmasking that infuriated its audience. *Twin Peaks* (1991) ended by trapping its hero in the Black Lodge and releasing his evil double into the world. *Seinfeld* (1998) put its characters on trial for their indifference to others, and its audience resented the verdict. *The Sopranos* (2007) cut to black in the middle of a scene. In each case the audience's anger was directed at a refusal: the finale declined to provide the satisfaction the series had trained its viewers to expect and offered another in its place. *Lost*'s refusal was the most theologically explicit of them, because what it offered in place of answers was not irony, ambiguity, or judgment, but grace.

11.6

The longer ending and the work on myth

Kermode's account of Mark's Gospel predicts what happened next. When the oldest gospel ended at 16:8, with women fleeing an empty tomb in fear, later scribes supplied longer endings, with appearances, commissions, and an ascension, to satisfy readers for whom the abrupt conclusion was intolerable. *Lost* acquired its longer ending within three months. "The New Man in Charge," an epilogue of some twelve minutes released with the series' final home-video sets in August 2010, answered several of the questions viewers had complained were left open: why DHARMA's pallets of food had continued to fall on the island long after the Initiative's destruction, what had become of Walt, and what Hurley's custody would look like. The producers became their own scribes. The longer ending stands outside the broadcast canon, and its existence confirms the force of the demand it answered.

The interpretive community did not end with the series either. Its wiki continued to grow; its podcasts and rewatch projects multiplied with the coming of streaming; and the finale's reputation has begun, in some quarters, to be reconsidered, as viewers who encounter the series whole, rather than across six years of waiting, receive the ending without the debt that shaped its first reception. Hans Blumenberg's *Arbeit am Mythos* (1979) describes this condition. Myth, Blumenberg argued, arises as the work by which human beings reduce what he called the "absolutism of reality"—the terror of a world that overwhelms because it is unnamed—by giving its powers names and stories; and myth cannot be brought to an end, because every attempt to end it becomes another version of it, to be worked on in turn. The book's last part, "Den Mythos zu Ende bringen," treats the attempt to bring a myth to its definitive end as itself one of the forms of the work on myth. *Lost* named the absolute reality of its island—the roaring thing in the jungle became a smoke, a brother, a man without a name—and its finale was an attempt to bring the myth to an end. Its reception is the work on myth continuing.

11.7

Shipwreck without spectators

The series answers Lucretius in its final image. A man lies on the ground in a bamboo grove, mortally wounded; a dog lies down beside him; and overhead an aircraft crosses the sky, carrying his friends away from the island he has saved. The composition inverts the opening of *De rerum natura* with precision. Lucretius's spectator stands safe on the shore and watches another's ship founder; his pleasure, the poet insists, lies not in the other's suffering but in the sight of evils from which he himself is free. In the last shot of *Lost* it is the castaway on the shore who watches, and what he watches is not a shipwreck but a rescue. The vessel overhead is safe; the man on the ground is dying; and he smiles. His pleasure is the reverse of the Lucre-

tian one. It lies not in his own safety from others' evils but in others' safety from the evil he has taken upon himself.

This is the last transformation the series performs, and it bears on the audience as much as on the hero. Blumenberg's history of the metaphor ended with the disappearance of the shore: since Pascal, no one watches from safety, and since Neurath, everyone rebuilds the ship at sea. *Lost* adds a final term. The spectator's position is not abolished; it is given to the one who stays, and its pleasure is converted from security into charity. The audience that had been embarked for six years was offered, in the last minute, the place of the one on the shore—not the place of Lucretius's spectator, savoring his own safety, but the place of the castaway watching others go home. Pascal would have called the offer a figure of charity, and the series' reception shows that it was not universally accepted. But the series had told its viewers from the beginning what it would ask of them. Its maxim was that those who will not live together will die alone. Its last image is a man who dies, not alone, watching the others live.

Chapter 12

The Limits of the Island

Terra Nullius, the Maternal Vessel, and the Ensemble



The preceding chapters have reconstructed the thought of *Lost* with deliberate sympathy, as a perditology whose concepts of constancy, custody, and anamnesis deserve a place in the history of ideas. Sympathy is not exemption. Walter Benjamin, in the seventh of the theses whose third and ninth have guided this study, warned that there is no document of civilization that is not at the same time a document of barbarism, and that the historian must brush history against the grain to ask whose labor and whose suffering the cultural treasures of the victors conceal. The series' final church, its window gathering the emblems of many traditions around a single light, is such a document. This chapter asks what its construction required. It argues that the series' universalist charity is articulated through specific erasures: of the Pacific and its peoples, in whose waters the "Oceanic" island is set; of mothers, whose bodies the series treats as vessels; and of the differences within its celebrated ensemble, which its eschatology gathers under an American and Christian roof. The critique is immanent. Each erasure contradicts a principle the series itself affirms, and each can be stated in the series' own terms: a custody that does not keep the excluded, an anamnesis that does not remember the forgotten, and a promise—that nothing is lost—that the series did not keep for those it did not count.

12.1

Terra nullius: a Pacific without Pacific Islanders

The doctrine of *terra nullius*, land belonging to no one, licensed the European occupation of territories whose inhabitants were deemed not to possess them; in Australia, from which

Oceanic Flight 815 departed, it was not repudiated in law until the High Court's decision in *Mabo v Queensland (No 2)* in 1992. The island of *Lost* is a *terra nullius* by design. It lies in the South Pacific, yet no Pacific Islander appears among its principal characters, and the archaeology of its sacred strata, which Chapter 2 excavated layer by layer, contains no Oceanic stratum at all. Beneath the survivors of 2004 lie the DHARMA Initiative's American and Orientalist utopia, a nineteenth-century slave ship carrying a captive from the Canaries, the Latin-speaking castaways of Mother's generation, and an Egyptianizing cult of uncertain origin. Hebrew, Egyptian, Iranian, Gnostic, and Indic traditions are all present. The traditions of the ocean in which the island sits—the genealogies, cosmologies, navigational sciences, and sacred geographies of Polynesia, Melanesia, and Micronesia—are not. The island's deepest past is Egyptian; its sacred center bears the name of a Hebrew patriarch; its last keeper is a Mexican American from Los Angeles. Of the peoples who have lived on the islands of the Pacific for millennia, it contains no trace.

The erasure was doubled by the conditions of production. The series was filmed on Oʻahu, and Hawaiʻi stood in not only for the island but for nearly every place its flashbacks visited—Sydney, Seoul, Iraq, Nigeria, London, Los Angeles. Haunani-Kay Trask's *From a Native Daughter* (1993) analyzed the conversion of Hawaiian land and culture into a commodity for tourism, a landscape emptied of its people's history and offered to outsiders as a pleasant anywhere. *Lost* completed the conversion. For six years Hawaiʻi became the world's most versatile backdrop, a place that could be every place because it was permitted to be none in particular.

The Tongan-Fijian scholar Epeli Hauʻofa's essay "Our Sea of Islands" (1993) supplies the decisive counter-image. Colonial discourse, Hauʻofa argued, belittled the Pacific by describing it as "islands in a far sea"—tiny, isolated, poor, dependent—whereas its own peoples had always known it as "a sea of islands," a vast connected world traversed by kin, trade, and navigation, in which the ocean joins rather than separates. *Lost*'s island is the apotheosis of the colonial description. It is the isolate absolute—unlocatable, unreachable, outside maps and at times outside time, and lost by definition. The series' very title presupposes the perspective Hauʻofa rejected, for an island in the Pacific is lost only to those for whom it was never home. The series' own epistemology sharpens the point. The island can be found, the fifth season teaches, only by the equations of Eloise Hawking and the instruments of the Lamp Post. In 1976, while the series' fictional DHARMA Initiative pursued its research, the Hawaiian voyaging canoe *Hōkūleʻa* sailed from Hawaiʻi to Tahiti under the guidance of the Micronesian navigator Mau Piailug, without instruments, by reading stars, swells, and birds—demonstrating that the Pacific's islands had never been lost to the knowledge of its peoples. The order of minds to which the series grants the power of finding is exclusively Western. The airline's name completes the irony. "Oceanic" is the brand of a fictional carrier, and its passengers are almost everyone except Oceanians.

12.2

Playing native: the Others and the Hostiles

Where the series does imagine the island's inhabitants, it imagines them through the oldest fantasies of settler colonialism, and then reveals the inhabitants to be settlers in costume. For two seasons the Others appear as primitives—barefoot, ragged, bearded, living in a jungle camp—until the second-season finale discloses that the beards are false and the camp a stage set, and the third season reveals that the Others live in a suburb with a book club. Philip Deloria's *Playing Indian* (1998) traced the long history in which white Americans constructed their own identity by performing indigeneity, from the costumed "Mohawks" of the Boston Tea Party to the scouting movement. The Others play native in exactly Deloria's sense. They are, almost without exception, recruits from the outside world, and their primitivism is a performance staged for newcomers. The series thus satirizes the colonial fantasy of the savage while ensuring that no actual native need ever appear: the only indigeneity on the island is a costume.

The colonial vocabulary is explicit. The DHARMA Initiative calls the Others "the Hostiles," the term the United States Army applied to the Native peoples who resisted removal; it lives behind a fence under a truce negotiated along a line neither side may cross; and its history ends in a massacre (Chapter 7). The series reverses the frontier's direction—here the "Hostiles" gas the settlers—but keeps its grammar. Its recurrent terror reverses another history. The Others take children: Walt, seized from a raft; Zach and Emma, taken from the tail section; Alex, taken from her mother as an infant and raised as one of them; Claire's unborn son, sought through the abduction of his mother. The series asks its viewers to fear a people who take children for their own good and raise them in another culture. In Australia, from which Oceanic 815 departed, federal and state governments, working with church missions and welfare agencies, removed Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children from their families for much of the twentieth century—between one in three and one in ten of all Indigenous children from about 1910 to 1970—for precisely that stated reason, as the national inquiry published as *Bringing Them Home* (1997) documented. The inquiry concluded that the policy of forcible removal could properly be called genocidal under international law. Its estimates were later contested, but the history was not obscure while the series was being made: on 13 February 2008, as its fourth season was airing, Prime Minister Kevin Rudd moved the Australian Parliament's formal apology to the Stolen Generations. Moved as the first item of business of the new Parliament and adopted unanimously, the apology answered the inquiry's recommendation that the nation's parliaments apologize; it made no provision for compensation. The island's nightmare is the region's history, inverted so that the colonized take the children of the colonizers.

The *Black Rock* compounds the inversion. The series' slave ship arrives in Pacific waters in 1867, in the decade of the Peruvian slave raids of 1862–1863, in which labor traders seized more

than 3,600 Pacific Islanders, about 1,400 of them from Rapa Nui—raids that by H. E. Maude's count cost more than 6,000 Islander lives in Peru, at sea, and through the smallpox and dysentery the repatriation ships carried home, and that left Rapa Nui, to which fewer than fifteen of its captives returned, with 111 people in 1877, and of the beginnings of "blackbirding," the recruitment by deception and force of Pacific Islanders for the plantations of Queensland and Fiji—some 62,000 indenture contracts in Queensland alone between 1863 and 1904, covering perhaps 50,000 people, of whom historians estimate that one in ten or more were taken by outright force and more than 14,500 died in the colony, before most survivors were deported under the Pacific Island Labourers Act of 1901, a founding statute of White Australia. The only captive of the *Black Rock* whose story the series tells is a Canary Islander. The Pacific's own enslaved, whose history the ship's very name and date evoke, are absent from its hold.

12.3

The bomb in the Pacific

Chapter 3 observed that the series places its hydrogen bomb, "Jughead," on the island in 1954, the year of the Castle Bravo test. The history the date evokes is specific. On 1 March 1954 the United States detonated at Bikini Atoll a thermonuclear device far more powerful than its designers had predicted; its fallout descended on the inhabited atolls of Rongelap and Utirik, whose people, not evacuated by the United States until two and three days later, suffered acute radiation sickness and, in later decades, elevated rates of thyroid disease and cancer, and on the crew of the Japanese fishing vessel *Daigo Fukuryū Maru*. The fishing boat's radio operator, Kuboyama Aikichi, died that September. That spring the Marshallese petitioned the United Nations Trusteeship Council to halt the tests. The United States had already removed the 167 people of Bikini from their atoll in 1946 to clear it for testing. The military governor, Commodore Ben Wyatt, arrived on Sunday, 10 February 1946, after church services, and asked them to leave for the good of mankind and to end all wars. According to official Navy records, as Jonathan Weisgall, then counsel to the people of Bikini, reports, he compared them to the children of Israel, whom the Lord had saved from their enemy and led into the Promised Land, and asked whether they would sacrifice their island for the welfare of all men. Their leader, Juda Kessibuki, answered that they would go believing that everything was in the hands of God, words that became the atoll's motto. On 7 March, before the people embarked, the Navy had the negotiation re-enacted for the newsreel cameras. The Bikinians' later suit against the United States described the consent they gave as having the outward form of a voluntary and informed agreement but almost none of its substance. Their first place of exile, Rongerik, could not feed them; a resettlement in the 1970s ended in a second evacuation in 1978, and they have not been able to return. Between 1946 and 1958 the United States conducted sixty-seven nuclear tests in the Marshall Islands, and the Nuclear Claims Tribunal later established under the Compact of Free Association awarded compensation for cancers and

other illnesses attributed to them. The series knows this rhetoric. Its Others, and DHARMA before them, justify abduction and experiment by appeal to the greater good; the history of the Pacific had already heard the phrase, addressed to a people asked to surrender their island. It had heard the series' scripture too. The Exodus that names the first season's finale (1.23–1.25) had already been preached in the Pacific to sanctify the removal of a people from their land, and the scene of that people's consent, re-enacted for the cameras, was theater of the kind the Others stage in their camp of costumes and false beards (Chapter 3). Teresia Teaiwa's essay "bikinis and other s/pacific n/oceans" (1994) traced how the name of the atoll, within days of the first postwar tests there in 1946, became the name of a swimsuit—an eroticized image of the Pacific body that, she argued, displaced and concealed the bodies of the Islanders whose home had been made a laboratory. The series' beaches, with their bathing castaways, belong to Teaiwa's genealogy; its bomb belongs to Castle Bravo's.

What *Lost* does with that history is instructive. In "Jughead" (5.03) the island's settler-natives—a young Charles Widmore, a young Eloise Hawking, and Richard Alpert—kill the American soldiers who brought the bomb and, on the advice of a time-traveling physicist, bury it. Resistance to nuclear colonialism in the Pacific is performed by figures who are not of the Pacific. In "The Incident" (5.16–5.17) the bomb is detonated by Americans for reasons that are entirely personal: Jack wants a life in which he never needed fixing, and Juliet wants never to have met the man she will lose (Chapter 5). The gravest catastrophe the twentieth century inflicted on the peoples of the Pacific becomes, on the series' island, an instrument in the private redemption of its American protagonists. Elizabeth DeLoughrey's analysis of the "island laboratory" in *Routes and Roots* (2007) names the pattern: the Pacific island imagined as an isolate available for experiment, its inhabitants subtracted from the experiment's design. The series names the history and does not examine it.

12.4

The maternal vessel

The series' second erasure concerns mothers, and it is written into the founding myth. The first named woman of the island's history, Claudia, exists in the narrative to give birth, and she is killed minutes after she has done so. The pattern recurs throughout the series with the regularity of the law Chapter 2 called the law of the substitute mother. Ben's mother dies giving birth to him. Women who conceive on the island die before they can bear their children, and the series' principal female scientist, Juliet Burke, is brought to the island to solve the problem. Claire is abducted for the sake of her unborn son; Danielle Rousseau's infant daughter is taken from her; Sun's pregnancy organizes much of her story and binds her to the island's lethal arithmetic; Kate's three years as Aaron's mother become the reason she is struck from the roll of candidates. When Kate asks Jacob why her name was crossed off the wall, he answers that it was because she became a mother, adding that it was only chalk and that the

office is hers if she wants it ("What They Died For," 6.16). The series' highest office was closed to a woman because she had raised a child, and reopened to her as an afterthought.

The gendered division of the series' anthropology is consistent. Its men are defined by their fathers: Jack by Christian, Locke by Anthony Cooper, Sawyer by the con man who destroyed his family, Ben by Roger Linus, Hurley by the father who abandoned him, Michael by his own failures as a father, Miles by the father he believed had rejected him—an obsession the series named in the title of its eleventh episode, "All the Best Cowboys Have Daddy Issues" (1.11). Its women are defined by their capacity to bear children, to lose them, and to raise the children of others. The one major exception confirms the pattern: Kate, too, is defined by a father—Wayne, the abusive man she learns is her biological father and kills by blowing up his house—but the series frames even this crime through a mother, since Kate kills him to free her mother from his abuse, and her mother turns her in ("What Kate Did," 2.09). Fathers are narrative problems to be worked through; mothers are vessels to be filled and emptied. Adrienne Rich's *Of Woman Born* (1976) distinguished motherhood as an experience from motherhood as an institution—a set of social arrangements governing women's bodies and lives—and the series represents almost exclusively the institution: reproduction, custody, disqualification from office. Maternal experience is rarely its subject; Claire's descent into feral madness after her separation from her son is the exception that shows how little interiority the series otherwise grants to maternity.

The theology of the Light raises the question to the level of the sacred. Luce Irigaray, in "L'hystéra de Platon" (*Speculum de l'autre femme*, 1974), read Plato's cave as a womb—a *hystera*—whose maternal origin the allegory represses in its ascent toward the paternal sun. Chapter 8 argued that *Lost* inverts Plato by placing its Good below, in a cave, bound up with water, at the island's Heart; the series restores, in Irigaray's terms, the maternal origin Plato's ascent forgot. But the restoration is followed at once by an appropriation. The island's first keeper is a woman, and the only female sovereign the series shows is what Erich Neumann called the Terrible Mother (*Die Grosse Mutter*, 1956): a liar and a murderer, who acquires her children by killing their mother and is killed by her son. After her death the keeping of the maternal Light passes from son to son—Jacob, Jack, Hurley—and the woman who might have succeeded them is struck from the roll for having become a mother. The series' Good is maternal; its custody is filial. Among its principal figures, Mother shares her namelessness with only one other: her younger son, the darkness. The two figures the series declines to name are the mother and the evil.

The series' women die, moreover, in ways that serve the stories of men. Nadia dies so that Sayid may grieve and be tempted; Shannon dies at Ana Lucia's hand so that Sayid may grieve again; Charlotte's death completes Faraday's tragedy and Alex's completes Ben's; Ana Lucia and Libby die so that Michael may carry their deaths as guilt. The comics writer Gail Simone named the pattern "women in refrigerators" (1999), after a story in which a hero comes home to find his girlfriend's body in one. Ilana, the woman Jacob entrusted with the candidates'

protection, is killed abruptly by unstable dynamite in a scene played almost as a joke ("Everybody Loves Hugo," 6.12). And the series' first female castaway, Danielle Rousseau—a scientist who survived alone for sixteen years—never receives an episode of her own. Her past is shown once, in "This Place Is Death" (5.05), through the eyes of a man who stumbles upon it in time; she is killed in the fourth season without having told her story. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak asked in 1988 whether the subaltern can speak. Rousseau's voice reaches the series as a looping signal to be decoded by others, and the novel the series did not write is the one Jean Rhys wrote for Charlotte Brontë's madwoman in *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966): the madwoman's own account of her island.

The critique must be stated with its counterweights. *Lost* gave its women more agency than much network television of its moment. Kate, Juliet, Ana Lucia, Sun, Penny, Rose, Ilana, and Eloise act, choose, fight, and command; Sun seizes control of her father's company; Penny's search saves Desmond; Rose's faith outlasts everyone's. But the series' theology of office remained male. Its keepers are sons, its last candidates are almost all men, and its one female sovereign is a figure of horror.

12.5

The ensemble and its center

Lost was celebrated, rightly, for the diversity of its ensemble. In 2004 it placed at the center of an American network drama a Korean couple whose scenes were played in Korean with English subtitles, an Iraqi former soldier, a Nigerian priest, a Mexican American lottery winner, a Black father and son, and an interracial married couple, and it gave each of them the same narrative instrument—the centric episode and its flashback—that it gave its white American leads. The achievement was real, and much of the series' international audience recognized itself in it. But an ensemble has a center, and the center of *Lost* is American. Its leaders and its central arguments belong to Jack, Locke, Kate, and Sawyer; its last keeper is a Californian; and the narrative that gathers the cast in its final hour is set in Los Angeles. The world beyond time in which the dead of Seoul and Sydney, of Iraq, Manchester, and Scotland await their passage is, by the series' design, the capital of the American entertainment industry. The flight was bound for Los Angeles, and the choice has a diegetic motive; it also has a meaning. The series' eschatology locates the waiting place of every nation in Hollywood—which is to say, as Chapter 5 observed of the *aevum*, in the duration of fiction itself.

The backstories of the ensemble's non-Western members, moreover, are organized with disquieting regularity around violence and crime. Sayid is a torturer; Jin is an enforcer for his father-in-law's criminal enterprise; Eko is a drug-running warlord; Sun's father is a gangster magnate. The series complicates each portrait with interiority and remorse, but the pattern belongs to the Orientalism Edward Said analyzed (1978), in which the non-Western subject is legible chiefly through his capacity for violence. Its post-2001 moment is legible in Sayid's story in particular: in "The Greater Good" (1.21), after his arrest at Heathrow on fabricated

terrorism charges, he is coerced by American and Australian intelligence into infiltrating a cell of Muslim militants in Sydney and persuading his former university roommate, Essam, to carry out a suicide bombing, so that the agencies can trace the cell's stolen explosives; the argument Sayid is made to use is the one the episode takes as its title, the greater good. When Sayid confesses that he has been working for the agencies, Essam turns the gun on himself, and Sayid, refusing to let the unclaimed body be cremated, stays to give his friend a Muslim burial, which is how he comes to be aboard Oceanic 815. The phrase the Others would make their creed enters the series as the instrument of an American and Australian security operation. The fates of the ensemble's families of color follow a pattern as well. The Kwons die together on the submarine, leaving their daughter an orphan off the island. Michael, the series' Black father, dies on the freighter and becomes one of the whispers who cannot move on, while his gifted son disappears from the narrative after the second season; Harold Perrineau, who played Michael, told *TV Guide* in May 2008, after Michael's death on the freighter, that he had wanted Michael and Walt to have a happy ending. He observed that the series had reunited Sayid with Nadia and Desmond with Penny but had found no interest in reuniting a Black boy with his father, so that Walt became one more fatherless child in a familiar stereotype; Carlton Cuse answered that the producers took pride in the cast's racial diversity. In 2023 Perrineau told Maureen Ryan, for *Burn It Down: Power, Complicity, and a Call for Change in Hollywood*, that he had raised the same concern in the second season, when an early script had Michael scarcely mention his abducted son, and Lindelof, interviewed for the book, conceded his own insensitivity and said that Perrineau had been right to raise it. The series' only answer came outside its broadcast canon, in the epilogue that promises Walt he may still help his dead father. Sayid, the series' Muslim, is awakened in the sideways not by Nadia, the Iraqi woman whose memory had defined him for six seasons, but by Shannon, a white American with whom he had a brief romance, and critics read the choice as an erasure of the history that had made him who he was.

The church has a center too. Its window gathers the emblems of several traditions, but its architecture is a church, its guide is named Christian Shephard, and its theology—remembrance, forgiveness, a light into which one passes—is Christian in grammar. Its first readers divided along exactly this line. The Spanish daily *La Razón* read the finale as Christian, indeed Catholic, the window's homage to every creed notwithstanding; a reviewer for *Christianity Today* found the window's assembly of symbols, from the cross to the yin-yang, the emptiest form of modern spirituality; and the historian of religion Benjamin E. Zeller described the series' religion as a characteristically American bricolage, a New Age afterlife assembled from traditions it did not represent with fidelity. The window permits all three readings. What it does not permit is one in which another tradition supplies the grammar. In the vocabulary of the theology of religions, the series' universalism is inclusivist rather than pluralist: closer to Karl Rahner's "anonymous Christians," saved by a grace whose name they do not know, than to John Hick's pluralism (*God Has Many Names*, 1980), in which the great traditions are

equally valid responses to a transcendent Real none can monopolize. Chapter 2 argued that the window relocates the Mosaic distinction from between religions to within persons. The critique adds that it does so under a Christian name. The Muslim, the Buddhist, and the unbeliever are welcome in the church, and the church is still a church.

12.6

Bodies and their cures

Disability studies offers the sharpest instruments for the series' treatment of bodies. David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder's *Narrative Prosthesis* (2000) argued that narrative depends on disability as a device: an impairment marks a character as deviant, sets the plot in motion, and is resolved by the story's end through cure, compensation, or death, so that disability serves the narrative as a crutch while the disabled body itself is denied a life of its own. John Locke's paraplegia is a narrative prosthesis in this exact sense. It is the series' first great secret, withheld until the fourth episode, "Walkabout" (1.04), whose closing revelation that Locke boarded the plane in a wheelchair reorganizes everything the viewer has seen. It is the ground of his faith, since the island healed him, and its return, when his legs fail as his faith falters ("Deus Ex Machina," 1.19), is the sign of crisis. His motto—"Don't tell me what I can't do"—belongs to what disability critics call the narrative of overcoming, in which the disabled hero's worth is measured by his refusal of his body's limits.

The sideways intensifies the pattern. Alison Kafer's *Feminist, Queer, Crip* (2013) named the "curative imaginary," the cultural assumption that a good future is a future without disability, in which the disabled body appears only as something to be repaired. The series' eschatology is curative. In the world beyond time Locke is paralyzed again, and his awakening is bound to Jack's surgery: he wakes from the operation, moves his feet, remembers, and walks into the church. The repair of his spine is not merely an event in the sideways but the condition of his recognition. The series' other healings follow the same logic. Rose's cancer is cured by the island, and Jack's vocation as the man who fixes—criticized in Chapter 4 as presumption—is vindicated in the sideways by the most consequential operation of his life. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's figure of the "normate" (*Extraordinary Bodies*, 1997), the unmarked body against which others are measured as deviant, describes the body that passes through the church doors.

The series' treatment of Hurley's body and mind is more ambivalent. For six seasons his size is a source of comedy, licensed above all by Sawyer's catalog of nicknames—"Lardo," "Jumbotron," "Pillsbury," and the rest. His psychiatric history is first a joke and then a wound: the imaginary companion of "Dave" (2.18) is played for uncanny comedy before it is revealed as a voice urging his death. Yet the series also refuses the conventional resolution. Chapter 4 argued that Hurley's madness is the site of the series' surest discernment, and Chapter 7 that he becomes its best sovereign. The fat man whom the narrative mocked and the psychiatric patient whom it doubted becomes the keeper of the island—uncured,

unchanged in body, and trusted. The reversal does not cancel the mockery, which it requires as its foil, but it suggests that the series' theology, at its best, was wiser than its comedy.

The eschatology's bodies are also paired. Many of the sideways' awakenings come through a romantic partner of the opposite sex, and the church is in large part a gathering of couples. The arrangement recalls Swedenborg's teaching that true marriages endure in heaven, and it reflects the network television of its moment; but it means that the series' universal communion contains no form of love that an American network in 2010 would not have recognized. A gathering of persons who are "two in distinction and one in likeness" is, in the series' execution, a gathering of heterosexual pairs.

12.7

The perditology against itself

These criticisms do not refute the reading this dissertation has advanced. They complete it, because each is a failure measured by the series' own principles. The series' political theology culminates in custody, a sovereignty that keeps without owning and attends to each, *omnes et singulatim* (Chapter 7); but an island kept without its own people, without a trace of the ocean's peoples, and by a filial line of keepers succeeding a murderous mother is a custody that has not counted all it keeps. The series' eschatology is an anamnesis whose principle Benjamin stated: the chronicler who recounts events without distinguishing great from small honors the truth that nothing that has happened should be given up as lost (Chapter 9). But the series' chronicle distinguishes. It remembers the Egyptian, the Hebrew, the Latin, and the Indic and forgets the Oceanic; it remembers the fathers and treats the mothers as vessels; it remembers the castaway's cure and forgets the disabled life. Its anthropology is a theory of constancy as fidelity to the other as other (Chapter 6); but the curative sideways receives Locke only once he walks, and the church receives Sayid only beside a partner who was not the love of his life. Each erasure is a breach of the series' own covenant.

The critique therefore has a double result. It confirms that the universalism of *Lost* is a historical artifact: an American network drama of the first decade of the twenty-first century, made on Hawaiian land, imagining the Pacific as a void to be filled with every tradition but the Pacific's own. And it confirms that the series' concepts are more capacious than its execution—that custody, constancy, and anamnesis, taken seriously, demand the very corrections the series failed to make. The perditology's principles indict its practice, and that is a measure of their worth. A thought that could not be turned against its author would not deserve the name of a philosophy.

The island, finally, was lost only from one shore. To the navigators of the Pacific, who read the swells and the stars and the flight of birds, there were never islands lost in a far sea, only a sea of islands; and to the people of Hawai'i, on whose land the series was made, the island of *Lost* was a familiar coast dressed as an unknown one. The series' last word is that nothing is lost. If it is to be true, it must include what the series itself did not find.

Conclusion

Nothing Is Lost

Lost ends where it began, with an eye. In the first shot of the pilot it opens on a bamboo grove, and its owner, not knowing where he is or how he came there, runs toward the sound of screaming and begins to save whom he can. In the last shot of the finale it closes in the same grove, and its owner knows where he is, how he came there, what he came to do, and what is becoming of him in dying. The distance between the two images is the distance this dissertation has measured. Pascal's islander, carried asleep to a desert and terrifying island, woke without knowing where he was, who had placed him there, what he had come to do, or what would become of him, and without any means of escape. The series takes up each of his questions and, over six seasons, answers each—not with the means of escape he lacked but with something Pascal would have recognized as better: a place to stay, a work to do, and others with whom to do it.

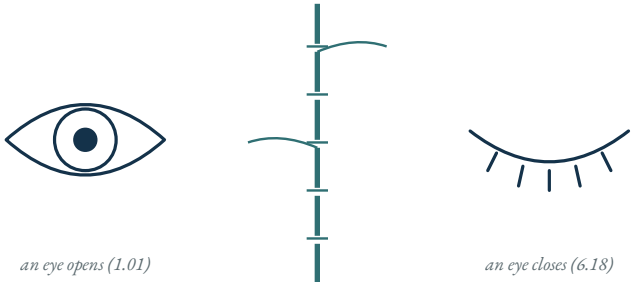


Figure 11 *An eye opens on a bamboo grove in the first shot of the pilot and closes in the same grove in the last shot of the finale.*

The argument has proceeded in three movements. Part I reconstructed the series' archives. It read the onomastic system as an ironic prosopopoeia of modernity—an ossuary of the Enlightenment in which the philosophers and savants are named, tested, and mostly buried in the presence of a patriarch named Jacob, as the *Mémorial* sets the God of Jacob against the God of the philosophers. It excavated the island's sacred strata and found them arranged as an inversion of Hegel's ladder of religions, descending from the modern to the archaic and culminating not in a consummate confession but in a window through which many traditions refract a single light. And it traced the series' passage through the four archipelagoes of Western island fiction—castaway, utopian, illusionist, and afterlife—showing that the series refuses, at each, the exit by which that archipelago had released its islanders: return, method, unmasking, and the revelation that the living were dead all along. That cumulative refusal is a narrative *via negativa*, and it clears the ground for the series' positive doctrines.

Part II developed those doctrines as a perditology, a systematic thought of lostness. Its epistemology replaces the antithesis of faith and reason with discernment, the capacity to tell a true summons from its counterfeit, which the series dramatizes in the capture of Locke's faith by the adversary and in Jack's late conversion, and which it locates, finally, in charity's use of reason—in a drowning man's warning written on his palm. Its chronosophy affirms that the past cannot be changed and denies that it is therefore lost: freedom is not the power to unmake what happened, which the series stages and refutes in the bomb of the fifth season, but the power to keep faith within it, which the series names in the title of its most celebrated episode. Its anthropology holds that the self is neither a substance, nor a bundle, nor a blank, but a promise kept across time and held by another; its negative image is the nameless smoke, the self without a constant. Its political theology traces the island's regimes from contract and exception through technocracy, theocracy, property, and charisma to custody, a sovereignty that keeps without owning, restrains without dominating, and amends its law in equity—entrusted at last to the least imperial man on the island and to the tyrant he forgave. Its theodicy is familial: evil is born in a household, from a mother's lie and a brother's rage, and the Good is chthonic—a light within the earth, shared, coveted, and vulnerable, that needs not defending but keeping. And its eschatology is an anamnesis: the end of history is neither apocalypse nor escape but a gathering in memory, in which the dead remember their one shared life, recognize one another, forgive, and go on. Its gnosis is custodial, an awakening that leads back into the world's memory rather than out of the world.

Part III turned to form, reception, and limits. It argued that the series' poetics moves from the opening of a hatch to the closing of one—from curiosity to custody—and that its seriality was a school of discernment. It read the finale's divided reception as the predictable consequence of Pascal's disproportion of orders: an audience trained as curious minds confronted a resolution whose goods, as Pascal wrote of the saints, are seen by God and the angels and not by bodies or by curious minds. And it subjected the perditology to the critique its own principles demand, showing that the series' universal charity was articulated through erasures—of

the Pacific and its peoples, of mothers, of the differences within its ensemble, of disabled bodies as they are—and that custody, constancy, and anamnesis, taken seriously, require the corrections the series failed to make.

The conjunction of these findings justifies the dissertation's central proposal: that *Lost* is a *serial Pascaliad*—a long-form serial narrative that literalizes Pascal's anthropology of the lost human being, traverses his three orders in sequence, and enacts in its form the movements of its thought. The term names a genre as well as a work. A Pascaliad is a fiction in which the questions of the *égaré*—where am I, who placed me here, what have I come to do, what will become of me in dying—are posed with full seriousness; in which the order of minds is honored, tested, and found insufficient; and in which resolution, when it comes, comes in a third order that the curious cannot see. Seriality is its natural medium, because discernment, constancy, and anamnesis are all forms of time.

The concept opens lines of inquiry that this study can only indicate. Damon Lindelof's next series, *The Leftovers* (2014–2017), created with Tom Perrotta, turns the perditology inside out: its subject is not the lost who are found but those left behind by the inexplicable departure of millions, and its finale ends not with a revelation but with a man's decision to believe a woman's account of where she has been. Michael Schur's *The Good Place* (2016–2020) ends, as *Lost* does, at a door through which its characters pass into an unseen beyond; but its final image of a wave returning to the ocean dissolves the person into the oceanic in a way the church of *Lost*, gathering persons who remain two in distinction and one in likeness, refuses. And *Battlestar Galactica* (2004–2009), which ran almost exactly alongside *Lost*, offers a cyclical eschatology—all of this has happened before and will happen again—against which the series' anamnestic eschatology can be measured. A comparative study of the serial finale as a theological form would set these works beside one another, and beside the scribes who completed the Gospel of Mark.

Pascal, after describing the islander's terror, adds a sentence that the series answers more fully than any other: "Et sur cela j'admire comment on n'entre point en désespoir d'un si misérable état"—and at this I marvel that people do not fall into despair at so wretched a condition. The castaways of *Lost* fall into despair repeatedly—in the Swan, in the flash-forwards, at the bottom of a well—and are drawn out of it, each time, by another person: a cry through a hatch, a voice on a telephone, a question asked at the bottom of a well, a palm pressed to a window, a touch in a hospital corridor. The series' reply to Pascal's wonder is that no one escapes despair alone, and that the island which seemed a place of exile becomes, through the fidelity of those who kept it and kept one another, the place where their true life was lived.

In the fragment known as *Le Mystère de Jésus*, Pascal records words he hears addressed to him in prayer: "Console-toi, tu ne me chercherais pas si tu ne m'avais trouvé" (L919/B553)—take comfort; you would not be seeking me if you had not already found me. The sentence is the perditology's last paradox and its last consolation. To be lost, in the series' theology, is already to be sought; to seek is already to have been found; and the search that occupied six

seasons, a hundred and twenty-one episodes, and an audience of millions was itself the sign of a finding that preceded it. The eye that opened in the bamboo grove closes there. Nothing is lost.

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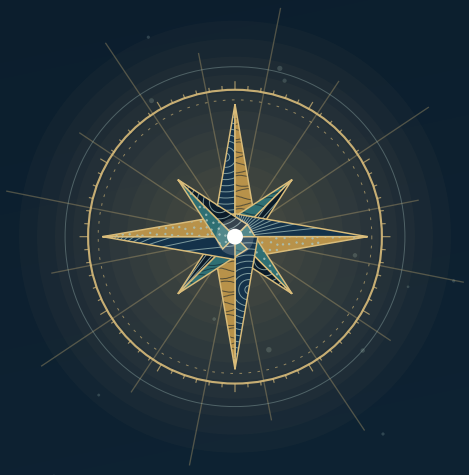
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Keywords

Lost (television series)
Damon Lindelof
J. J. Abrams
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Blaise Pascal
Pensées
three orders
Deus absconditus
serial Pascaliad
perditology
constancy
custody
anamnesis
custodial gnosis
chthonic Good
familial theodicy
discernment of spirits
Ignatius of Loyola
faith and reason
Pascal's wager
William James
W. K. Clifford
Søren Kierkegaard
Emmanuel Levinas
Paul Ricoeur
ipse identity
personal identity
John Locke
David Hume
Derek Parfit
Augustine of Hippo
distentio animi
philosophy of time
closed timelike curves
Novikov self-consistency principle
Molinism
middle knowledge
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The God of Jacob, Not of the Philosophers

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